

66th ANNUAL
General Service Conference



Our Spiritual Way of Life:
Steps, Traditions and Concepts

The 66th Annual Meeting of the
General Service Conference
of Alcoholics Anonymous

2016 FINAL REPORT | CONFIDENTIAL

The Sixty-Sixth Annual Meeting of the General Service Conference of Alcoholics Anonymous

Our Spiritual Way of Life: Steps, Traditions and Concepts

2016 *Final Report*

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Confidential—full names used

Since this report is a *confidential* A.A. document, for members only, it contains members' full names and addresses.

This usage—to facilitate communication within the Fellowship—was approved by the 1975 Conference. Such confidential use respects our Tradition of anonymity in *public* communications and with media (press, radio, TV, etc.).

66th ANNUAL General Service Conference



"Most of us here today come from our areas by election or the hat, but all of us are here today as guardians of A.A.," said Barb Colley, of West Virginia, delegate chair of the 2016 General Service Conference in her greeting to Conference members at the event's opening session. "So, as I see it," she added, "this is my challenge here, perhaps yours, also: to continue to grow through the 36 Principles, to serve A.A. as a whole, to be a guardian of A.A. and to keep my eyes wide-open, smiling and laughing, arms outstretched, open and welcoming."

Reflecting the Conference theme, "Our Spiritual Way of Life: Steps, Traditions and Concepts," Barb's address set the Conference in motion, launching a week's worth of discussion, debate and the pursuit of A.A.'s primary purpose.

Meeting from Sunday morning, April 17 to Saturday afternoon, April 23, 2016, at the Crowne Plaza Times Square Hotel in New York City, the 134 voting members constituting the 66th General Service Conference assembled from all parts of A.A.'s eight service regions across the United States and Canada. Serving as "the actual voice and the effective conscience for our whole Society" (Concept II, *The A.A. Service Manual/Twelve Concepts for World Service*), the 2016 Conference was comprised of 93 delegates, 25 members of the General Service Board of Trustees, the A.A. World Services and Grapevine Corporate Boards, and 16 members of the A.A. staff of the General Service Office, the Grapevine and La Viña.

Terry Bedient, Class A (nonalcoholic) chairperson of the General Service Board, served as Conference chair; G.S.O. general manager Greg Tobin, and Barb Colley, delegate chair, served as vice chairs; and Mary Clare Lynch served

as Conference coordinator Andrew Ware. West Central regional trustee, gave the Keynote Address, noting that unity in A.A. "is not when you agree with me, but when we hear all voices." He continued, "We *all* win when we have broad discussion, listen to the minority voice and find our collective group conscience."

As the business of the Conference got underway, two visitors from the Ukraine — Mykhailo Araslanov, past World Service Meeting delegate, and Yury Tarnavskiy — were admitted to the Conference as observers.

Sunday evening the Opening Dinner was followed by an open A.A. meeting, chaired by Michelle Pattridge, Eastern Massachusetts, chairperson of the Conference Agenda Committee; the leader was Betty Morton, Southeast Michigan. Speakers were: Drew Armstrong, Southern Wisconsin; Jennifer Kuntz, British Columbia/Yukon; Richard Boisvert, A.A.W.S. director; Ami Brophy, Grapevine executive editor/publisher; and Racy Joseph, G.S.O. staff member.

Conference week is long, often arduous, but ultimately rewarding — filled with board and committee reports, presentations and discussions, area service highlights, sharing sessions and committee meetings. The main focus of each Conference though, is on the deliberations of each of the thirteen Conference committees, and it is during the committee meetings that the major work of the Conference is done. Once again, this year, after a joint meeting with each corresponding trustees' committee, the Conference committees reviewed material and background information, weighed and discussed various issues and came up with recommendations, some of which resulted in Conference Advisory Actions.

Following two days of committee meetings and a Tuesday

afternoon trip to visit G.S.O. and Grapevine offices, the workshop session on Wednesday morning focused on the report from the trustees' Feasibility Study Subcommittee, with workshop questions developed to facilitate brainstorming among Conference members on four basic topics: improving internal and external communications; increasing revenues; reducing expenses; and structure. The report itself, presented earlier in the week by David Morris, Class A trustee and chairperson of the trustees' subcommittee, evaluated some current fiscal trends and presented a three-year budget outlook of the General Service Board and its two operating corporations, A.A.W.S., Inc. and A.A. Grapevine, Inc.

Based on the workshop discussions, the General Service Board will review the feedback gathered from Conference members and determine what ideas may be actionable, bringing them back to future General Service Conferences for consideration.

On Thursday, as the bulk of the committee reports began, a brief Conference-wide training session was conducted to facilitate electronic voting — a procedure in the second year of a two-year trial. Armed with input from last year's Conference, an outside consultant was brought in to oversee the process and after a series of practice votes — using mock questions like "Do you like coffee?" to test the system — the Conference as a whole took a vote (by hand — the old-fashioned way) to move forward electronically.

A report will be prepared as the result of the two-year experiment, and the 67th Conference will decide whether future Conferences will employ this method of tallying results.

With discussion and voting on committee agendas and floor actions finally complete, Friday evening rotating Panel 65 delegates lined up around the room and gave emotional two-minute farewells, highlighted by a tongue-in-cheek song dedicated to Panel 66 delegates and sung to the tune of "Route 66." The 2016 General Service Conference then officially closed with the Serenity Prayer, led by Lisa Part (English), Michel Bergeron (French) and Gilberto Vence (Spanish).

Rotating trustees gave their farewell talks at the closing brunch on Saturday morning: Michele Grinberg and John Fromson, Class A (nonalcoholic) trustees, and Andrew Ware, West Central regional trustee.

While the General Service Conference works year round, the annual meeting held every spring is the culmination of the year's activities, the time when the collective conscience of A.A. in the U.S./Canada emerges to take actions that will help groups and members today and in years to come. In this way, the Conference is a window to the future of the Fellowship.

Each Conference has its own flavor and focus, and as the 66th Conference began to recede, those returning members of the 67th Conference started to turn their attention toward the 2017 Conference with its theme "Supporting Our Future."

Greetings

My name is Barb Colley, delegate, Panel 65, Area 73, West "By God" Virginia. Welcome back fellow Panel 65 delegates and welcome Panel 66 delegates to your first Conference. Having answered roll call, we are now officially voting members of the 66th General Service Conference. What a privilege and honor it is to be your Conference Delegate Chair. Greetings and welcome also to the Class A and B trustees of the General Service Board, our Conference chair Terry, vice chairs Andrew and Greg, and secretary Mary Clare, directors and staff members of A.A.W.S. and Grapevine, the many support staff and other invited guests to this Conference.

Our theme this year, "Our Spiritual Way of Life: Steps, Traditions and Concepts," is very much on target. This encompasses our 36 Principles, such as honesty, love and tolerance found in the Steps, anonymity and humility in the Traditions, and vision, mutual trust and sacrifice in the



Concepts. Most of us here today come from our areas by election or the hat, but all of us are here today as guardians of A.A. Our theme gives us an opportunity to continue to grow and further our understanding of such a challenge.

My husband and I attended the 2010 International Convention in San Antonio. As we were checking out of the hotel, my husband approached the check-out line. Another hotel staff person said he would take the next person, but the fellow attending to the line said no he was almost finished and would handle the last one in line. There are no coincidences in Alcoholics Anonymous. As he was pulling up our bill, he asked, "Who are you people?" I had just walked up to the desk and as my husband was figuring out just how he was going to answer, the fellow said, "I've seen all kinds of people come and go here with baby showers, birthday parties, weddings, church groups, businesses, organizations and they all come and go with their eyes straight ahead as if they had blinders on and tunnel-vision, frowns and closed-in. You folks came in and are going out with your eyes wide-open, smiling and laughing, arms outstretched and welcoming! Who are you?"

I have experienced the latter: when I first came into the rooms of Alcoholics Anonymous; more so, as I very soon became active in general service; but, so much more so this last year and a half serving as a delegate for my area at the General Service Conference. So, as I see it, this is my challenge here, perhaps yours, also: to continue to grow through the 36 Principles, to serve A.A. as a whole, to be a guardian of A.A. and to keep my eyes wide-open, smiling and laughing, arms outstretched, open and welcoming.

Briefly, 29 years ago, I attended my first assembly. A couple of fellows were "conversing" about an issue, a bit hotly, I thought. As they broke for lunch, I said to my then significant other that I did not want any part of that! But those two fellows walked out with their arms over each other's shoulders asking where they were going for lunch. And, here I am.

I read somewhere that if I considered this experience beyond my wildest dreams, I would be selling myself short. I definitely didn't think this was in my Higher Power's plan for me. I am humbled.

Again, welcome to you all. My heart is overflowing.

Barb Colley, West Virginia

Keynote Address

Welcome to the 66th General Service Conference! I want to especially welcome all of you who are attending your first General Service Conference — all of the Panel 66 delegates, the new staff members and the new Class A trustees. I remember my first Conference and jumping right into this process. I want to thank Mary Clare and the organizers for the loving invitation to give this address. I am excited about what we have on the agenda for this week. We get to think about, discuss and make decisions on matters affecting A.A. as a whole. In this talk my aim is to help get us started along the way.

The theme of this Conference is all encompassing: "Our Spiritual Way of Life: Steps, Traditions and Concepts." It will be a challenge to cover all of the Steps, Traditions and Concepts and how they tie together in our spiritual way of life, but if you'll bear with me for the next four hours, I'll give it a go. All kidding aside, this theme underlines that the spiritual way of life is a common thread in all that we do: our personal recovery, in A.A. group activities and in general service. In A.A. we have a common ailment and a common way out through the Steps. We have a common set of Traditions for all of our groups. We have a set of Concepts that guides our general service. In all of this we are guided by spiritual principles. For me these are not mutually independent. I don't leave my program at the door when I sit down with my home group for a business meeting. I didn't stop participating in my home group business meetings when I became a trustee nor did I stop being a sponsor when I became a trustee. Applying these principles — all of them — in all that we do here at the Conference, at General Service Board meetings, at Forums, at area assemblies, at district meetings, and at our home groups is a challenge indeed. To quote from Chapter Five, "No one among us has been able to maintain anything like perfect adherence to these principles. We are not saints. The point is, that we are willing to grow along spiritual lines." If we let the Steps, Traditions and Concepts guide us this week then we as members of the Conference are willing to grow along spiritual lines.

I'd like to talk a little more about two spiritual principles: unity and tolerance. To me these two need to be closely tied together in order for A.A. to continue to thrive. Tolerance is key in keeping our unity. This is true at all levels of general service. Each area decides how many area assemblies to have, which positions will best serve the area, and how much of a financial contribution to make toward the General Service Conference. One of the pleasures I have as a regional trustee is to travel to each of the areas in my region and to attend one of their area assemblies or conferences. I enjoy seeing what each area does that is similar to other areas and what each area does that is unique to that area in how they do their business. Each district gets to decide how often to meet and what services to provide to groups in the district. Each group decides how often to meet, what type of meeting they want to hold and how the group wants to split its contributions — or even if it wants to make contributions — to its area, its district, its intergroup and the General Service Board. Recently some A.A. members in Montana started a 1728 Group in which every month they will discuss a Step the first week, a Tradition the second, a Concept the third and then discuss how these are related in the fourth week. I have no idea what they are planning on doing in months where they have a fifth meeting. Nor do I know if this will work out or if this will be too distracting from carrying the message to newcomers. I do applaud them, however, for trying something new and I look forward to hearing how that format works for them.

Where does tolerance come into play? In tolerating other A.A. groups, districts, areas and so on to operate as they see fit and not to denounce them as "not A.A." if they are not operating as we do. It is certainly incumbent upon us to discuss the Traditions and Concepts, and the vitally important role they play in our Fellowship and in our general service structure. It is important for me to embrace the fact that there are groups in my district that have more structure than my home group as well as ones that have less. It is important for all of us to welcome newcomers to our meetings, to share our experience with them and then let them figure out where they belong. "Love and tolerance of others is our code."

How does the theme apply to our week ahead? I'm reminded of a joke once told by a staff member at a prior General Service Conference. He said that one way to win an argument at the General Service Conference is to say, "Instead of what you suggested, why don't we try a spiritual solution." So let us apply our spiritual way of life in all that we do this weekend. Let's have broad discussion on the agenda items and workshop topics, listening to the minority voice and keeping our minds open. At our regional service conference when discussing agenda items we ask those in attendance not to applaud after someone expresses an opinion that you agree with. It is a natural tendency to want to show your approval by clapping when someone says something you support, but we ask for no applause so that someone with a minority opinion might be more willing to express it. We all win when we have broad discussion, listen to the minority voice and find our collective group conscience.

Some of the things we will be discussing this weekend have to do with strategic planning. Is it possible for an organization with an upside down triangle structure to do strategic planning? Can we do effective strategic planning? I believe the answer is yes, we can. I know that we have had stumbles in our process as we have tried strategic planning over the years. As in all that we do, even when we stumble, we rely on spiritual principles to guide us as we try again. One of the things we will all need is vision. As Bill wrote in his essay on leadership, "Now comes that all-important attribute of vision. Vision is, I think, the abil-

ity to make good estimates, both for the immediate and for the more distant future." I think it is appropriate for the General Service Board to examine

where we are now, to determine what trends seem to be happening, to consider where we want to be in the future, and to decide what steps are likely to get us there. Furthermore, I think it is appropriate for every member of the Conference to do this and to examine and question all the work of the General Service Board. In looking at the big picture, we have to ask about any possible action, not only "Does this help us reach out to the still-suffering alcoholic?" and "Does this follow within our Traditions?" but also,

"If we do this action will it prevent us from doing a more effective action?" and "Does this action help us reach our larger goals?"

Changing topics, I'd like to discuss the Conference Inventory Report. Over the last three years this Conference has applied one of our spiritual principles and taken its own inventory. It has been a treat to see us go through that process and participate in it over a number of different panels. In his keynote address as we started this inventory process three years ago George M. said, "We are not here to take pride in doing the responsible thing by taking an inventory. We are here to help assure the unity and effectiveness of A.A. in its mission to carry the great message of hope to anyone, anywhere, who has a desire to do something about his or her drinking problem." Now that we have finished the inventory process and have a final report we need to look and see if there are changes we need to make in order to assure the unity and effectiveness of A.A. This process of going through the Inventory Report and suggesting General Service Conference agenda items is open to all of the Fellowship. I know we have already seen some suggestions come out of the inventory process but I don't think we are done by any means.

In closing, I want to thank all of you for listening today. It has been a privilege for me to take part in a number of General Service Conferences. I look forward to working with all of you this week as we, the members of the 66th General Service Conference, act as the group conscience for A.A. as a whole.

Andrew Ware, West Central regional trustee



■ Advisory Actions

Conference Advisory Actions represent recommendations made by the standing committees and approved by the Conference body as a whole or recommendations discussed and voted on by all Conference members during general sessions. The group conscience of the Fellowship in the United States and Canada was expressed in the following Advisory Actions, which the General Service Board accepted in its legally required annual meeting following the 2016 Conference.

FLOOR ACTIONS

It was recommended that:

- 1 General Service Conference delegates be provided a copy of the final approved annual General Service Office and A.A. Grapevine budgets with the pre-Conference material for all future Conferences.
- 2 The General Service Board develop a new policy and a plan that enhances the General Service Conference Agenda Review and Selection Process, providing the area delegate members of the Conference a role in the vetting and selection of proposed agenda items through the Conference process to be brought to the 2017 General Service Conference.
- 3 The trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference create a plan to translate Conference background material, considering all possible methods, with a progress report to be forwarded to the 2017 Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions that describes the process and costs.

AGENDA

It was recommended that:

- 4 The theme for the 2017 General Service Conference be: "Supporting Our Future."
- 5 The following be presentation/discussion topics for the 2017 General Service Conference:
 - a. Growth:
 1. Diversity — Outreach and Attraction
 2. Safety — An Important Consideration
 3. Communication — Today and Tomorrow
 - b. Participation:
 1. Fellowship vs. Membership
 2. Leadership: "I am Responsible..."
 3. Is Your Voice Heard?
 - c. Contributions:
 1. Spirituality and Money
 2. Fully Self-Supporting Our Obligations
 3. Apathy and Power of the Purse
- 6 The Conference Agenda Committee review the summary of the previous year's Conference evaluations and, where appropriate, make suggestions for improvement to the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference.
- 7 The General Service Office post to the Conference

dashboard, and regularly update information concerning the status of all proposed Conference agenda items.

ARCHIVES¹

No recommendations.

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

It was recommended that:

- 8 A new section on A.A. and medications be added to the pamphlet "If You are a Professional..." with the following text:

A.A. Members and Medications

A.A. does not provide medical advice; all medical advice and treatment should come from a qualified health care professional. The suggestions provided in the pamphlet "The A.A. Member—Medications and Other Drugs" may help A.A. members minimize the risk of relapse.
- 9 Text be added to the last paragraph of the first page of the pamphlet "Is There an Alcoholic in the Workplace?" to read (additions in bold):

A.A. can help organizations, **corporations and businesses, regardless of size**, contact men and women who have achieved sobriety, and are willing to share their experience freely with anyone who seeks help
- 10 Several minor revisions to the pamphlet "How A.A. Members Cooperate With Professionals" be approved.
- 11 An introductory paragraph for professionals be added to the pamphlet "Problems Other Than Alcohol" addressing the notion that while some language in the 1958 pamphlet is dated, the issues are prevalent today, and asked that a draft introductory paragraph be brought back to the 2017 Conference Cooperation With the Professional Community Committee for review.

CORRECTIONS

It was recommended that:

- 12 The video to replace "It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell" with the title "A New Freedom" be approved.

FINANCE

No recommendations.

GRAPEVINE

It was recommended that:

- 13 The delegate chair for the Grapevine Conference Committee be allowed the same participation at the January A.A. Grapevine Board Meeting as all other delegate chairs at their corresponding trustees' committees.

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/ REGIONAL FORUMS¹

No recommendations.

¹Members of this committee serve on this as a secondary committee assignment.

LITERATURE

It was recommended that:

- 14 The trustees' Literature Committee develop a plan that includes a systematic schedule for the annual review of recovery literature items, taking into consideration the following: content, relevance, and usefulness; and prioritized by time span since last review. The committee requested that the plan also include an annual report, to be forwarded to the Conference Literature Committee, reflecting the results of their review and any other items for proposed updates or revisions.
- 15 The trustees' Literature Committee revise the pamphlet "Young People and A.A." to include information about young people's conferences and that the proposed text be brought to the 2017 Conference Literature Committee for review.
- 16 The trustees' Literature Committee update the pamphlet "Young People and A.A." to better reflect the experiences of young people in A.A. today. The committee requested that a progress report or draft pamphlet be brought to the 2017 Conference Literature Committee.
- 17 The trustees' Literature Committee undertake a comprehensive revision of the pamphlet "The Twelve Traditions Illustrated" with a modernized presentation of both text and illustrations to reflect contemporary A.A. experience. The committee requested that a progress report or draft pamphlet be brought to the 2017 Conference Literature Committee.

POLICY/ADMISSIONS

It was recommended that:

- 18 Mykhailo Araslanov, past World Service Meeting delegate, and Yury Tarnavskiy from Ukraine be admitted to the 66th General Service Conference as observers.
- 19 Implementation of Phase 1 of the Conference Translation Project to translate pre-Conference and Conference material into Spanish and French, as described in the 2015 Advisory Action, continue with an estimated cost of \$50,000 – \$100,000.

- 20 The 69th General Service Conference be held April 28-May 4, 2019 since these dates do not conflict with any significant holiday or hotel availability.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

It was recommended that:

- 21 A proposal for implementing a Google-for-Non-Profits account for carrying the message of A.A. to the public be developed and brought back to the 2017 Conference Public Information Committee for review.
- 22 A proposal for the implementation of a Twitter account for carrying the message of A.A. to the public be developed and brought back to the 2017 Conference Public Information Committee for review.
- 23 The English- and French-language versions of the video public service announcement "Tengo Esperanza," be centrally distributed, tracked and evaluated at a cost not to exceed \$40,000, in addition to distribution by local committees, and that the information gathered from the process be forwarded to the 2017 Conference Public Information Committee for their review.
- 24 The video public service announcement "I Thought" be discontinued.

REPORT AND CHARTER

It was recommended that:

- 25 A new section on "Local Forums" be added to Chapter 9 (The General Service Board) of *The A.A. Service Manual*, after the "Regional Forums" section with the following text:

LOCAL FORUMS

In October 2006, the concept of Local Forums was approved by the General Service Board. The purpose of Local Forums is to bring Forum information to A.A. members in remote, sparsely populated areas, urban neighborhoods or underserved A.A. communities. Any A.A. community or service entity may request a one-and-a-half or two day Local Forum. Unlike Regional Forums, the responsibility



for Forum expenses such as meeting room rental and miscellaneous expenses are assumed by the Local Forum Committee. The General Service Board will send two participants, one from the Board and one from the General Service Office or Grapevine office, and display literature at Board expense. Like Regional Forums, Board participation in Local Forums requires the approval of the trustees' Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums. The Regional Forums coordinator works closely with the Local Forum organizing committee to create an agenda that is responsive to local needs.

- 26 The following text in endnote 4 be removed from Concept XII on page 73 of the *Twelve Concepts for World Service*:

4. Bill here, apparently inadvertently, used the phrase "in action and spirit," instead of "in thought and action," that appears elsewhere in both the Conference Charter and the statement of Concept XII.

- 27 The following text be removed from the Concept XI essay on page 58 of *Twelve Concepts for World Service*:

Women workers present still another problem. Our Headquarters is pretty much a man's world. Some men are apt to feel, unconsciously, that they are women's superiors, thus producing a reflex reaction in the gals. Then, too, some of us — of both sexes — have been emotionally damaged in the area of man-woman relations. Our drinking has made us wrongly dependent on our marriage partners. We have turned them into our "moms" and "pops," and then we have deeply resented that situation. Perhaps maladjustment has taken still other turns which leave us with a hangover of hostility that we are apt to project into any man-woman relatedness that we undertake.

It is possible for these forces to defeat the good working partnerships we would like to have. But if we are fully aware of these tendencies they can be the more easily overcome, and forgiven. We can be aware also that any sound working relation between adult men and women must be in the character of a partnership, a non-competitive one in which each partner complements the other. It is not a question of superiority or inferiority at all. Men, for example, because they are men, are apt to be better at business. But suppose we replaced our six women staff members with six men? In these positions could the men possibly relate themselves so uniquely and so effectively to our Fellowship as the women? Of course not. The women can handle this assignment far better, just because they are women.¹⁰

- 28 Endnote 10, on page 59 in *Twelve Concepts for World Service* in the Concept XI essay be revised by the Publishing Department with language noting that two

paragraphs have been removed from the Concept XI essay and are available upon request from the G.S.O. Archives Department as a reference to A.A. history.

- 29 The A.A. Service Manual be revised per existing schedule after the 2016 General Service Conference and that a new edition be published biannually (i.e., every two years), beginning in 2017 at a savings of approximately \$45,000–\$50,000 in alternate years when a new edition is not published. The next edition of *The A.A. Service Manual* is to be published in 2018 (after the Conference), the subsequent edition in 2020 (after the Conference), etc.
- 30 The category title "Online Meetings" be changed to "Online Meetings/Online Groups" on page vi and vii in the A.A. Directories.

TREATMENT FACILITIES/ SPECIAL NEEDS/ACCESSIBILITIES

It was recommended that:

- 31 The term "Special Needs" be removed from the name of the Conference Committee on Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities and throughout the committee's Composition, Scope and Procedure. The new name of the committee will be the Conference Committee on Treatment and Accessibilities.

TRUSTEES

It was recommended that:

- 32 The following slate of trustees be elected at the annual meeting of the members of the General Service Board in April 2016, following presentation at the 2016 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

Class A

Leslie S. Backus, B.A.	Peter Luongo, Ph.D., LCSW-C
Terrance M. Bedient, FACHE	Nancy J. McCarthy
Hon Christine Carpenter	David M. Morris, C.P.A.
Hon Ivan L.R. Lemelle	

Class B

Thomas Ardolf	Scott Huyghebaert
Richard Boisvert	William Noonan
Carole Boerner	Chet Parker
Joel Castellaw	Richard Purtell
Joe Downey	Bob Wilcox
Bill Farnsworth	Cate Wittig
Yolanda Flores	Albin Zezula

- 33 The appointment of the following slate of officers of the General Service Board be approved at the annual meeting of the members of the General Service Board in April 2016, following presentation at the 2016 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

<i>Chairperson</i>	Terrance M. Bedient, FACHE
<i>First vice-chairperson</i>	Bob Wilcox
<i>Second vice-chairperson</i>	Chet Parker
<i>Treasurer</i>	David M. Morris, C.P.A.
<i>Secretary</i>	Bill Farnsworth

- 34 The February 2016 appointment of the following officers by the chair of the General Service Board be approved at the annual meeting of the members of the General Service Board in April 2016:

<i>Assistant treasurer</i>	Donald W. Meurer
<i>Assistant secretary</i>	Eva Sanchez

This appointment process is in accordance with the General Service Board Bylaws.

- 35 The following slate of directors be elected at the annual meeting of the members of the A.A. World Services Corporate Board in April 2016, following presentation at the 2016 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

Richard Boisvert	William Noonan
Beau Bush	Richard Purtell
Joe Downey	Eva Sanchez
Homer Moeller	Greg Tobin
David Noll	

- 36 The following slate of directors be elected at the annual meeting of the members of the A.A. Grapevine Corporate Board in April 2016, following presentation

at the 2016 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

Lynda Bergeron	Yolanda Flores
Carole Boerner	Ivan Lemelle
Ami Brophy	Paz Preciado
Joel Castellaw	Albin Zezula
Josh Eggleston	

- 37 If a vacancy for a regional trustee occurs prior to September 1 in the first year, then an election for a three-year term would occur at the following General Service Conference (GSC) for the affected region. If a vacancy for a regional trustee occurs between September 1 in the first year and August 31 of the third year then the delegates from the affected region would be given an option to hold an election for a six-year or five-year term, or leave the position vacant, depending on when the vacancy occurs. Regardless of whether the term was for three, five or six years, the regional trustee would be expected to serve two years on one of the two operating corporation boards.



■ Presentations and Reports

FINANCE REPORT

The Finance report, which is summarized here, was given on Sunday afternoon by David Morris, treasurer of the General Service Board and chairperson of the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee. The full report, accompanying slides, and detailed appendix are not included in this publication, but are available upon request. For more details on A.A. finances, please see the financial section of this Report, as well as the trustees' Finance and Budgetary report. A subsequent question and sharing session on the report took place Monday afternoon.

Good afternoon. My name is David Morris and I am a Class A trustee and treasurer of the General Service Board. It is again my privilege to deliver the Treasurer's report to the 66th General Service Conference of Alcoholics Anonymous or, as it is more commonly referred to, "Finance around the Picnic Table," the phrase coined at the 59th Conference.

This phrase means that much of the finance discussion during Conference is "preaching to the choir." As always, what we need is better communication about what finance really means when members talk about "the numbers" around the euphemistic picnic table before and after meetings. Clear and concise communication is the key. Although our finances continue to grow much more complex, remember that Corporate Poverty is more a state of mind, rather than the size of our bank account. "Too much — and we argue over perilous wealth and lose sight of our primary purpose of carrying the message. Too little — and we risk losing the ability to carry the message at all."

Our goal is to help you become familiar with A.A.'s financial position so that you can communicate clearly to your areas. Enhancing your understanding of our finances is one way to improve the service structure.

Through this presentation, we will review the Fellowship's Seventh Tradition self-support efforts; the services provid-

ed to the Fellowship by the General Service Office; the publishing activities of A.A. World Services, A.A. Grapevine and La Viña; the 80th International Convention; the Pension and Retiree Medical Plans; and the Reserve Fund. We will also discuss 2015 actual results compared to 2014 actual results, 2015 actual results compared to 2015 budget, take a look at the 2016 budgets, and discuss projections for 2017 and beyond.

Self-support: In terms of self-support, a 20-year history shows generally increasing Seventh Tradition contributions from 1996 through 2015, with the current year being \$7,154,146. However, there has been little growth over the last several years. Additionally, of the 65,741 total groups listed in the U.S. and Canada, only 40.3% (26,500 groups) contributed in 2015. This compares to 41.6% (27,103 groups) that contributed in 2014, out of 65,222 total groups.

The A.A.W.S. Finance Subcommittee on Self-Support continues to work diligently toward a goal of developing sustainable self-support initiatives. With the ever-present possibility that print sales might decline in the future, it is vital that the Fellowship fully embrace the Seventh Tradition. Delegates, other trusted servants and G.S.O. staff have offered many creative and practical ways to communicate the message of the need for self-support, and we are grateful for everyone's participation. Popular efforts have included the increased discussion of our November Gratitude Month, as well as increasing the focus on Birthday Envelopes. The answer to self-support may very well be in sustained communication — and it is here where we continue to need your help and suggestions.

Inflation, also, has had an impact when it comes to self-support, as it has diminished the value or purchasing power of one dollar since the very first days of A.A. through today. Statistics show that \$1.00 in 1935 is equivalent to \$13.00 today, regardless of what that 1935 dollar was spent on, whether it went for alcohol, coffee or was put into the Seventh Tradition self-support basket.



Services: When it comes to the services provided to the Fellowship and their related costs, \$9,629,499 was expended in 2015, covering the following service activities at G.S.O. group services, public information, cooperation with the professional community, treatment facilities, corrections, overseas services (literature assistance), archives, General Service Conference.

Regional Forums, World Service Meeting, International Convention, trustees' and directors' activities, and supporting services, which include the direct costs of administration, finance, human resources, information technology, rent, and all other indirect overhead.

When these 2015 costs of \$9,629,499 are matched up with the 2015 Seventh Tradition contributions of \$7,154,146, there is

a resulting shortfall of \$2,475,353

This short-

fall is covered by an excess of publishing profits.

Publishing: For the 2016 A.A.W.S. budget, publishing results are projected to be slightly improved over 2015 due to higher unit sales. When this 2016 publishing profit is combined with the 2016 cost of services provided to the Fellowship, a small net loss of \$26,700 is projected to occur. However, assuming that there are no changes in the way business is conducted or Seventh Tradition self-support contributions do not radically increase, this 2016 loss is projected to grow to a net loss of \$505,000 in 2017 and a net loss of \$997,000 in 2018 because of the inflationary impacts on operating expenses.

The results for Grapevine also show downward trends in terms of circulation and income, and projections for 2017 and 2018 show losses of \$190,700 and \$275,500 respectively. In 2015, the shortfall between revenue and expenses for La Viña was \$146,378, which continues to be made up through a transfer from the General Service Board's General Fund. Losses for La Viña are projected at \$152,600 for 2016, \$166,100 in 2017, and \$175,300 in 2018.

International Convention: Turning to the International Convention held in Atlanta in July 2015, while there was a record number of 56,900 attendees, generating revenues of \$5,929,138, the costs of hosting the event were \$6,139,569, resulting in a loss of \$210,431 or 3.4% of revenues. There were three principal reasons for the loss: 1) increased security concerns in today's terrorism-prone world; 2) an approximately 300% increase over budget in the number of attendees with either special needs or those over 65 who had mobility issues; and 3) more

attendees meant more transportation costs.

To address a conceptual matter raised by some that the International Convention is a fixed cost event and that all attendance above a certain level should be pure incremental revenue and profit, as we have tried to show, an event of this size and scope is one of variable revenues and costs. There are incremental costs for each new attendee because as the number of attendees dramatically increases, everything else changes. The more people that attend, the more the cost of security, the more the cost of busing and the more the cost for special needs requirements.

Historically, the results of the 13 International Conventions held since the first in St. Louis in 1955, show a net profit of \$1,349,944.

Pension and Retiree Medical Plans: In 1965, A.A. established a traditional Defined Benefit Pension Program for its employees. This plan will continue to exist until the last eligible employee who is covered retires and then eventually passes away in 40 to 50 years. However, to cap this exposure, A.A. transitioned from a Defined Benefit Plan to a Defined Contribution Plan for all new A.A.W.S. and Grapevine employees hired subsequent to January 1, 2013. Over the

very long-term, this change will cap the pension plan obligations and reduce ongoing costs. Defined benefit pension costs are funded out of A.A.W.S. and Grapevine current operations and now account for about 9% of operating expenses, down from 12% in 2013.

Reserve Fund: The Reserve Fund Ratio is defined as the number of months that the Reserve Fund could cover the operating expenses of the two operating entities. At December 31, 2015, the ratio is 10.2 months. Looking at budget trends for the next three years, 2016 shows a combined operating loss of \$325,600, increasing to \$861,800 in 2017 and \$1,447,800 in 2018. Since the Reserve Fund will need to be utilized to fund these losses in 2017 and 2018, the coverage ratio declines to 7.0 months by the end of 2018.

In conclusion, I want to acknowledge the extraordinary talent and dedication that I am privileged to observe as treasurer. Thank you to the members of all of the finance committees, especially those of both operating entities, who work through enormous amounts of materials throughout the year. Thank you to Greg Tobin and Ami Brophy for competently overseeing our operating entities. And a very special thank you to Don Meurer and our talented and dedicated A.A.W.S. and Grapevine finance teams. A special thank you also goes out to Phyllis Halliday and Eugene O'Brien, both of whom retired during 2015. Finally, a special thanks to our Independent Auditors, who do an extraordinary job, always exhibiting professionalism and independence.

And remember, Finance has no importance in and of itself. Finance is simply a way to help carry the message to the still-suffering alcoholic.

David Morris, treasurer, General Service Board



REPORT ON FEASIBILITY STUDY

On Monday afternoon, David Morris presented the report from the Feasibility Study Subcommittee, summarized below. Questions and sharing on the report followed.

My name is David Morris and I am a Class A trustee and chairman of the Feasibility Study Subcommittee. Over the next few minutes, I am going to expand upon the Report from the Subcommittee on Feasibility Study by providing additional background as to what the Feasibility Study Subcommittee is, why it was formed and what we are seeking from you, the Delegates of the 66th General Service Conference.

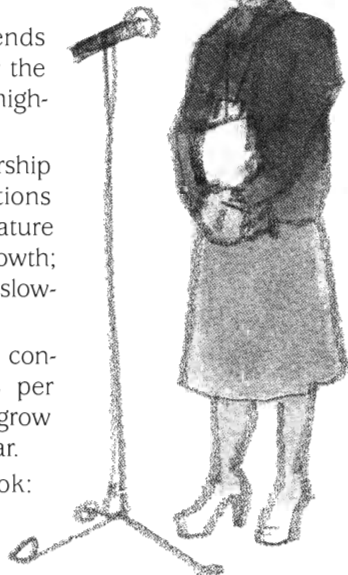
By way of background, during the July 2014 trustees' Finance and Budgetary committee meeting, there was a request to add to the November 2014 Finance agenda a new item entitled, "Strategic Initiative on Structure." Several trustees had noted various negative trends, the natural extension of which would mean that A.A. will be facing a very challenging future. They felt that we should all collectively begin to study these trends and their implications. For A.A.W.S., membership, contributions and literature sales are showing little growth. Expenses continue to increase slowly. For Grapevine, magazine circulation continues to decline and expenses are slowly increasing.

Discussion of these trends ultimately evolved into the motion that: "The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous undertake a comprehensive study of the current business models, corporate structure and long-term sustainability of the General Service Board and both operating Corporations, keeping in mind the spiritual basis of Alcoholics Anonymous."

The topic of the Feasibility Study was introduced to the 65th General Service Conference in the 2015 Finance Presentation, and at the January 2016 General Service Board meeting, it was agreed that the report from the Subcommittee on Feasibility Study should be forwarded to the 66th General Service Conference for consideration and input.

Evaluating current trends and the budget outlook for the next three years, the study highlighted the following:

- G.S.O./A.A.W.S.: membership levels are flat; contributions show little growth; literature sales show slow to no growth; expenses continue to grow slowly — 2% – 3% per year.
- Grapevine: subscriptions continue to decline 2% – 3% per year; expenses continue to grow slowly — 2% – 3% per year.
- 2016 Budget Outlook:



G.S.O./A.A.W.S., Grapevine, and La Viña combined budgeted result is a \$325,600 loss, with following years having even larger losses, assuming no changes in operations.

To facilitate presentation, workshop topics were developed for the 66th General Service Conference to provide the opportunity for brainstorming on four basic topics: improving internal and external communications; increasing revenues; reducing expenses; and structure. Based on these discussions, the General Service Board will review the feedback and determine what ideas may be actionable and bring them back to future General Service Conferences for consideration.

David Morris, treasurer, General Service Board

CONNECTING WITH THE NEWCOMER

Sunday afternoon the presentation/discussion session was chaired by John Fromson, Class A trustee.

All Inclusive — Never Exclusive

One of our finest spiritual practices in A.A. is holding out our hands and welcoming the suffering newcomer. Perhaps for the first time, after a long drought of loneliness and isolation, the alcoholic new to A.A. feels the inclusion — the connection — that we offer.

The first part of Tradition Three (Long Form) states: "Our membership ought to include all who suffer from alcoholism. Hence we may refuse none who wish to recover." We are a big tent: we include everyone who asks for help with their drinking problem. Our spiritual program teaches us to overcome the natural human tendency to judge and exclude a person who may be homeless, unkempt, sharing unpopular opinions, or exhibiting "attitude." Any alcoholic — regardless of lifestyle, profession, race, religious or political beliefs — is welcome. The Big Book says: "We are people who normally would not mix. But there exists among us a fellowship, a friendliness, and an understanding which is indescribably wonderful." (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. 17)

And this from the A.A. Grapevine: "Every day, hopeless alcoholics walk into A.A. meetings, grab onto hope, and begin a renewal of their spirit." ("A Candle of Hope," Grapevine, April 1991)

As with many of us, when I first encountered A.A., I remember the desperation, the self-loathing, the wall of separation I felt when first entering the rooms. Prior to A.A., after many unsuccessful attempts to



overcome my alcohol affliction, I realized that Alcoholics Anonymous was probably the “last house on the block” for me. The fear of possible failure to connect with A.A. was terrifying — I would not find recovery. The relief at feeling accepted and belonging to this Fellowship gave me the hope and courage to enter this new spiritual way of life. My Higher Power reminds me of these memories when I meet a newcomer, so that I can pass on the welcome and the compassion that I received when I was new.

A.A. history tells us about the growing pains of our Fellowship. Membership rules were fashioned by early members fearful of negative impacts on our society. Ultimately, these regulations were abandoned. In the words of Bill W.: “...we would neither punish nor deprive any A.A. of membership ...to take away any alcoholic’s full chance was sometimes to pronounce his death sentence, and often to condemn him to endless misery. Who dared to be judge, jury, and executioner of his own sick brother?” (*Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*, p. 141)

In “Who Is a Member of Alcoholics Anonymous?” Bill talks about the irony of “worthy” alcoholics judging the “less worthy”: “Imagine, if you can, one alcoholic judging another!” (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 37) He also states: “We wish to be just as inclusive as we can, never exclusive.” (*Ibid*, p. 39)

As an A.A. member, it is vital for me to grow in the spiritual practice of connecting with and including the newcomer. Because I can become distracted and not always do this, I find that questions posed by the Traditions Checklist from the A.A. Grapevine can help to keep me on track. Here are a few:

- “In my mind, do I prejudge some new A.A. members as losers?”
- “Is there some kind of alcoholic whom I privately do not want in my A.A. group?”
- “Do I set myself up as a judge of whether a newcomer is sincere or phony?”

We are grateful for all that A.A. has given us. In gratitude, we extend our love and caring to the newcomer.

Marge Del Carlo, Eastern Missouri

Are We Doing Enough to Help the Newcomer — Are We Going to Any Length?

Before I begin, I would like to thank our conference coordinator for the loving invitation to give this talk. It’s always an honor to be invited to participate in A.A., and it’s a special honor indeed to briefly share on this topic with my Conference peers.

In preparing for this talk on Connecting with the Newcomer, I thought of something my sponsor told me years ago. He said, “You’re not Humpty Dumpty and this isn’t Alice in Wonderland. Words mean what they mean, not what you think they mean or what you want them to mean.” So I got out that other big book — the dictionary

— and I looked up the word “connect.” Its definition is “to have or establish a rapport,” and rapport is defined as “a friendly relationship.” So, how then do we have or establish a friendly relationship with the newcomer to Alcoholics Anonymous? Or to look at it in a different way, what do we do that sometimes gets in the way of that friendly relationship?

Perhaps the most important spiritual principle to keep in mind in connecting with the newcomer is our code: love and tolerance of others. If we’re keeping with this code, we should be loving and tolerant toward all, not just those who behave the way we want them to. Newcomers are notoriously reluctant to take direction, or at least I was (and sometimes still am). I think it is human nature to prefer to be led rather than pushed.

Of course, there are limits to just how permissive we ought to be. I’m not suggesting we accept unacceptable behavior or we compromise our other principles. Like so many other things on the path of spiritual growth, this may be a place where balance is better than the all or nothing approach that seems to come so naturally to us. I think it’s true what they told me when I was new, that A.A. was doing just fine before I got here and the group wasn’t going to bend to my wishes. But they didn’t say it in a way that was smug, sarcastic, or superior; they were kind and matter-of-fact about it. Kindness is so important in all our A.A. affairs; like my mother used to say, “It’s not what you say, but how you say it.” When I was new, I don’t know how much I remembered of what people said, but the kindness of strangers always made (and still makes) an impression on me. I’m not sure where folks get the idea that it’s okay to be impolite to others in the name of “rigorous honesty.” There is always a way to speak the truth in a way that’s patient, tolerant, kind, and loving.

And speaking of patience, tolerance, kindliness, and love: is all that supposed to fly out the window when someone mentions drugs in an A.A. meeting? I am as much a believer in Tradition Five as the next guy, but is it necessary to be downright rude about it? One of our rotating Class A trustees suggested, in her farewell talk last year, that rigidity about singleness of purpose was one reason why our membership is flat; not singleness of purpose itself, but the rigidity with which we apply it. I am puzzled by a phenomenon I see in our great Fellowship, which manifests itself in a number of ways: that which we chastise in the individual, we often embrace as a society. We tell our pigeons that they should not be “terminally unique” but then we talk as though we alcoholics are so very different than the rest of human nature; we have any number of expressions for people who aren’t A.A. members (“Earth people,” “normies,” etc.).

Another way the phenomenon manifests itself is in individual self-centered fear, which we agree is not okay, versus our collective self-centered fear that drugs will “ruin A.A.” and the behavior driven by that collective

fear. In my experience, a better approach is to explain to the nonalcoholic coming to us in hopes of solving some problem other than alcoholism — whether that problem be drugs, gambling, sex, etc. — how important identification is, and that we may be doing the nonalcoholic more harm than good by giving them the impression that A.A. has a solution to that other problem. Just like in other facets of my life, miraculous results often come when I ask God to shift my perception from thinking about me to thinking about you.

Now about this well-intentioned but misguided idea that the newcomer is somehow the most important person in the room. Nonsense. By definition, a “most” important person means there are at least three levels of importance: the most, the least, and however many in between. If there were two levels of importance, then we’d have more important and less important people. But we do not have levels of importance in A.A.; what we have is just plain ol’ A.A. members. Tradition One suggests our common welfare comes first, and everyone is important whether they’re thirty days sober, thirty years sober, or somewhere in between.

Finally, I think the most important thing we can do in A.A. (see what I did there?) is to remember that the main thing is to keep the main thing the main thing. The main purpose of the book that gave our Fellowship its name is to show other alcoholics precisely how we have recovered. There is no greater task in Alcoholics Anonymous, nor is there any higher calling than carrying that main purpose into our meetings and our interactions with one another. The spiritual principles embodied in our Twelve Steps, as laid out in the Big Book, have given me a life that is second to none. I have a new Employer who provides what I need, if I keep close to Him and perform His work well. I can think of no better way to have or establish a friendly relationship with newcomers to Alcoholics Anonymous than by freely sharing this gift with them, and showing them that they too may find a new Employer.

Tom Misteli, Northeast Texas

Home Group — Where It Begins

It is my honor to present on the topic “Home Group — Where It Begins.” Thank you for the loving invitation to participate with all of you today. I have a wonderful home group and I hope you do, too.

At the beginning of the year I was reading in my *Daily Reflections* and I came across this entry for January 2nd entitled, “First, the Foundation”: “Practicing the A.A. program is like building a house. First I had to pour a big, thick concrete slab on which to erect the house ... The first room was rickety because I wasn’t used to the work. But as time passed, as I practiced the program, I learned to build better rooms. The more I practiced, and the more I built, the more comfortable, and happy, was the home I now have to live in.”

This writer was talking about working on his own recovery, but I think it applies to how we as newcomers use our home groups as well. A solid foundation with solid materials makes a solid home group — and that’s “Where It Begins.”

I spent some time in Haiti after the earthquake of 2010. While there, I got to witness what a house built on an unstable foundation with *rickety* materials can look like. There was rubble and destruction everywhere. I had the privilege of attending the only A.A. meeting being held in this country of 10 million people. It is associated with a treatment facility run by a non-profit organization in the city of Port au Prince, population 3 million. At the first meeting I attended, a member there was reading the words of our basic text in Haitian Creole from a typewritten plastic spiral bound workbook. He told me of their hopes to have “New York” publish the book in Creole, the language of the people there. At my second meeting, I met a man from New York who had returned to Haiti and was trying to get sober (a newcomer). He spoke and read English and Creole, but not French, which was the language of the Big Books that they had at the meeting. I gave him my English pocket version. These experiences have inspired me to champion for translation of the Big Book into Haitian Creole. It seems to me that appropriate literature facilitates more and better meetings — in Haiti, the U.S., Canada, and around the globe. A home group that doesn’t have a proper foundation (suitable literature in the language of the people) has a difficult time not crumbling like a rickety house in an earthquake.

We can embrace the fact that there are many types of home groups to belong to. We have “decorated” the rooms in our houses in different ways:

“Each group is as unique as a thumbprint, and approaches to carrying the message of sobriety vary not just from group to group but from region to region. Acting autonomously, each group charts its own course. The better informed the members, the stronger and more cohesive the group — and the greater the assurance that when a newcomer reaches out for help, the hand of A.A. always will be there.” (“The A.A. Group,” p. 11)

I’ve belonged to the same home group since I got sober. My first long-term sponsor was a past delegate. And I really had no idea what that meant. She was kind, gentle, and service oriented. She played a pivotal role in starting our group.

I’ll read you our group’s mission statement: “Our primary purpose is to stay sober and carry A.A.’s message of recovery from alcoholism in a structured manner through the use of: our basic text, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, and all Conference-approved literature, sponsorship, and an active home group...” I told you they were awesome.

I didn’t know there was any other way to do this deal. How lucky am I? When this lovely woman passed away in 2008, our group lost a great A.A. member. It seems as though our home groups can start as a safe dwelling



place, but then they become a life-affirming model of proper behavior with many rooms to maintain. We learn how to be other-centered rather than self-centered. I learned how to pour coffee for others at a work meeting by pouring coffee for others at an A.A. meeting. One of my home group members tells the story of reconciliation with his estranged brother after stacking chairs at his niece's wedding; something he learned to do in A.A.

So what does this mean to us today at this 66th General Service Conference?

From the pamphlet, "Inside A.A." (#6): "The local group is the basic unit of A.A. world service. Group needs, group attitudes, and group support determine the type and amount of service G.S.O. can render." The group and group member are at the very top of our upside down service triangle. Their support gets me here, and my support keeps them here. Our efforts this week are for them.

I look around today and I humbly stand here amongst the New York City skyscrapers. They were built on bedrock with high quality materials, a symbol of our Fellowship's foundation, heritage, and tradition. Since 1951, here at this Conference, I am convinced that experience and practice have built a comfortable and happy home that we all get to live in.

Libbie Lapp, Montana

CONNECTING WITH EACH OTHER

Monday evening the presentation/discussion session was chaired by Michele Grinberg, Class A trustee.

Singleness of Purpose — Staying Pertinent in a Changing World

Hello, fellow servants. It is with great joy and much grat-

itude that I dare speak to you. I hope my address will reflect what A.A. has given me, and what the Fellowship represents for me to this day.

My first contact with A.A. — which I did not know existed — came at the suggestion of my employer, who believed I might have a drinking problem. The person sitting in front of me spoke to me for about an hour and most of what he said sounded familiar. He might as well have been talking about me. He suggested I attend a meeting that same day at lunchtime and that I would meet other people like me.

For the first time in many years, I felt at home as I was greeted with a warm welcome and an unconditional acceptance.

In *Daily Reflections*, on January 28, Bill W. says: "Showing others who suffer how we were given help is the very thing which makes life seem so worth while to us now." This reflection reminds me of my early days of sobriety. After the first nine months, I stopped attending meetings for the next three years. This decision led me to the lowest depths of my entire life. I was alone and I strongly wished to die.

Coming back to A.A., I was greeted again with warmth as I had been at my first meeting, and found what I had missed most: the contact with other people who, like me, were alcoholics and that soft pat on the back that told me I was okay even though I doubted it.

These two facts led me to understand the importance of the theme of my presentation: "Connecting with Each Other." In my mind, to connect means to pass on to the other person. These people passed on the A.A. message to me through their experience, their suffering, and their recovery. They taught me, as Bill says, that life is precious and that it can be good if I make enough of an effort.

Their attraction gave me the hope that one day I could have what they had. For the last thirty years, I have consistently met people who had that attraction, and I can sense there are many of those here today, and I thank you for that.

The other part of my presentation is about: "Singleness of Purpose" — to be pertinent even in a changing world.

Since the beginning, I have been talking about that very singleness, which in my mind is Tradition Five, which reminds us that our primary purpose is to carry the message to the alcoholic who still suffers. Indeed, A.A. has but a single purpose.

Of all our Traditions, this Tradition is, in my opinion, the one that best defines our Fellowship and who it exists for. There is no place for interpretation and there is no way we can deviate from our primary objective.

I believe this Tradition is still pertinent, even despite the constant evolution our world is going through; for like all others, it is based in humility, love, sharing, attraction, honesty, acceptance, and tolerance, which are spiritual principles that have remained human principles, not subject to change, despite centuries of evolution on our planet.

I have lived through what Bill and Bob experienced in their early recovery and I am convinced that those who will be here eighty years from now will feel the same because we are emotional human beings and I do not believe this will change.

So, thank you for granting me the privilege of speaking to you and celebrating the wonderful Fellowship that saved my life.

Thank you for your warm welcome. You have made me a better man.

Michel Bergeron, Southeast Québec

Informed Group Conscience — The Key to Unity

The first word of the First Step is "we" not "I." We decided to join Alcoholics Anonymous and we became a part of a society. How is it that the very life of an alcoholic and future alcoholics depends on uniting together? When I became a member of A.A., I realized I needed to conform to the spiritual principles for my personal recovery. Then I was taught the spiritual principle of our Second Tradition, that there is a loving God who expresses Himself through our group conscience. So I thought, just how does God speak through members for that group to have an informed group conscience?

When my life had come to a turning point, I asked God to help me. I asked Him to give me guidance and for help to not drink alcohol. I was guided to Alcoholics Anonymous. My life depended on working the Steps. I used to think I had all of the answers and could fix the world. By working the Steps, I realized that I could self-sabotage, mislead and deceive myself and that I could not fix me or anyone else. I quickly learned that it was beneficial to consult with my sponsor and other alcoholics. I was taught to live the Three Legacies, that my life was dependent on service to my God and to working with other alcoholics. As Dr. Bob shared in his story, working with other alcoholics was paying back the debt for the one who passed it on to him, and was a little more insurance against a possible slip. I believe by God's grace and being guided to A.A. my life has been saved and restored. When I asked for help, the hand of A.A. was there.

Now that my life has changed by working the Steps, it was suggested to pass it on. But how? I stepped up and started to put my faith into action and started serving A.A. at the general service level. I went to my first district meeting in Brockville, Ontario, Canada. As my home group's G.S.R., I started to bring topics and issues to our group business meeting for discussion. I then brought our group's feedback to the district. I started to learn about group conscience and the importance of being informed on topics or issues before a decision was made. I moved on to serve my district and went to area meetings where I got to see that A.A. is much bigger than I first realized and that it is a worldwide society of people. I found that being a member in this Fellowship meant that I was united with others all around the world. I was just a small part of something really big. Yet, my part is vital for the Fellowship's survival. While serving in A.A., I was a part of resolving issues to help others stay sober not only in my local area but all around the world. The responsibility to take care of the Fellowship was placed in our care by the founders and it is our responsibility as members of A.A. to find ways to carry this message to the still-suffering alcoholic.

I have learned that by having a plan or an idea, and then just implementing it without considering others, is not the best thing to do. It has been passed on by those



who have gone before us that we need to seek God and consult widely for the wisdom of others before implementing an idea or plan, if at all. We look at a plan or an idea from all sides and after really listening to the critics we may modify or change it all together. As we unite for a decision on how best to move on an idea or plan, God is able to express Himself through each member. Each among the vast multitude of members in this society has different experience and perceptions that can help to examine an idea or plan from all angles. We each have a right to participate in the discussion and together we come to an informed group conscience on what is best for A.A. as a whole, and its future. We are thoroughly allowing the collective conscience of the Fellowship to participate in the process and this is how we become truly informed.

I conclude and agree with what our founders have passed on to us, the most beneficial result of working with others is just as it is stated in Tradition One: "The unity of Alcoholics Anonymous is the most cherished quality our Society has. Our lives, the lives of all to come, depend squarely upon it. We stay whole, or A.A. dies. Without unity, the heart of A.A. would cease to beat; our world arteries would no longer carry the life-giving grace of God; His gift to us would be spent aimlessly." (*Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*, p. 129)

Unity in service is the vital key for our Fellowship's future to stay alive.

Vicky Shaw, Central New York

Be Involved, Be Inspired, Be of Service

I got sober in a small college town in eastern Washington State. The first A.A. meeting I attended regularly was the noon meeting on campus where the members were mostly college kids. I remember very little of what was said or done at my first several meetings. A good friend says I was sweaty and shaky and nowhere to be found when the meeting was over.

What I do remember is that they were having fun. They did not look like I felt. I remember the smiles and the laughter, and I can still hear a friend calling from the top of the stairs, "Keep coming back, Darren," as I tried to escape the fellowship after the meeting. I pretended that I didn't hear him and kept right on walking, but I smiled inside knowing that they knew my name and wanted me to keep coming back. It seemed that everywhere I went on campus or around town, I would turn the corner and run into two or three of those A.A. people. I was lonely, miserable and suffering from untreated alcoholism. They were laughing and enjoying life.

After six months of doing things my way, I was desperate for a way out. The demonstration of a new way of living was the inspiration that helped me to surrender and ask for help. That noon meeting on campus became my first home group. Participation in a home group was the spark that I needed for the revolution to

begin. Overnight, it seems, I was no longer doing this alone. I had a host of new friends and a fresh outlook on sobriety.

My new friends and mentors showed me a new purpose and I learned that our group meetings and group activities and even the future of Alcoholics Anonymous were now my responsibility. I was introduced to general service and I quickly began experiencing our Twelve Traditions in action. It wasn't long before I was road-tripping to area assemblies and committee meetings, possessed of the same enthusiasm and energy that had attracted me in the first place.

Throughout my sobriety, sponsoring other men, involvement in a home group and service to the Fellowship have been the lifeblood that's kept me spiritually connected and balanced, especially during those times when life has been challenging. There have been periods when I wasn't so well balanced and where my enthusiasm and willingness have been minimal. I've sometimes thought: "I'm tired of my home group," or "I don't want to go to those stupid meetings."

I'm grateful that these thoughts have been mostly temporary and that I've usually managed to get re-grounded and quickly headed in the direction of the next right action. I'm reminded of a friend who once said, "There's not a lot of spiritual growth taking place sitting here on my couch." I need to remember to stay open for business and in a position where spiritual growth can take place.

One of my favorite Big Book passages is in "Bill's Story," where it says "For if an alcoholic failed to perfect and enlarge his spiritual life through work and self-sacrifice for others, he could not survive the certain trials and low spots ahead. If he did not work, he would surely drink again, and if he drank, he would surely die." (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. 14) This passage reminds me to always take a look at my A.A. activities and ask myself: are they truly about work and self-sacrifice?

Nothing gives me a spiritual recharge like picking up a new sponsee. The men that I sponsor are absolutely the bright spots of my life. But, I can't just sit around and wait for a new guy to fall in my lap or feel content with simply putting my name on phone lists and attending my home group. What's worked best for me is getting out of my comfort zone and finding those meetings where my same old message is new and fresh again. I can always go seek out that guy who's miserable, lonely and not happy with his sobriety, just like I was in the beginning.

Another "get off the couch" experience that's helped to recharge my energy and enthusiasm has been to periodically change home groups. I like to look for a new home group that has maybe lost its way or has forgotten about general service — or maybe just doesn't know any better — and share my experience and knowledge with them. Helping them helps me to be involved, be inspired and be of service.

Darren Flint, Western Washington

CONNECTING WITH A.A. AS A WHOLE

Scott Huyghebaert, trustee-at-large/Canada, chaired the Thursday morning presentation/discussion session.

Participating in All of A.A.

In the beginning, my first meeting was all of A.A., as far as I was concerned. I arrived as the meeting started and left as soon as it was over. After a while, I found myself thinking about things that were said at the meeting and the people who said them.

Before long I was showing up early and staying late, and I began to look forward to seeing my new friends and going out for coffee after the meeting. Sitting in a restaurant drinking coffee for hours, talking and laughing, I learned that sobriety was more than just not drinking. While developing a tolerance for caffeine, I got a sponsor, who suggested I needed a "commitment." So I took one at my home group, setting up and cleaning up. I was making meetings, I was following suggestions and gradually I noticed that more of my friends were sober than not. And, I knew things about these new friends that I didn't about my drinking buddies. I must be connecting to all of A.A.; what more could there be?

In the beginning, having a commitment was enough because I was new. Over the years I took on new and more challenging commitments, and as my responsibility grew, so did the complexity of these commitments. I needed to strengthen my foundation and like many A.A.s in that circumstance, I turned naturally to the Traditions. I read the literature, I listened to other members share their experience, and thought that meant I understood. However, subsequent experience has taught me that comprehension almost always is the result of the actions I take, not just the reading or the listening or the thinking I do.

In the beginning, Connection and Participation seems, with hindsight, to have been easier ... but was it? In the beginning, A.A. was just my first meeting, but I still had lots of old ideas. In the beginning, A.A. was only one meeting where I connected with others like me, if for no other reason than that I was blessed with the gift of desperation necessary to suppress a natural skepticism that questioned all the suggestions made with respect to needed changes in my life. Through participation I made both personal and philosophic connections that made these suggestions tolerable, such that before I knew it, I had claimed them as my own. While I was unaware of any master plan motivating my actions, I've come to appreciate the grand design that continues to unfold. The point is, it was the verbs that made this happen, not the nouns. Only through action did I remain sober, teachable, and open to new ideas.

Connection to A.A. and Participation in its programs preceded knowledge of recovery, spirituality, and peace of mind. From I.C.Y.P.A.A., to the Corrections Committee, to area leadership, my actions led me deeper and more broadly into all aspects of our Fellowship, from meetings to sponsorship, to committees. At the same time, it provided the courage necessary to abandon a well-paying

job and pursue a dream career that demanded relocation, and which led to a host of other experiences that neither fulfilled my dream nor left me burdened with regrets.

I know what it means when someone says "I earned my seat in A.A.," or "I paid my dues," but those around me know that I've continued to earn my seat by participating in the opportunities to repay a debt that can never be satisfied. The question is: what can I do to assure there is a seat for the next person? Our primary purpose, "to carry the message," is the responsibility that I share.

After thirty-five years, I've come to realize how little my motivation has changed. I wanted to stay sober and I started to participate out of fear that not doing so would lead me to drink again. Today, my "fear" might be better described as respect, but nonetheless, sobriety is the motivation regardless of the words I use. Further, I've come to understand that knowledge, whether gleaned from books, experience, or the often unappreciated guidance of those around me, has fortified this motivation and reaffirmed what I was told when I first arrived: that "time" in the program is no guarantee of wisdom — and lack of time no barrier to insight.

Connecting to A.A. and Participating in A.A. have always been about maintaining my sobriety. Today I realize that this sobriety is dependent on my passing it on to others who in turn will come to see that they, too, must pass it on. Whether they choose to do so on the local, district, area, or national level is not as important as that they choose to do it in the first place.

Thomas Babuscio, Chicago, Illinois

Understanding Self-Support

Aloha Kakou. This translates to "May there be friendship or love between us." My name is Cheryl and I am an alcoholic. I am truly honored to be serving as the Panel 65 Delegate for Area 17, Hawaii. I serve on the Corrections Committee and the Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums. I received a loving invitation to present on the topic "Connecting with A.A. as a Whole: Understanding Self-Support." Upon receiving the email, I was immediately overcome with a great deal of angst. After consulting with my service sponsor, past delegates and my Higher Power, it all seemed a bit more manageable. I remembered what a friend of mine told me years ago when I was to give a presentation to a large group. She said, "Take God with you when you go to the podium." And so I'm following her advice; I brought my God with me, to stand right here beside me.

There are doubtless many aspects to this topic. Two stood out. First, there was the experience of the early A.A.s. As A.A. grew, the need for funds to support an office and enable the word of A.A. to spread became apparent. Bill W. and some of the early members felt the only way for the Fellowship to survive was to approach philanthropic institutions or individuals for funds. Fortunately for A.A., one individual who was approached, John D. Rockefeller, Jr., replied, "I am afraid that money will spoil this thing" at the same time as he endorsed the Fellowship. Early A.A. members

began to see the concern presented by accepting outside contributions described in the cliché “He who pays the piper calls the tune.” Thus began our policy of self-support.

My loving invitation suggested the possibility of incorporating the Conference Theme, “Our Spiritual Way of Life: Steps, Traditions and Concepts.” This got me thinking about the spiritual side of the Seventh Tradition, the second aspect I’ll address. When I got to these rooms, I didn’t know anything about spirituality. I was a very concrete thinker, always trying to figure things out. And, I didn’t understand words like trust, faith, humility, willingness and acceptance. It took me a long time to see the spiritual aspect of contributing to the Seventh Tradition.

So, what does our Seventh Tradition make possible?

- It keeps the doors of A.A. meetings open for all of us. By doing that, it saves lives. I would not be here today were it not for A.A., and I have heard this sentiment expressed over and over again in meetings.
- It supports Intergroup/Central Offices where our phones are answered and A.A. literature is available.
- It funds G.S.R.s to area assemblies connecting A.A. group members to A.A. as a whole.
- It supports districts, D.C.M.s, area committees, officers and the area delegate so they can meet and discuss local issues.
- Alcoholic inmates get Big Books.
- Professionals get accurate information about A.A.
- It funds the area delegate’s yearly attendance at the General Service Conference where the voices of the home groups in the area are carried and shared with 92 other delegates from the U.S., Canada and Puerto Rico.
- It supports the General Service Office.

What if there were no G.S.O.?

- There would be no Big Book, “Twelve and Twelve,” Grapevine or any of the 68 translations of the Big Book (with 13 new translations pending), or other literature which has been published in over 87 languages worldwide. Looking at the display of foreign language Big Books always touches my heart. Our contributions to the Seventh Tradition have made it possible for A.A. to spread throughout the world and offer a solution to suffering alcoholics from Nunavut near the North Pole to Iran and China. Talk about going to any length to carry the message!
- G.S.O. helps maintain unity and effectiveness of our Twelfth Step work. Without G.S.O., the groups would not be connected to each other through the general service structure. There would be wide variations in A.A. in different geographic areas.
- A.A. Loners wouldn’t receive the letters from other A.A.s, a service G.S.O. facilitates.

If it were not for these entities, many new people would never discover the miracles of A.A.

Our contributions to the Seventh Tradition are a materi-

al expression of our commitment to A.A. as a whole. The amount of our contribution is secondary to the spiritual connection that unites all groups around the world.

In closing, I want to refer to an article in the October 1967 Grapevine titled “A.A.’s Tradition of Self-Support.” Bill W. answers the question of why should we support all these services financially. He said, “The answer is simple enough. Every single A.A. service is designed to make more and better Twelfth Step work possible, whether it be a group meeting place, a central or intergroup office... or the world service Headquarters... Though not costly, these service agencies are absolutely essential to our continued expansion — to our survival as a Fellowship.” (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 350)

This is as true today in 2016 as it was when Bill said it in 1967. Twelfth Step work is the lifeblood of Alcoholics Anonymous.

Mahalo palena ‘ole (gratitude beyond measure) to you and Alcoholics Anonymous for my life today.

Cheryl Nesler, Hawaii

Reaching Out to the Next Generation of A.A.s

My name is Jim Stone, Panel 65, Area 1, Alabama/N.W. Florida. I want to thank the Conference Committee for the opportunity to give this presentation, and I am truly grateful to be here. “Connecting with A.A. as a Whole: Reaching Out to the Next Generation of A.A.s” will enable us to continue carrying the message of recovery, unity, and service for generations to come. But, when I got to A.A. in 1992, I had the vague notion that maybe someday I might be able to drink like a normal person. I was selfish and self-centered. I wasn’t interested in carrying a message of any sort. That being said, connecting with A.A. as a whole and reaching out to the next generation of A.A.s took a long time. With good sponsorship and direction, I am able to do both now — and it is my responsibility to continue to do that. I have to be willing and open-minded enough to use all the tools available to me, now and in the future, to accomplish that. It will take time for the newcomer, just as it did with me, and I have to practice patience, tolerance and love when working with them.

Bill W. wrote an article in the Grapevine in July 1960 titled, “A.A. Tomorrow.” The article can be found in either Grapevine’s online Story Archive or in *The Language of the Heart* (p. 308). While that article was written over 55 years ago, the basic principles remain the same. In it, Bill said, “Clearly our first duty to A.A.’s future is to maintain in full strength what we now have. Only the most vigilant caretaking can assure this.”

Going forward, A.A. will need to continue to grow as new communication tools become available. I believe Bill would have utilized the new technologies available today, though practices of the past will still be important regardless of what future tools we use: we will still need to protect the anonymity of our members; we will still need to protect the confidences of information shared in meetings,

on social media, or in online chat rooms. If we do these things, A.A. will be attractive to newcomers and to those coming back to the rooms of Alcoholics Anonymous.

The subject of this presentation was discussed as a topic at my home group and the discussion was useful in its preparation. As with a lot of A.A. meetings, there was a broad range of age, race, and backgrounds of the members. There was discussion about the next generation of A.A.s being young members, but it is not limited to young people. It will be anyone with an alcohol problem, regardless of their age, race, gender, occupation or sexual orientation.

It was pointed out that the tools of recovery we use now — and have for years past — are still effective and work across generational boundaries. One oldtimer at the meeting talked about being welcomed to the group, not being lectured or told what to do. People shared their experience, strength, and hope. One of the most attractive things about A.A. is the language of the heart that you hear in the rooms. Our next generation of A.A.s will appreciate the honesty and heartfelt feelings expressed in meetings, in print, or on social media.

Sponsorship is one of the most important tools we need to continue to use. Through sponsorship we need to encourage the people we sponsor to carry the message of A.A.'s Three Legacies of Recovery, Unity and Service — not just Recovery alone; encourage new members of A.A. to participate in our groups' business meetings, in district meetings and at area assemblies. We need to express the importance of A.A.'s literature, whether hardcopy or electronic, in carrying the message of A.A., and introduce newcomers to the Grapevine, Box 4-5-9, the *Final Conference Report*, and other newsletters that carry the message of what is going on with A.A. as a whole. We should stress the importance of participating in our service structure, and what that work has done for us. It is by doing these things that we keep our current and future members informed about what is going on in A.A.

So, keep an open mind about new technology. If it is used responsibly, and in a welcoming, loving and tolerant way, many future A.A. members may be saved from the grasp of alcoholism. In using the new tools available to us we need to remember our singleness of purpose of helping the still sick and suffering alcoholic, whether they are new, returning, or just having a hard time for any reason. We can also use new tools to assist in carrying the message of our Three Legacies for our current A.A. members and for generations of new A.A.s to come.

In closing, it is important that we continue to carry the same message A.A.

has always carried, whether it be in meetings, print or electronically. It is important that we stay connected to A.A. as whole. A.A. needs to stay current and utilize new tools as they become available — the future of A.A. depends upon it.

Thank you for allowing me to participate, and for the love and hope that can be found in the rooms Alcoholics Anonymous.

Jim Stone, Alabama/N.W. Florida

A.A. GRAPEVINE/LA VIÑA

Following dinner Thursday evening Ami Brophy, Grapevine's executive editor/publisher, and Irene Donoso, La Viña editor, gave a PowerPoint presentation, summarized here, which was moderated by Albin Zezula, chairperson, A.A. Grapevine Board. The full report, with accompanying slides, is available upon request.

Hello. I'm Ami Brophy and I am an alcoholic currently serving as the executive editor/publisher of A.A. Grapevine, Inc.

In its infancy, Grapevine offered a way to connect the groups (then about 300). It also served to: foster understanding among groups; share ideas about how to keep groups going; provide information about alcoholism and the new research being done; share tips on how A.A.s were staying sober; report on the formation of new groups.

By the late 1940s and early 1950s, Grapevine had become an important public relations tool for the new Fellowship, as well. Articles in the magazine by leaders in law, religion, medicine, and journalism, along with a balanced tone and professional presentation helped to establish the credibility of A.A., the efficacy of the program, and its seriousness of purpose. Bill's letters during 1946 also specified that Grapevine should not take advertising or contributions — which can make it really challenging for a magazine! His vision for Grapevine as the "Voice of A.A." was formalized in 1986 at the General Service Conference with an Advisory Action that appears inside the front cover of every Grapevine: "Since each Grapevine cannot go through the Conference-approval process, the Conference recognizes the A.A. Grapevine as the international journal of Alcoholics Anonymous."

As Grapevine's format transformed from a newsletter to a pocket-sized magazine, its editorial content evolved, too. In the late 1990s, our "meeting in print" began an online presence with www.aagrapevine.org and



Grapevine's website has become a tremendous tool for anyone who wants to get information, connect or participate at any time.

Grapevine and La Viña share the ongoing task of keeping the Fellowship's communication channel vital, relevant and useful and a number of recent projects have offered ways for members to get involved: the Grapevine's ongoing Audio Project; 2015 Subscription Challenge; current Grow Your Grapevine outreach effort; and the Carry the Message gift subscription effort. The Grapevine board is also seeking organization-wide support in the form of list sharing with A.A.W.S. to expand the reach of Grapevine and La Viña.

Additionally, a new Grapevine Subscription App has recently been introduced, through which subscribers receive the monthly issue, access to an archive of past issues, special notices from Grapevine, and the option to email an article to a friend. The app has also been enabled for audio stories and featured videos such as the Public Information PSA "Doors."

Grapevine and La Viña are our forums. We are familiar with what they have accomplished and contributed so far. But what else can be accomplished that might engage and inform members, promote unity, and offer one more doorway into A.A.?

As we look forward let's imagine if Grapevine:

- curated regional histories of stories by area on a clickable map available for download.
- offered a podcast of experience, strength and hope from members around the country.
- published books that focus on specific cultural experiences to help carry the message to populations that are under-represented in our Fellowship
- offered secure forums where members could share their experience real time.
- offered a space to post and share sober art and imagery.
- hosted online Grapevine meetings.
- created an online forum to discuss topics of importance to the Fellowship.
- directly supported A.A. communication efforts at A.A.W.S. with artwork, writing, and creative presentation.
- offered a hub of anonymous speaker tapes for distribution and broad sharing.
- had an international section to give North America a glimpse into A.A. around the world.
- had a Twitter account that distributed written articles or members' short audio stories directly in the member's own voice.

It's food for thought...

Now, let's hear from Irene Donoso, La Viña's editor.

to update us about La Viña.

La Viña reflects the ongoing "expressed need" of alcoholics in the growing number of Hispanic A.A. communities. As far back as 1991, our General Service Conference responded to this need with an Advisory Action to translate one Grapevine story into Spanish each month, an action that ultimately led to the bi-monthly magazine we have today.

La Viña receives an average of 100 stories each month from members. These stories are available in the print magazine, in free downloadable audio stories online, in our 4 books (and first ebook), and 11 CDs. The recently launched "La Viña Weekly Quote" in Spanish features the words of Bill W. taken from the books *The Language of the Heart* and *The Best of Bill*. Together with the print magazine, the Spanish-language web pages on aagrapevine.org/español serve as an important communications tool for Spanish-speaking members.

This year the 20th anniversary of La Viña will be celebrated in Arizona, Florida, Connecticut and Texas, among other places. Is your area's linguistic district aware of these activities?

Now let's finish with some exciting news: As Hispanic A.A. members often choose to communicate by text message, last September we launched the La Viña Spanish-Language Text Message Service for members to purchase subscriptions, receive free updates, news and much more. Nearly 700 members are registered so far and this effort has driven subscriptions and heightened awareness.

Ami Brophy, executive editor/publisher;

Irene Donoso, La Viña editor



■ Workshop

On Wednesday morning, Conference members split up into small groups for a workshop session to discuss the trustees' Feasibility Study Subcommittee report. Each group was provided with some brainstorming questions and four separate topics were covered: Communications; Revenue; Expenses; and Structure. Each group had a moderator and a reporter and provided a summary from each section that was presented to the full Conference at a session on Thursday morning. The report-backs are condensed here, but are available in full upon request.

Communications

Brainstorming Questions:

- Assuming that we undertake an effort to identify and develop a more effective internal and external communications for: still-suffering alcoholics looking for help; A.A. members; "Friends of A.A."; and the general public, how can that be accomplished? What should those efforts specifically include?

In terms of reaching the still-suffering alcoholic, emphasis was placed on communication at the local level — individual members, groups, districts, areas — welcoming the newcomer, offering and improving sponsorship, engaging in local committee work (especially P.I. and C.P.C.), and developing effective cooperation between districts and intergroups. The use of technology was also discussed, focused on utilizing the Internet, especially with the tools from A.A.W.S., the Grapevine, and intergroups/central offices such as live chats and forums for sharing.

Discussion of communicating with A.A. members was focused on two elements: member-to-member communication, which centered on strengthening the home group, sponsorship and workshops; and communication through the service structure, which included better use of technology, talking about money, and looking for ways to connect areas.

Communication with "Friends of A.A." and the general public could be enhanced by technology (website improvements, YouTube, social networking) and a wider use of available resources. A difficulty can be finding members willing to participate in P.I./C.P.C. work. In carrying the message outside the Fellowship, it was noted, "We are anonymous, not invisible."

Additional suggestions/ideas:

- Better utilize G.S.O.'s FNV data base for more efficient bundling and distribution of information/resources
- Update pamphlets focused on carrying the message outside the Fellowship
- Reach out to medical and legal systems; encourage speaking with medical and law students
- Inventory the effectiveness of A.A.'s outreach mechanisms (PSAs, website, newsletters)
- Adopt-a-group; adopt-a-professional

Revenue

Brainstorming Questions:

- Reflecting on the Seventh Tradition of self-support as it currently exists today, what specific changes or enhancements could be made to both increase the dollars contributed and the participation involvement by groups and individuals?
- Reflecting on the A.A.W.S. literature being sold today, both in terms of variety of items being sold and their price, are there specific changes that could be made, such as the creation of additional types of literature that could be sold?
- Reflecting on the magazines and other publications currently being sold by Grapevine and La Viña, what changes could be made to further enhance their desirability so that the Fellowship would be enticed to increase their subscriptions and purchases of such materials?

A recurring theme was the need for enhanced communication throughout the Fellowship regarding what happens to the money that is put in the basket, both throughout the service structure and at G.S.O. What do contributions cover? Groups and individuals need to know more coherently what services they are financing. Members need to be engaged in the financial stability of A.A. as a whole.

It was noted that there is a wealth of historical material in the A.A. Archives that could be used to generate new literature in keeping with the Traditions. There was also discussion of greater use of technology for existing A.A.W.S. materials, such as eBooks and audio books, while improving the online buying experience for members on the G.S.O. website. It was also noted that the process for generating new literature is long and arduous and could be examined with an eye toward simplification. Additionally, materials that haven't sold well or had a price increase in a long time should be evaluated. And perhaps there is more literature than is necessary and overlapping content could be simplified.

The Grapevine and La Viña offer a direct connection to A.A. members and groups and need to be supported more actively throughout the Fellowship. A great tool for corrections, some wondered if the magazine needed to be so expensive to produce and if the renewal process could be made less cumbersome. Editorially, it was thought that Grapevine could provide more information and service news for the Fellowship along with sharing the experience, strength and hope of individual members.

Additional suggestions/ideas:

- Make the contribution section of G.S.O.'s A.A. website more visible, with easy access and utilization; highlight the recurring contribution option
- Provide wider distribution of letter sent to contributors highlighting services provided by G.S.O. (twelve points)
- Consider applying a registration fee for Regional Forums;

consider selling literature at Regional Forums

- *Consider selling A.A. medallions and other “drunk junk”*
- *Seek opportunities for opting in to Grapevine through Fellowship-wide events*

Expenses

Brainstorming Questions:

- Reflecting on the specific service activities provided to the Fellowship by G.S.O., what specific services or items could be either changed or eliminated to reduce expenses?
- Reflecting on the current organizational operating structures of A.A.W.S. and Grapevine, what back office functions could be combined to reduce operating expenses?

It was felt that communication is a big key regarding services and their expense, especially in bridging the disconnect within the Fellowship between the expectation of services provided and the support of those services through contributions. One way of reducing expenses discussed was doing more at the area/district level to communicate with groups instead of having G.S.O. provide all the direct services (kits, etc.). This decentralization could help defray mailing/distribution costs and reduce redundancies in services provided. Technology was another area for reducing expenses wherever possible (digital versus paper), as well as developing more accurate data bases and mailing lists, and posting more service and financial material on the website.

In terms of the office operation of G.S.O. and Grapevine, it was felt that both offices are relatively lean and that both continue looking for ways to contain and reduce expenses on a regular basis. The suggestion was made for the General Service Board to look into hiring an outside efficiency consultant to review office functions and identify where and how procedures could be streamlined.

Additional suggestions/ideas:

- *Increase use of videoconferencing for corporate board meetings, interviews, etc.*
- *Explore ways to cut international travel costs; evaluate cost/benefits of World Service Meeting*
- *Should the General Service Conference be held every other year (with interim coverage in alternate years similar to zonal meetings)? Over a shorter period of time (five days versus seven)? In less expensive venues (decreased costs of holding the meeting outside the city)?*
- *Explore the possibility of consolidating the Grapevine and A.A.W.S. online stores to reduce costs and increase customer satisfaction*
- *Consider publishing La Viña electronically*

Structure

Brainstorming Questions:

- Reflecting on the current organizational operating structures of G.S.B., A.A.W.S. and GV and *without* regard to either costs or efficiency, are there better structures that could be developed that would allow A.A. to better deliver its spiritual message of hope and recovery?
- Reflecting on the current organizational operating structures of G.S.B., A.A.W.S. and GV but this time considering costs and efficiency, are there better structures that could be developed that would allow A.A. to better deliver its spiritual message of hope and recovery?

One report focused on “silos of service” whereby the various service entities seem to work side-by-side but without sufficient communication between them. One suggestion was that the two corporate boards could meet at the same time, and then participate afterward in a joint meeting with all members of the General Service Board to facilitate the transmission of information and gain a better understanding of the goals of each entity. The “silos of service” effect extends also to the General Service Conference committees and their corresponding trustees’ committees, leading to miscommunication sometimes felt throughout the entire service structure. There is also a concern for the perception in the Fellowship of an arbitrary nature to the selection of agenda items in the General Service Conference process.

In terms of different organizational structures that could benefit the Fellowship, a suggestion was made to establish a Conference Committee on Technology. In today’s rapidly changing digital world, such an approach might help the Fellowship absorb the growing use of technology, find new ways of carrying our message to professionals and the general public, and disseminate/distribute our materials. And rather than having technology — and its impact on the Fellowship — recognized under the wing of P.I. or C.P.C., it should stand on its own. Technology is moving faster than A.A. and we need ways to better integrate it into our Fellowship.

Additional suggestions/ideas:

- *Review and evaluate the current regional structure, with an eye toward expanding it to provide a stronger service structure reporting directly to the Fellowship*
- *Search ways to better utilize Class A trustees on the corporate boards*
- *Consider the spiritual and practical implications/impediments there might be in combining the publishing activities of A.A.W.S., Inc., and A.A. Grapevine, Inc. under one corporation*
- *Consider combining Grapevine and Box 4-5-9 to create a single published item that is not only a meeting in print but also serves as a means of distributing news to the Fellowship*

■ Reports from the General Service Board, A.A.W.S., and Grapevine Corporate Boards

GENERAL SERVICE BOARD REPORT

Trustees report: Greetings and welcome to the 66th General Service Conference, especially to those who are attending for the first time. This week we are embarking together on a spiritual adventure under the theme, "Our Spiritual Way of Life: Steps, Traditions and Concepts." The theme seems particularly relevant as we address a wide range of agenda items reflecting our Three Legacies of Recovery, Unity and Service.

The General Service Board has met four times since our last Conference: for the annual members meeting in April, and quarterly board meetings in August, November and February. A major focus throughout the year has been on strategic planning.

Following the 2015 General Service Conference, the General Service Board welcomed two new Class A (non-alcoholic) trustees, Peter Luongo and Leslie Backus, along with two new Class B trustees, Yolanda Flores and Scott Huyghebaert. At the end of this year's Conference three trustees will rotate: Class A trustees Michele Grinberg and John Fromson, and regional trustee Andrew Ware. We are grateful for their dedication, self-sacrifice and tireless service on behalf of the Fellowship.

On the G.S.O. front, we welcomed a new general manager, Greg Tobin, who took over in October from Phyllis Halliday who served in the position for seven years. We also welcomed two new staff members, Sandra Wilson and Jeff Wine, while saying farewell to a number of long-time A.A.W.S. and Grapevine employees: Louis Carillo (assistant bookkeeper) after 34 years of service; Constance Ivey (contributions supervisor) after 37 years of service; staff member Jim Malone after six years; and Grapevine controller Eugene O'Brien who retired after 12 years.

Additionally, throughout the past year, construction has been underway for the G.S.O./Grapevine co-location project, and as of the second week in January, the Grapevine has moved into its new area on the 11th floor, reducing overhead and streamlining the use of space.

Since the 65th Conference, the General Service Board has hosted Regional Forums in Albany, New York; Casper, Wyoming; Whitehorse, Yukon; St. Louis, Missouri; and Milwaukee, Wisconsin.

On the international front, trustees and G.S.O. staff were invited to A.A. events in Poland, Italy, and Ukraine. Additionally, our trustees-at-large attended the 19th REDELA (Meeting of the Americas) in Mexico City, Mexico, which is the A.A. zonal service meeting corresponding to the A.A. service structures in North, Central and South America. Staff members and trustees also attended zonal service meetings in Dubai (the Asia-Oceania Service Meeting), England (the European Service Meeting), and South Africa (the Sub-Saharan Africa Service Meeting). Zonal meetings are designed to provide a forum for A.A. representatives in far-flung places to discuss the challenges of creating service structures, literature distribution and practicing A.A. principles in all their affairs. In 2016, our

trustees-at-large are scheduled to attend A.A. events in Germany and Panama, and will be participating in the 24th World Service Meeting, which will be held in Rye Brook, New York.

As we have since 1991, we welcomed Conference committee chairpersons and the Conference delegate chair to the General Service Board weekend in January. Delegate chairpersons attended an orientation at G.S.O., met with their committee staff secretaries, and participated in sessions of corresponding trustees' committees. The practice of inviting Conference committee chairs continues to benefit the Conference process in helping delegate chairs fulfill their responsibilities to the Conference and to A.A. as a whole.

One of the highlights of the past year was celebrating A.A.'s 80th birthday at the 2015 International Convention in Atlanta, Georgia. With 56,900 registered attendees, this was the largest International Convention yet, and was well attended by members from around the world, with Mexico, the United Kingdom and Germany leading the way. In all, over 1,000 people participated in over 250 A.A. meetings, panels, and marathons, held in Finnish, French, German, Italian, Japanese, Lithuanian, Polish, Portuguese, Russian, Spanish and ASL. Over 4,000 volunteers from the Atlanta Host Committee greeted and guided Convention-goers throughout the weekend, spreading information and enthusiasm. The Oldtimers Meeting on Saturday featured 106 oldtimers with 50 or more years, including 10 members with over 60 years of sobriety, and on Sunday the Closing Meeting featured a presentation of the 35 millionth copy of the Big Book to the Sisters of Charity of St. Augustine, the order to which longtime A.A. friend Sister Ignatia belonged.

Although attendance was a record high, with revenues of \$5.9 million, Convention expenses were \$6.1 million, resulting in an estimated loss of \$210,000. The higher than anticipated numbers of attendees necessitated reserving more hotels located further away from downtown Atlanta, thereby increasing transportation costs to connect the hotels and the convention center. Other higher than expected expenses, including stadium production and security, were also related to larger numbers of attendees with special needs.

However, with the Convention's objectives to provide opportunities for a rededication of attendees to the primary purpose of A.A., to enable attendees to witness the success and growth of the A.A. program around the world, and to let the world know that A.A. is alive, flourishing and available as a community resource, locally and internationally, it can be said that this Convention was a great success. And so with gratitude we look forward to the next International Convention in Detroit, Michigan in 2020, and on to Vancouver, British Columbia in 2025.

In August, the board established a number of subcommittees for its Conference, Corrections, Literature, Nominating, Public Information and Treatment and Accessibilities Com-

mittees and met in executive session to select the new general manager.

At its November meeting, the board received the final report of the Subcommittee on General Service Conference Observers and agreed to forward it to the 2016 Conference Committee on Policy and Admissions, along with a request to consider the concept of admitting representatives from the service structures of other Twelve Step fellowships to observe the General Service Conference.

The board also agreed to forward to the 2016 Conference C.P.C. Committee the recommendation that the pamphlet “Three Talks to Medical Societies by Bill W.” be retired. While it is of historical interest, the pamphlet is quite lengthy and dated. Additionally, the board approved a recommendation that “Special Needs” be removed from the name of the trustees’ Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Specials Needs-Accessibilities and throughout the committee’s Composition, Scope and Procedures, and that a similar request be forwarded to the corresponding Conference committee.

In January, the board agreed to forward to the Conference Committee on Policy and Admissions a request for two persons from the Ukraine to attend the 2016 Conference as observers. Additionally in January, following requests from previous General Service Conferences, the board agreed to forward to the 2016 Conference Committee on Policy and Admissions a report on “Plans for the Translation of All Conference Background” and a report on “Conclusions Regarding the Conference Agenda Committee and the Agenda Selection Process” to the 2016 Conference Agenda Committee.

Much of the board’s focus over the past year has been on strategic planning, and the board agreed to forward to the 2016 General Service Conference the report from the subcommittee on Feasibility Study. The report was developed for the sole purpose of soliciting input and advice from the delegates of the 66th General Service Conference and will be the subject of workshop-style discussion throughout this week. The report will provide the opportunity for brainstorming on four basic topics: improving internal and external communications; increasing revenues; reducing expenses; and structure. Based on these discussions, the General Service Board will review the feedback and determine what ideas may be actionable and bring them back to future General Service Conferences for consideration.

The board also approved the General Service Board Strategic Plan titled “Serving the Fellowship,” which will be circulated in full with this report. The plan examines a number of the challenges and opportunities currently facing the Fellowship and establishes goals and possible processes to achieve these goals. Organizing the key strategic priorities into three different sections — Reaching Out the Hand of A.A., Improving Relations and Communications, and Fiscal Planning — the board has begun the process of addressing the lack of growth in the Fellowship in recent years, the effectiveness of communication throughout the

service structure, and the decline in literature sales and subscriptions which may result in financial challenges and require long-term fiscal planning. Some of the items in the plan are aspirational for the Fellowship, and the board recognizes that the goals described in the plan can only be achieved through the combined efforts of the board, the operating corporations, the General Service Conference and the Fellowship itself.

These are some of the highlights of a very active year — a year which has brought the future into greater focus and which culminates in the discussions that will take place here this week as we search for an informed group conscience on the many matters before us.

And so, as we begin our work, let us reaffirm our commitment to carrying A.A.’s lifesaving message. The General Service Conference is a gift passed on to us, and each of us has an obligation to keep the doors of A.A. open to those who so desperately need it — now and in the future — no matter who or where they are or what their background is. Our resolve to communicate within our principles under the theme, “Our Spiritual Way of Life: Steps, Traditions and Concepts” and bring forth what is best for the future of A.A. should be our guidepost and a measure of our success this week. I thank you for the opportunity to serve this Fellowship.

Terrance Bedient, chairperson

ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS WORLD SERVICES, INC.

Directors’ report: Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. (A.A.W.S.) is a not-for-profit corporation composed of nine directors. Members of A.A.W.S., Inc. are the 21 trustees of the General Service Board, who elect the nine directors responsible for oversight of the General Service Office (G.S.O.), group services, printing and distribution of Conference-approved literature and service material. A.A.W.S. holds copyrights in A.A. literature, and is responsible for translations of A.A. literature, including titles licensed to A.A. boards in other countries.

A.A.W.S. directors include two general service trustees and two regional trustees; three nontrustee directors; G.S.O.’s general manager and staff coordinator. Essential nonvoting support personnel attend each board meeting: G.S.O. staff, chief financial officer, publishing director, human resources manager, archivist, and board secretary.

Each year directors serving on Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. report to the General Service Conference on A.A. publishing, group services provided by G.S.O., and other activities linked directly to A.A.’s primary purpose. I am privileged to present this report on behalf of my fellow directors. The purpose of the publishing activities and group services provided by A.A.W.S. and G.S.O., as requested from the Fellowship, is to support members’ and groups’ Twelfth Step efforts to reach the still-suffering alcoholic. The structure, composition and responsibilities of Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. are described in Chapter 10 of *The A.A. Service Manual*.

The A.A.W.S. Board has met seven times since the 65th Conference to receive reports from G.S.O. management and staff, review updates on group services activity, track progress on implementation of Conference and board recommendations related to A.A.W.S., review financial reports, price new and revised publications, consider publishing operations and G.S.O. administrative matters, discuss requests from A.A. members and non-A.A.s seeking permission to reprint A.A. copyrighted literature, and to address other pertinent matters. (Concurrent with the seven board meetings, the A.A.W.S. Board met twice to conduct strategic planning sessions.)

The A.A.W.S. Board utilizes the committee system to address extensive agendas, to gather background material, and to thoroughly consider requests. The board, in turn, discusses committee reports and votes on any recommendations presented by a board committee in these reports. In addition, the board conducts long-range and strategic planning. Committees of the A.A.W.S. Board are: Technology/Communication/Services, which addresses the needs of service assignments, reviews G.S.O. communications with the Fellowship, and oversees G.S.O.'s A.A. website; Publishing reviews format requests, reprints, international translations of literature and other publishing matters; Finance oversees budgeting and financial results; and Nominating recommends candidates for A.A.W.S. nontrustee director and general service trustee vacancies.

Group Services: A net total of 1,195 new A.A. groups in the U.S. and Canada were listed at G.S.O. last year. Each new group's general service representative (G.S.R.) or contact receives A.A. literature and basic information to encourage the group to link with their local structure and support Twelfth Step activities. The service piece, "Services Provided by G.S.O./A.A.W.S." describes in detail the services provided by the A.A. staff assignments and other employees at G.S.O.

- *G.S.O.'s A.A. Website* — Oversight of G.S.O.'s A.A. website is the responsibility of the A.A.W.S. Board of Directors, acting through its Technology/Communication/Services and Publishing Committees and in accordance with the Twelve Traditions of Alcoholics Anonymous. The website received a total of 12,793,449 visits for the year 2015, an increase of 35% from the previous year's total of 9,422,166. New features include a "What's New" page to highlight new content on the site, dynamic web banners to "A.A. ORG Web Banners" page for linking to aa.org, and 2015 International Convention logo to home page as a link to Convention information. Representatives from G.S.O. attended the National A.A. Technology workshop held October 2-4, 2015 in St. Louis, Missouri. The purpose of this event is to share the message of Alcoholics Anonymous through technology to help the next alcoholic.

Forums and Other Events — Throughout the year, G.S.O. staff members are invited to attend and participate in many local and area service events, conferences and conventions. These trips help provide information about G.S.O. to A.A. gatherings and help staff to gather local

experience to add to other collected experience available from G.S.O.

- *Regional Forums:* A.A.W.S. directors and G.S.O. staff participated in six Regional Forums in 2015: the Northeast Forum in Albany, New York in May; the West Central Forum in Casper, Wyoming in August; the Western Canada Forum in Whitehorse, Yukon in September; the Local Forum in Timmons, Ontario, Canada in September; the Southwest Forum in St. Louis, Missouri in October; the East Central Forum in Milwaukee, Wisconsin in November.

- *National A.A. Archives Workshop:* G.S.O. Archivist, Michelle Mirza, along with senior archivist April Hegner, attended the 19th National A.A. Archives Workshop held in Independence, Ohio. There were 170 attendees (mostly archivists serving at the area, district or intergroup level) from the United States and Canada. April conducted a workshop on preserving photographs, and Michelle presented on Archives collections of A.A. material in the 1940s.

- *Intergroup/Central Office/A.A.W.S./A.A.G.V.:* The 30th Annual Intergroup/Central Office seminar was held in Fort Lauderdale, Florida, September 16-20, 2015. Members of the A.A.W.S. and A.A.G.V. Boards attended, as well as management and staff from both offices, including the G.S.O. staff member serving as liaison to intergroup/central offices.

International — Trustees, G.S.O. management and the International desk staff member received invitations from A.A. in other countries to share information regarding licensing and translations and experience with A.A. groups and trusted servants in local service structures. Highlights include: our International staff member attended the Annual Italian Convention in Rimini, Italy and the Asia-Oceania Zonal Meeting in Dubai in October; our general manager, along with G.S.O. staff member, Mary C., attended the European Service Meeting in York, UK; Greg T. our new general manager, attended the Poland General Service Conference at the Center on Missionary Animation in Warsaw.

Financial — Complete audited financial details for 2015 are included in the Conference Manual and *Final Conference Report*. Here is an overview:

- Total contributions for the year ended December 31, 2015, were \$7,154,156, \$154,156 (2%) greater than budget and \$256,077 (3.71%) greater than last year.
- Net sales for the year 2015 were \$12,489,433.
- Gross margin from literature sales was \$9,732,441.
- For the year 2015, net revenues were \$15,324,964.
- For the year 2015, total operating expenses were \$15,119,339.

2016 Budget — The A.A.W.S. Board approved the 2016 budget of the General Service Office with a net loss of \$26,691; after review by the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee, the budget was approved by the General Service Board.

Publishing Sales — For 2015, sales were below the estimate: \$12,706,249 actual sales vs. estimate of \$14,820,000, which is a \$2,113,751 (14%) negative variance. Total ebook gross sales for January-December 2015 stand at \$244,132 with 62,409 units distributed.

- **International licensing and translation:** January-December 2015 saw a noticeable surge in international requests, submissions and licensing. Translations shepherded through the review process reached an all-time high record of 58 (up 45% from the previous year) across 28 languages (up 47% from 2014). Notable languages/countries include (but are not limited to): Arabic, Croatian, Karen (Burmese immigrant populations), Farsi (Iran), Konkani (Goa, India), Maltese, Mongolian, Navajo, Russian, Somali, and Ukrainian.

G.S.O. and Staff Operations

- **Construction and Co-location Project:** The project of co-locating the General Service Office and the A.A. Grapevine office on the 11th Floor of 475 Riverside Drive commenced in early fall. Although there are still a number of open items to be resolved, Grapevine moved in the week of January 11, and is now settled into their new work space.

- **2015 International Convention of Alcoholics Anonymous:** The 2015 International Convention was held in Atlanta, Georgia, July 2-5, 2015. This was our largest Convention to date, with 56,900 registered attendees from around the world; over 250 A.A. meetings and panels were held for over 1,000 participants. The Atlanta Host Committee, 4,000 volunteers strong, greeted and guided attendees. The closing meeting featured a presentation of the 35 millionth copy of the Big Book to the Sisters of Charity of St. Augustine, the order to which longtime A.A. friend, Sister Ignatia, belonged.

- **Employees:** At year-end 2015, G.S.O. had 79 full-time employees, 4 part-time employees, and 5 temporary employees.

- **New Employees:** The position of payroll analyst was filled with the hiring of Pedro Velez. Although new to the G.S.O. family, Pedro comes to us from the Grapevine where he had been employed for 27

years. Our new G.S.O. general manager, Greg Tobin, came on board in October 2015. Jeff Wine commenced employment on October 5, 2015 on the Corrections assignment, and Sandra Wilson began on the Literature assignment as of November 2, 2015. Nancy Davis joined G.S.O. as executive assistant to the general manager on November 30, and Dmitry Kerget joined as an IT network administrator on December 8, 2015.

- **Retirees:** Louis Carillo, assistant bookkeeper, retired on June 1, 2015 after 34 years of service. On August 1, 2015, Constance Ivey, contributions supervisor, retired after 37 years of service. Phyllis Halliday, G.S.O. general manager, retired on October 1, 2015.

- **G.S.O. Visitors:** In 2015, G.S.O. welcomed 1,694 visitors, many of whom travelled great distances to visit and express gratitude for their sobriety.

- **Archives:** Last year, the Archives staff responded to approximately 1,300 requests for information and research, a clear indication of the Fellowship's continued interest in A.A. history.

- **Reprint Requests:** In 2015, A.A.W.S. granted permission/ did not object to 65 requests to reprint from A.A. literature, and denied permission to 81 requests.

The directors of the A.A. World Services Board and the management and staff of the General Service Office have worked diligently throughout 2015 on several major initiatives, such as the Conference Translation Project, as well as the 2015 International Convention and the office renovation of the 11th floor of the Interchurch Center in New York, which now accommodates the Grapevine office as well as G.S.O. All of these efforts are undertaken to strengthen the foundation of support A.A.W.S. provides for the Twelfth Step work of the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous by its members, groups and Conference structure. We look forward to an equally productive year ahead.

Chet Parker, chairperson



■ Literature Distributed — 2015

ENGLISH

Books

Alcoholics Anonymous	372,626
Alcoholics Anonymous (soft cover)	249,019
Alcoholics Anonymous (large print)	36,857
Alcoholics Anonymous (pocket abridged)	109,452
Alcoholics Anonymous (large print/abridged)	11,825
Daily Reflections	116,981
Daily Reflections (large print)	12,208
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (reg. ed.)	105,504
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (gift ed.)	3,785
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (soft cover)	116,967
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (large print)	19,867
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (pocket ed.)	36,350
A.A. Comes of Age	6,382
As Bill Sees It	20,326
As Bill Sees It (soft cover)	20,779
As Bill Sees It (large print)	5,939
Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers	6,259
"Pass It On"	4,998
Experience, Strength & Hope	7,896
Total	1,264,020

Booklets

The A.A. Service Manual/ Twelve Concepts for World Service	22,342
Living Sober	93,657
Living Sober (large print)	8,210
Came to Believe	28,638
Came to Believe (large print)	3,236
A.A. in Prisons: Inmate to Inmate	12,348
Total	168,431

Pamphlets

A.A. and the Armed Services	10,148
A.A. and the Gay/Lesbian Alcoholic	26,737
A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional	25,815
A.A. for the Native North American	14,703
A.A. for the Woman	68,936
The A.A. Group	78,373
A.A. in Your Community	28,971
A.A. in Correctional Facilities	15,541
A.A. in Treatment Settings	23,904
The A.A. Membership Survey	35,001
The A.A. Member — Medications and Other Drugs	75,504
A.A. Tradition — How It Developed	17,126
A.A.'s Legacy of Service	10,717
A Brief Guide to Alcoholics Anonymous	100,424
Circles of Love and Service	40,038
Bridging the Gap	24,507
Members of the Clergy Ask About A.A.	12,321
The Co-Founders of Alcoholics Anonymous	11,574
Do You Think You're Different?	79,392
Frequently Asked Questions	159,167
Frequently Asked Questions (large print)	6,277
G.S.R.	40,539
Grapevine and La Viña— Our Meetings in Print	15,391
How A.A. Members Cooperate	15,744
How It Works	50,110
If You Are a Professional	24,548
Inside A.A.	28,625
A.A. for the Black and African American Alcoholic	19,359
Is A.A. for You?	300,664
Is A.A. for Me?	88,659
Is There an Alcoholic in the Workplace?	15,515
Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?	50,852
It Happened to Alice	24,209

It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell	29,511
The Jack Alexander Article	13,549
Let's Be Friendly With Our Friends	10,666
Many Paths to Spirituality	82,390
A Member's-Eye View of A.A.	29,431
Memo to an Inmate	
Who May Be an Alcoholic	22,512
A Message to Correctional Facilities Administrators	9,993
A Newcomer Asks	262,726
Problems Other Than Alcohol	89,903
Questions and Answers on Sponsorship	239,983
Speaking at Non-A.A. Meetings	10,596
The Twelve Concepts for World Service Illustrated	27,911
The Twelve Steps Illustrated	46,856
Twelve Traditions Flyer	4,878
The Twelve Traditions Illustrated	47,375
This Is A.A.	216,841
This Is A.A. (large print)	5,721
Three Talks to Medical Societies by Bill W.	10,304
A.A. for the Older Alcoholic (Lrg Print)	38,175
Too Young?	43,850
Understanding Anonymity	58,217
What Happened to Joe	22,874
Young People and A.A.	72,335
A.A. for the Alcoholic with Special Needs	15,112
Total	2,951,100

Miscellaneous

Wallet cards-two-fold	244,981
Wallet cards-I Am Responsible	31,442
Wallet cards-Anonymity	30,088
Anonymity Display Card	2,248
Parchment-scrolls	1,583
Placards	469
C.P.C. Workbook	1,335
Archives Workbook	469
Corrections Workbook	1,122
P.I. Workbook	1,600
Treatment Facilities Workbook	1,208
Treatment Facility Kit	364
Special Needs Workbook	367
Twelve and Twelve on Computer Disk	14
A.A. Guidelines	74,383
Group Handbook	2,089
Wire Racks	1,472
Cassettes (tape cassettes)	15
Audio CDs	495
DVDs	4,357
Alcoholics Anonymous (cassette album)	10
Alcoholics Anonymous (4th Ed cassette album)	10
Alcoholics Anonymous (4th Ed CD album)	1,887
A.A. Comes of Age (CD album)	230
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (cassette album)	16
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (CD album)	891
TV Public Service Announcements	245
Radio Public Service Announcements	130
Twelve Steps Shade displays	1,295
Twelve Traditions Shade displays	1,182
Fact File	2,066
Table Top Display 12 & 12	458
Pioneers of A.A. (cassette album)	3
Pioneers of A.A. (CD album)	40
Living Sober (CD album)	253
Total	408,817
Grand Total	4,792,368

SPANISH

Books & Booklets

Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous soft cover)	9,175
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous hardcover)	7,683
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous abridged pocket size)	5,830
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous Large Print)	2,809
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous Large Print/Abridged)	1,557
Como lo ve Bill (As Bill Sees It)	3,430
A.A. llega a su mayoría de edad A.A. Comes of Age)	2,453
El Dr. Bob y los buenos veteranos (Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers)	1,675
Transmítelo (Pass it On)	2,471
Reflexiones diarias (Daily Reflections)	6,972
Viviendo sobrio (Living Sober)	10,758
El Manual de Servicios de A.A./ Doce Conceptos para el Servicio Mundial (A.A. Service Manual/Twelve Concepts)	3,276
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions)	11,677
Llegamos a creer (Came to Believe)	4,761
A.A. en prisiones de preso a preso (Inmate to Inmate)	4,711
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (pocket ed.)	2,974
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (large print)	4,298
De las tinieblas hacia la luz	3,405
Total	89,915

Pamphlets

A.A. en su comunidad (A.A. in Your Community)	6,312
44 preguntas (44 Questions)	14,246
Esto es A.A. (This is A.A.)	13,818
¿Es A.A. para usted? (Is A.A. for You?)	51,478
Hay un alcohólico en su vida? (Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?)	5,198
Carta a un preso que puede ser un alcohólico (Memo to an Inmate)	3,069
El punto de vista de un miembro de A.A. (A Member's-Eye View)	1,923
Alcohólicos Anónimos por Jack Alexander (Jack Alexander Article)	2,278
Seamos amistosos con nuestros amigos (Let's be Friendly with our Friends)	2,492
Tres charlas a sociedades médicas por Bill W. (Three Talks to Medical Societies)	2,579
Un principiante pregunta (A Newcomer Asks)	7,582
Como funciona el programa (How It Works)	2,599
Lo que le sucedió a José (What Happened to Joe)	3,730
Comprendiendo el anonimato (Understanding Anonymity)	3,564
El grupo de A.A. (The A.A. Group)	6,948
Preguntas y respuestas sobre el apadrinamiento (Questions and Answers on Sponsorship)	8,233
El miembro de A.A. — Los medicamentos y otras drogas (The A.A. Member — Medications and Other Drugs)	2,715
Las Doce Tradiciones Ilustradas (The Twelve Traditions Illustrated)	4,247
A.A. en centros de tratamiento (A.A. in Treatment Centers)	2,119

Los jóvenes y A.A. (Young People and A.A.)	7,102
La tradición de A.A. — ¿Cómo se Desarrolló? (A.A. Tradition — How It Developed)	1,687
Una breve guía a A.A. (A Brief Guide to A.A.)	7,505
A.A. en las instituciones correccionales (A.A. in Correctional Facilities)	1,465
Problemas diferentes del alcohol (Problems Other Than Alcohol)	4,658
Es mejor que estar sentado en una celda (It Sure Beats Sitting In a Cell)	4,020
¿Cómo cooperan los miembros de A.A.? (How A.A. Members Cooperate)	1,293
Dentro de A.A. (Inside A.A.)	2,466
A.A. como recurso para los profesionales de la salud (A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional)	1,819
Un ministro religioso pregunta acerca de A.A. (The Clergy Asks)	1,800
R.S.G. (G.S.R.)	1,579
¿Se cree usted diferente? (Do You Think Your Different?)	4,223
Le sucedió a Alicia (It Happened to Alice)	3,442
Hablando en reuniones no-A.A. Speaking at non-A.A. Meetings	803
A.A. para la mujer (A.A. for the Woman)	8,411
Encuesta sobre los miembros de A.A. (A.A. Membership Survey)	2,214
¿Hay un alcohólico en el lugar de trabajo? (Is there an alcoholic in the workplace?)	2,647
¿Es A.A. para mí? (Is A.A. for Me?)	9,960
A.A. para el alcohólico de edad avanzada (A.A. for the older alcoholic)	3,202
Los Doce Pasos Ilustrados (The Twelve Steps Illustrated)	3,542
Círculos de amor y servicio (Circles of Love & Service)	1,977
Uniendo las orillas (Bridging the Gap) ⁹⁵¹	
Los Doce Conceptos Ilustrados (Twelve Concepts Illustrated)	2,213
A.A. para los alcohólicos gays/lesbianas (A.A. for the Gay and Lesbian Alcoholic)	1,743
El legado de servicio de A.A. (A.A. Legacy of Service)	591
Si usted es un profesional (If you are a Professional...)	2,864
El Grapevine y La Viña de A.A. (Grapevine...Our Meeting in Print)	811
¿Demasiado joven? (Too Young?)	3,704
A.A. para el alcohólico con necesidades especiales A.A. for the Alcoholic with Special Needs	1,085
Muchas sendas hacia la espiritualidad Many Paths to Spirituality	7,040
Total	241,947

Miscellaneous

Guías (Guidelines)	7,605
Parchments, Spanish	482
Tarjetas tamaño billetera (wallet cards)	18,010
Alcohólicos Anónimos (cassette album) (Big Book on cassette)	13
Alcohólicos Anónimos (CD album) (Big Book on CD)	598
Los Doce Pasos (cassette album) (Twelve Steps on cassette)	12
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (CD album)	628
Total	27,348
Grand Total	359,210

FRENCH

Livres (Books)

Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous — format relie)	3,268
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous — format souple)	1,001
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous — format poche)	437
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous — large print)	652
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous — large print/abridged)	32
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve — format relie)	1,324
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve — format souple)	472
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve — large print)	303
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve — format poche)	585
Le Mouvement des A.A. devient Adulte (A.A. Comes of Age)	305
Reflexions de Bill (As Bill Sees It)	1,454
Reflexions Quotidiennes (Daily Reflections)	2,861
Dr Bob et les pionniers (Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers)	232
(Expérience, Force & Espoir) (Experience, Strength and Hope)	210
Transmets-Le (Pass It On)	269
Les A.A. en Prison (A.A. in Prison)	445
Total	13,850

Plaquettes (Booklets)

Nous en sommes venus à croire (Came to Believe)	1,176
Vivre... sans alcool! (Living Sober)	2,710
Le Manuel du Service et les Douze Concepts	1,235
Total	5,121

Brochures (Pamphlets)

Voici les A.A. (This is A.A.)	8,247
Les A.A.: 44 Questions (44 Questions)	1,730
Les A.A.: sont-ils pour vous? (Is A.A. for You?)	7,232
Les A.A. pour la femme (A.A. for the Woman)	903
Collaboration des membres des A.A. (How A.A. Members Cooperate)	487
Y a-t-il un Alcoolique dans Votre Milieu de travail? (Is there an alcoholic in the workplace?)	265
Le membre des A.A. face aux médicaments et à la drogue (The A.A. Member — Medications & Other Drugs)	851
Les A.A. — Article du Saturday Evening Post (The Jack Alexander Article)	118
Collaborons avec nos amis (Let's Be Friendly With Our Friends)	1,675
Questions et réponses sur le parrainage (Questions and Answers on Sponsorship)	1,662
Les A.A.: Une ressource pour les médecins (A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional)	1,584
Les A.A. dans les centres de traitement (A.A. in Treatment Facilities)	1,772
La Tradition des A.A. et son développement (A.A. Tradition/How It Developed)	487
Vous vous occupez prof. d'alcoolisme? (If You Are a Professional)	1,863
L'Histoire de Nicole (It Happened to Alice)	298
Jean face à son problème d'alcool (What Happened to Joe)	228
Les A.A. dans votre milieu (A.A. in Your Community)	998
Problèmes autres que l'alcoolisme (Problems Other Than Alcohol)	1,327
Point de vue d'un membre sur les A.A. (A Member's-Eye View of A.A.)	358

Les Douze Traditions illustrées (The Twelve Traditions Illustrated)	1,361
Les A.A. dans les établissements correctionnels (A.A. in Correctional Facilities)	271
Ça vaut mieux que de languir en prison (It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell)	1,174
Petit guide pratique sur les A.A. (A Brief Guide to A.A.)	1,153
Les membres du clergé se renseignent (Members of the Clergy Ask About A.A.)	210
Les deux fondateurs d'A.A. (The Co-founders of A.A.)	554
Message à l'intention d'un détenu (Memo to an Inmate)	336
Message aux Dir. d'Etabl. Correctionnels (Message to Correctional Facilities Administrators)	47
Le groupe des A.A. (The A.A. Group)	1,650
Les Douze Concepts illustrés (Twelve Concepts Illustrated)	1,307
Le sens de l'anonymat (Understanding Anonymity)	3,686
Trois causeries à des sociétés médicales (Three Talks to Medical Societies)	190
Y a-t-il un alcoolique dans votre vie? (Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?)	984
Le R.S.G. (The G.S.R.)	1,279
Causeries à l'extérieur des A.A. (Speaking at Non-A.A. Meetings)	325
Trop jeune? (Too Young?)	1,135
La Structure de l'Association des A.A. (Inside A.A.)	1,216
L'Héritage des Services des A.A. (A.A.'s Legacy of Service)	204
Cercles d'amour et de service (Circles of Love & Service)	1,838
Vous croyez-vous différent? (Do You Think You're Different?)	870
Sondage sur les membres des A.A. (The A.A. Membership Survey)	2,475
Les jeunes et les A.A. (Young People & A.A.)	968
Votre B.S.G. (Your G.S.O.)	1,125
A.A. pour l'alcoolique plus âgé (A.A. for the older alcoholic)	1,010
Un nouveau veut savoir (A Newcomer Asks)	4,790
Les A.A. sont-ils pour moi? (Is A.A. for Me?)	1,193
Favoriser de rapprochement (Bridging the Gap)	88
Les Douze Etapes illustrées (Twelve Steps Illustrated)	1,631
Les A.A. et les gais et lesbiennes alcooliques (A.A. for the Gay and Lesbian Alcoholic)	698
Les A.A. et les Autochtones d'Amérique du Nord (A.A. and the Native North American)	108
Pour L'alcoolique Besoins Spéciaux (A.A. for the Alcoholic with Special Needs)	600
Différentes avenues la spiritualité (Many Paths to Spirituality)	8,300
Lignes de conduite A.A. (Guidelines)	1,692
Total	76,553

Divers (Miscellaneous)

12 & 12 (cassette album)	0
12 & 12 (CD album)	217
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (CD album)	297
Carte 12 Etapes/12 Traditions (Wallet card 12 Steps & 12 Traditions)	1,390
Carte anonymat (Français/anglais) (Anonymity wallet card)	450
Carte Je Suis Responsable (I am responsible wallet card)	401
Video Cassettes	0
DVDS	18
Notre Méthode (How It Works)	12,070
Manuel de Groupe	41
Pochette de l'Information Publique	26
Pochette des Centres de Detention	26
Pochette de la CMP	82
Prière de la Sérénité (12x16) (Parchment Serenity Prayer)	46
Pochette des Centres de Traitement	28
Dossier d'Information sur les A.A. (Fact File)	103
Total	15,195
Grand Total	110,719

A.A. GRAPEVINE, INC.

Directors' report: A.A. Grapevine, Inc. is one of two affiliate corporations of the General Service Board and the multimedia publisher of Grapevine magazine content, available on various platforms and in a variety of formats. A.A. Grapevine, Inc. also publishes Spanish-language content in La Viña magazine and its related book, CD and audio formats, as well as Spanish-language web pages on aagrapevine.org.

By charter, the A.A. Grapevine Board consists of seven to ten directors. Since the 65th Conference, there have been eight directors: two general service trustees; two regional trustees; three nontrustee directors; and the executive editor/publisher. Because of the sudden loss of our dear friend and general service trustee, Ed Martin, soon after last year's Conference, the board operated with seven directors for the better part of the year and up until this Conference. As Bill W. wrote about Dr. Bob in 1950: "Nor would he have us praise him or grieve his passing..." (*The Co-Founders of A.A.: Dr. Bob & Bill W.* p. 3-4). Bill imagined that Dr. Bob could be heard saying: "...I was just another alcoholic trying to get along — under the Grace of God." (*ibid.* p. 4) We can imagine Ed saying something similar.

The purpose of the Grapevine Corporate Board is to serve the A.A. Fellowship in the following ways:

- To oversee the publishing operations of A.A. Grapevine, Inc.
- To provide sound financial management of the corporation.
- To establish corporate policies and set corporate priorities.
- To engage in the ongoing process of strategic planning.
- To operate in accordance with the principles of A.A. as expressed in the Twelve Steps, Twelve Traditions, and Twelve Concepts.

The board strives to engage the Fellowship, to ensure members' awareness of the various uses for the tools provided to help carry the message!

The A.A. Grapevine Board met in person seven times since the last Conference and once via an all-day teleconference. In 2015-2016, two standing committees were active: the Nominating Committee, chaired by Bill Farnsworth, facilitated all facets in the selection of candidates for board openings and selecting a general service trustee; the Finance & Budget Committee, chaired by Joel Castellaw, provided oversight for the budget process. Three ad hoc committees were continued: the Governance Committee, chaired by Bill Farnsworth; the Grass Roots Committee, chaired by Ed Martin; and the Carry the Message Committee, chaired by Lynda Bergeron. The A.A. Grapevine Board changed its committee structure: (1) expanding the scope of the Nominating Committee to include the items handled by the ad hoc Governance Committee; and (2) combining the ad hoc Grass Roots and Carry the Message Committees into one new ad hoc Outreach Committee for 2015. The Editorial Advisory Board, consisting of members with particular

expertise in media, met five times, always by teleconference in 2015.

Since the last Conference, A.A. Grapevine, Inc. has produced 12 issues of Grapevine, six issues of La Viña, an annual wall calendar and pocket planner, and three ebooks. La Viña magazine continues to be published in 64 pages in response to the 2010 Conference Advisory Action to maintain spiritual parity with Grapevine magazine.

A.A. Grapevine, Inc. distributed 103,193 Grapevine and La Viña books, CDs, and other items, including the two latest book titles: *Forming True Partnerships* featuring stories by A.A. members about the many ways members use the Twelve Steps, sponsorship, and the tools of the program to improve and repair relationships, old and new and commemorative editions of *Happy, Joyous and Free* were published in English, Spanish and French for the International Convention to mark A.A.'s 80th year. La Viña launched an opt-in text messaging effort in August 2015 to better connect with the Spanish-speaking Fellowship.

Circulation — Grapevine's average monthly print circulation was 71,966 in fiscal year 2015 (this is more than budget by 2,405 and less than 2014 by 2,034). The Grapevine Online (GVO) averaged 5,233 subscribers in 2015. The average bimonthly circulation of La Viña was 10,355 (this is 252 less than budget and 116 below 2014 levels).

Operations — During 2015, A.A. Grapevine continued operational cost-control measures resulting in expenses coming in under budget.

Financial — Complete and audited financial details for 2015 are included in the Conference Manual and *Final Conference Report*. Here is an overview:

- Grapevine ended 2015 with net income of \$245,204 against budgeted net loss of \$14,614.
- Gross profit for the magazine and subscription products reached \$1,432,614. Gross Profit on the magazine was ahead of budget by \$14,367.
- Gross Profit on books and related items was \$505,806.
- Overhead Costs were budgeted at \$1,961,235 versus an actual of \$1,733,336. This was a savings of \$227,899. This savings occurred mainly in Website Expenses and General and Administrative Expenses.

La Viña — La Viña is published by A.A. Grapevine, Inc., with expenses not covered by income funded by the General Service Board as a service to the Fellowship. La Viña had an average circulation of 10,350 per issue. Gross Profit on the magazine was \$63,160. This is ahead of budget by \$6,187. Gross Profit on Related Items was ahead of budget by \$782, and overhead was under budget by \$4,252. The net difference between revenue and expenses for 2015 was \$146,378, or \$13,073 less than was budgeted.

A.A. Grapevine and the Reserve Fund — A.A. Grapevine maintains a balance in the Reserve Fund to fund its unfulfilled subscription liability. The balance at December 31, 2015 was \$1,943,500, and the actual subscription liability

as of that date was \$1,873,708, meaning that the liability is overfunded. In March 2016, A.A. Grapevine, Inc. will be making a transfer of \$260,000 into the Reserve Fund. This is the third consecutive year in which A.A. Grapevine, Inc. was able to make a substantial transfer of excess working capital to the Reserve Fund. The A.A. Grapevine Board continues to be deeply grateful to the staff for these tremendous achievements.

Website — The website was updated to better serve the Fellowship and to engage a wider and more diverse audience; it remains central to Grapevine's current and future plans. Month end December 2015 reports indicate that an average of 41,917 unique visitors visit an average of 3.37 pages on aagrapevine.org each month. A dedicated Subscription Challenge web page provided monthly updated information about states', provinces' and territories' growth in subscriptions on a percentage basis throughout the year. The states with the greatest percentage growth in new paid subscriptions and subscription gift certificates were Missouri (for GV) and Delaware (for LV). These states will have a special section in a respective 2016 issue of Grapevine or La Viña featuring members' stories from that state, province or territory.

A dedicated audio page for Grapevine's audio offerings was created for the website, including a showcase for the Audio Project, featuring up to seven-minutes long recorded stories submitted by members; 261 audio stories have been received and are in the process of being archived. Two members' audio stories are offered online as samples.

Grapevine continues to produce a complimentary Grapevine Daily Quote, featuring excerpts drawn from the archives of classic Grapevine literature. Selections are posted daily on aagrapevine.org and may be requested on an opt-in basis for daily email delivery. Subscriptions number 39,368 as of February 2016.

Grapevine and La Viña subscribers are committed to the print magazine as an invaluable Twelfth Step tool and for personal use. In keeping with the Fellowship's desire and support, the print publications will continue. At the same time, Grapevine's online offerings continue to attract new subscribers with few conversions from print. AAGrapevine.org has become the premiere connection with the Fellowship; the majority of subscriptions/purchases now occur online, and digital communications are both effective and cost saving. About 25% of A.A.G.V.'s online subscribers opt for both the online services and the print magazine. Offered as a bundle, the Grapevine Online subscription provides unlimited access to previously unpublished stories, Audio Grapevine, the Story Archive and the current online issues of both Grapevine and La Viña.

At current prices, GV's basic online subscription costs subscribers about ten cents a day, and the print subscription is eight cents per day. The GV Board and management team's efforts continue to broaden awareness of the magazines, books, audio and website to carry the message

through an expanded subscriber base. The Subscription Challenge outreach effort, limited Fellowship New Vision (FNV) list-sharing efforts with A.A.W.S., subscription and book offers on the International Convention registration form have contributed to the growth of subscriptions. The Grapevine Board is seeking to expand these efforts, including seeking new connections through opt-in choices on local, state and regional roundups, convention or conference registrations. Organization-wide support is essential to the continued health of A.A.G.V., Inc. and has been the subject of many discussions with both the G.S.B. and A.A.W.S. boards.

The A.A.G.V. Board and management team are committed to self-support and A.A. Grapevine, Inc.'s continued financial vitality, with member support, while growing and evolving. The focus on financial health as demonstrated throughout 2015 will continue in 2016. It is understood that cost reduction represents only one piece of the break-even formula, while new approaches to additional revenue are equally important. In addition, the Grapevine Board is considering for 2016 and 2017:

- Launching the Grapevine subscription app.
- Working with A.A.W.S. to identify efficiencies.
- Celebrating La Viña's 20th anniversary through a dedicated engagement effort
- Launching the Grow Your Grapevine effort in March 2016.
- Introducing regional pages to the website.
- Updating the GVR/RLV interface online.
- Reviewing international shipping vendor relationship.
- Incorporating video and audio on the Grapevine subscription app.
- Continue expanding communications with groups directly through broader use of group contact information provided through Fellowship New Vision (FNV).
- Exploring the use of opt-in selections on local roundup, convention and conference registration forms for those who wish to receive Grapevine email messages.
- Offering existing GV CD content in MP3 formats.
- Expanding the digital subscriber base and communications.
- Providing a rewarding and supportive work environment for staff, including training and development in line with stated objectives.

As a mirror of the membership, Grapevine both reflects and belongs to the Fellowship. For more than seven decades, Grapevine has conveyed the "Voices of A.A." as a tool for many in recovery, evolving over time and reliably carrying the message to anyone who reaches out for the hand of A.A. Should the Fellowship desire that Grapevine and La Viña continue into the future — for alcoholics and friends, many of whom may not know about A.A. yet — additional subscribers will be required. Organization-wide support for A.A. Grapevine, Inc. is integral to this effort, to our history and to our future.

Albin Zenáta, chairperson

Books

Best of Bill — Hard Cover (Discontinued)	14
Best of Bill (Soft Cover)	5,287
Best of Bill (Large Print)	937
Best of The Grapevine I — Soft Cover	269
The Language of the Heart (Hard Cover)	2,853
El Lenguaje del Corazón	2,483
A.A. Around the World (Soft Cover)	287
The Language of the Heart (Soft Cover)	2,529
Thank You For Sharing (Soft Cover)	533
Spiritual Awakening (Soft Cover)	2,245
The Home Group Revised (Soft Cover)	831
I Am Responsible: The Hand of AA (Soft Cover)	618
Emotional Sobriety (Soft Cover)	5,524
Language of the Heart (Large Print)	676
In Our Own Words	692
Beginners Book	3,163
Voices of Long-Term Sobriety	1,163
A Rabbit Walks Into a Bar	2,225
Spiritual Awakenings Vol II	1,073
Step By Step (Soft Cover)	2,004
Emotional Sobriety II (Soft Cover)	3,033
Young & Sober	1,721
Into Action	1,474
Happy, Joyous & Free	10,489
Happy, Joyous & Free — Fr & Sp	3,511
One on One	2,615
No Matter What	2,600
Grapevine Daily Quote Book	5,328
Sober & Out	1,475
Forming True Partnerships	4,888
Best of Bill — French (Soft Cover)	1,322
The Home Group — French (Soft Cover)	201
Le Langage Du Coeur	278
En Tete a Tete	969
Best Of Bill — Spanish (Soft Cover)	2,476
Lo Mejor de la Viña	965
El Grupo Base	1,344

Total: 80,095

E-books

Language of the Heart	1,043
Best of Bill	852
Lo Mejor de Bill	62
Step by Step	76
Emotional Sobriety I	882
Emotional Sobriety II	268
Spiritual Awakenings I	115
Spiritual Awakenings II	61
Young & Sober	20
Into Action	33
Happy, Joyous & Free	113
Forming True Partnerships	141
Other	679

Total: 4,345

CDs - English

2,164

CDs - Spanish

1,777

Total: 3,941

Miscellaneous

16,022

Grand Total 104,403

GRAPEVINE SUBSCRIPTIONS* — GEOGRAPHICAL BREAKDOWN

	APRIL 2016	APRIL 2015	INCREASE/ DECREASE
UNITED STATES*			
Alabama	507	525	(18)
Alaska	377	410	(33)
Arizona	1,508	1,474	34
Arkansas	326	378	(52)
California	6,595	6,542	53
Colorado	1,244	1,298	(54)
Connecticut	1,083	951	132
Delaware	273	299	(26)
District of Columbia	109	150	(41)
Florida	3,999	3,971	28
Georgia	1,675	1,719	(44)
Hawaii	413	356	57
Idaho	492	500	(8)
Illinois	2,106	2,257	(151)
Indiana	1,052	1,050	2
Iowa	639	642	(3)
Kansas	660	681	(21)
Kentucky	550	590	(40)
Louisiana	487	555	(68)
Maine	411	434	(23)
Maryland	836	957	(121)
Massachusetts	1,584	1,675	(91)
Michigan	2,198	2,269	(71)
Minnesota	1,804	1,791	13
Mississippi	255	306	(51)
Missouri	1,475	1,161	314
Montana	463	426	37
Nebraska	576	603	(27)
Nevada	722	654	68
New Hampshire	476	433	43
New Jersey	1,945	2,014	(69)
New Mexico	461	446	15
New York	3,930	3,873	57
North Carolina	1,735	1,759	(24)
North Dakota	283	288	(5)
Ohio	1,659	1,803	(144)
Oklahoma	481	540	(59)
Oregon	1,180	1,151	29
Pennsylvania	3,763	3,877	(114)
Rhode Island	311	236	75
South Carolina	611	639	(28)
South Dakota	238	244	(6)
Tennessee	704	721	(17)
Texas	2,623	2,645	(22)
Utah	432	371	61
Vermont	268	257	11
Virginia	1,650	1,669	(19)
Washington	1,953	2,056	(103)
West Virginia	262	271	(9)
Wisconsin	1,744	1,681	63
Wyoming	197	204	(7)
Puerto Rico	15	19	(4)
U.S. Possessions/APO	41	49	(8)
Virgin Islands	32	34	(2)
Subtotal US	61,413	61,904	(491)
CANADA			
Alberta/NWT	633	714	(81)
British Columbia/YKN	845	856	(11)
Manitoba	296	274	22
New Brunswick/PEI	223	208	15
Nova Scotia/ Newfoundland/Labrador	257	290	(33)
Ontario	2,545	2,671	(126)
Quebec	242	243	(1)
Saskatchewan	295	300	(5)
Subtotal CANADA	5,336	5,556	(220)
FOREIGN*			
	643	669	(26)
Grand Total	67,392	68,129	(737)
LA VIÑA SUBSCRIPTIONS*			
	Mar./Apr. '15 7,955	Mar./Apr. '14 7,893	Diff. 62

(*does not include monthly orders)

■ Trustees' Committees and G.S.O. and Grapevine Reports

ARCHIVES

Trustees' report: The trustees' Archives Committee was established by the General Service Board, and held its first meeting in October 1973. This committee is responsible for developing and implementing the policies that govern the Archives services. The committee makes recommendations to the General Service Board on Archives procedures and budget. Through its group conscience, and guided by A.A.'s principles and professional standards, the committee undertakes and upholds its responsibility and authority for the maintenance and use of the Archives.

The committee supports the G.S.O. Archives' commitment to permit access to members of Alcoholics Anonymous and others for research purposes. The committee, since the 2015 General Service Conference, granted permission to eight researchers for use of archival material. The permission also included access to archival audio recordings for limited use. Each request is carefully considered through recommendations from the Archivist and established Archives policies. The permission to conduct research is granted conditional on a signed agreement to strictly maintain the anonymity of all members, alive and deceased, including A.A.'s cofounders.

At the committee's first meeting in August, we made our annual review of the History and Actions and noted some significant actions and Archives policies. We reviewed the report and Committee Considerations of the 2015 Conference Archives Committee.

A subcommittee was formed to review the Archives policy and form entitled: "Deed of Gift." A revised policy that includes a new section for accepting collections with electronic records, as well as changes prompted by an attorney's legal review, was approved at the January meeting. The committee also reviewed the Archives Classified Records Policy and made no changes.

We discussed, and agreed to forward to the 2016 Conference Committee on Archives, a request to explore ways to encourage groups to write or update their histories. The committee also discussed the importance of reaching out to members of the Fellowship who may have significant historical collections, or know of someone in possession of one, that may want to share it with G.S.O. Archives. The committee discussed the many different demographics of A.A.'s members, and how G.S.O.'s archives collection might embrace and disseminate material that demonstrates A.A.'s inclusiveness.

We reviewed the Archives "Sound and Moving Image Policy and Procedures" and requested that the Archivist prepare background concerning the cost of migrating a moving image file format in its current state to an accessible format for users, for further discussion in July 2016. The Archivist will also provide a list of titles held in the Moving Image Collection and respective copyright information, where available. The committee also requested the Archivist to identify portions of the policy that may need revision.

Throughout the year, we were kept apprised of projects executed by the Archives staff, as well as tabulated research inquiries handled by the staff. The Archivist also informed the committee of projected goals outlined for the upcoming year. The committee is extremely grateful to our talented Archivist and her staff for their continuing efforts to properly preserve A.A.'s historical materials, to respond to the Fellowship's many requests and to provide useful background information to its trusted servants when the needs arise.

Michele Grinberg, chairperson

Archivist's report: The mission of the General Service Office Archives is to permanently document the work of Alcoholics Anonymous, to make the history of the organization accessible to A.A. members and other researchers, and to provide a context for understanding A.A.'s progression, principles and traditions. The Archives staff assumes full ownership of the material under our care. This means that we exercise professional judgment in acquiring, appraising, organizing, preserving, securing and managing the vast array of historical material we oversee.

The Archives staff provides resource material and service to A.A. members, researchers and others about A.A. history, responds to worldwide information requests, and offers professional support to local areas, districts or groups interested in researching their history. In 2015, we responded to over 1,300 requests for information, utilizing a combination of unpublished primary sources and published material maintained in the repository. We welcomed new local archivists and committee chairs serving either in the area or district position and furnished each individual with an Archives Workbook, Guidelines and other resources.

We endeavor to raise awareness of A.A.'s history and archives through our electronic newsletter, *Markings: Your Archives eNewsletter*. The newsletter is published three times a year, in English, Spanish and French, and delivered to subscribers via A.A.'s digital delivery system.

The Archives exhibit space at the Atlanta International Convention was an outstanding success. The specially designed exhibits included timelines of the founding of A.A., and of the publication of the Big Book; exhibits on the history of Young People in A.A., of past International Conventions, of Special Needs and much more. We also had a theater room featuring *Markings on the Journey* and *Bill's Own Story*, which was filled to capacity throughout the Convention week. Letters were sent to all the International Convention Archives volunteers, thanking them for their dedicated service in assisting our numerous visitors and tirelessly answering their questions.

We have been reporting on our ongoing multiyear project that involves the development of the Archives audio catalog. This project, which commenced in 2012, requires listening to many thousands of recordings of oldtimers, early friends of A.A. and others. The collection includes

a series of oral history interviews conducted by Bill W. in the 1950s, talks of significant early friends who supported the fledgling Fellowship and other valuable recordings. Thus far, we have completed cataloging over 3,000 recordings. The final phase in the project, scheduled to begin in January 2016, includes cataloging the General Service Conference recordings from 1960 through 1970.

Another ongoing project instituted in 2013 entailed the scanning of early group correspondence from the United States, Canada and around the world (1940s through 1950s). The scanning assistant has digitized thousands of letters from states Alabama through Ohio. The original letters are being preserved for permanent storage in the Archives' secured offsite facility while user copies are maintained onsite. We anticipate a completion date of this project by December 2016. We also conducted a most extensive inventory of the G.S.O. Reference Room, which houses hundreds of binders containing background documents from trustees' and Conference committees and other reference material. We also accepted over 60 cubic feet of material from various offices as a result of the construction.

In keeping with our mission, the Archives associate archivists and senior archivist worked with several personal collections and papers to preserve, arrange and create Finding-Aids. One collection includes the papers of Gary Glynn, trustee emeritus of the General Service Board. Another collection of material was donated by Joan Jackson, former Class A trustee. The Archives staff also processed papers from two former G.S.O. staff.

Archives staff continues to develop the "Archives and History" portal of the A.A. website. We added three new clips to the Archives audio library that included brief portions of the following: Bill W.'s 1965 talk at A.A.'s 30th Anniversary Convention; an interview with Sister Ignatia conducted by Bill W. in 1954; and Sister Ignatia's talk at A.A.'s 25th Anniversary Convention in 1960. We also updated the A.A. Timeline, adding new entries for the years 2009 through 2015, and created a new digital exhibit on A.A.'s 10th Anniversary Celebration. The staff also worked on curating a series of new exhibitions in the Archives exhibit room. The wall exhibit was refreshed to show the individual journeys of Bill and Dr. Bob followed by the beginning of the Fellowship through building services to others.

None of this work would be possible without the help of a very capable team of archivists, working to ensure that we fulfill our mission and goals.

Finally, the Archives staff extends gratitude to those members and others who have generously donated material to the Archives within the past twelve months.

Michelle Mirza, archivist

AUDIT COMMITTEE

Trustees' report: The trustees' Audit Committee, formed by the General Service Board in 2003, is composed of a

minimum of three and a maximum of five trustees who are appointed by the chairman of the General Service Board. The committee was created as a proactive measure to assist the General Service Board in fulfilling its fiduciary obligation of Prudent Corporate Governance.

The committee meets at least twice a year with the outside auditor and G.S.O. and Grapevine management; separately with the auditor; and in executive session without the auditor. The Audit Committee reports to the General Service Board and reviews such items as audit process, audit results, internal controls, best accounting practices, and management integrity. The Audit Committee also recommends appointment of the auditor to the board.

David Morris, chairperson

COMMUNICATION SERVICES

Staff report: G.S.O. offers an A.A. website, www.aa.org, to serve the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous as a resource for A.A. members, those seeking help from A.A., professionals working with alcoholics, the media, and the public at large. G.S.O.'s website provides accurate and consistent information about A.A., provides details about services coordinated by G.S.O. and encourages participation of A.A. members, groups and committees in A.A. services and activities.

The Communication Services staff member serves as the liaison for information about G.S.O.'s A.A. website, collecting feedback on design and content from visitors to the website; chairing G.S.O.'s Intra-Office Website Committee; and collaborating with G.S.O.'s Digital Media manager to continually update and improve www.aa.org. Collected experience regarding local website committees is shared from this desk upon request.

This staff member serves as secretary to the A.A.W.S. Technology/Communication/ Services Committee, and prepares Website Activity Reports to the A.A.W.S. Board and the Conference Committee on Public Information.

In September, the Communication Services staff member attended the second annual National A.A. Technology Workshop, first held in August 2014 to provide a forum to gather, share and seek solutions to technology-related issues faced by local A.A. members, groups and service entities.

Rick Walker

COMPENSATION COMMITTEE

Trustees' report: The trustees' Compensation Committee, formed in 2006 by the General Service Board, consists of at least four trustees. The committee was created as a proactive measure to assist the General Service Board in fulfilling its fiduciary obligation of Prudent Corporate Governance.

The Compensation Committee reports to the General Service Board and reviews and advises A.A. World Services, Inc. and A.A. Grapevine, Inc. on such items as overall compensation philosophies and policies, best compensation practices, and compliance with the IRS for executive com-

pensation for nonprofit organizations.

This past year, the Compensation Committee reviewed the retiree medical benefits for A.A.W.S., Inc. and A.A. Grapevine, Inc., and made a recommendation to the corporate boards to discontinue offering retiree medical benefits for new employees.

The committee worked with A.A.W.S. and AAGV to obtain the services of Astron Solutions to prepare compensation studies for the highest paid executives in each corporation. The committee received the reports and met with Astron Solutions via teleconference. The reports indicated that all salaries reviewed are within reasonable levels and do not represent excessive compensation.

William Noonan, chair

CONFERENCE

Trustees' report: The committee met three times since the 2015 General Service Conference. During that period we worked on all Advisory Actions and Additional Committee Considerations pertaining to the General Service Conference and discussed all proposed Agenda items pertaining to the 2016 Conference. In reviewing our Composition, Scope and Procedure, we elaborated on procedure number 7, changing "Selecting by lot, first-term delegate members on each Conference committee, within established practices," to "Selecting by lot, within well-established practices that account for rotation, regional mix, gender mix and committee size, and the first-term delegate members on each Conference committee."

We reviewed the summaries of the 2015 Evaluation Questionnaires, notes from the G.S.O. sharing session, along with a comparison of numerical ratings from the past five Conference Evaluation Summaries, and discussed a Consideration asking that we develop a report on providing the GSC Evaluation Form in an anonymous digital format, in addition to the current paper format. We reviewed some sample options for conducting digital surveys, and tabled discussion until the July meeting, so that staff can develop background which will include cost and time savings to the office, and details related to the exploration of practical factors related to implementation of a digital survey.

We discussed the Electronic Voting Trial Evaluation Summary and made suggestions regarding the orientation process for electronic voting at the 2016 General Service Conference. In 2017 we will provide the Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions with a report evaluating electronic voting using data gathered at the 2015 and 2016 General Service Conferences.

The committee acknowledged changes to the usual Conference week schedule that were made in order to accommodate a request from the General Service Board for time on the agenda to obtain sharing from all Conference members on the Board's Feasibility Report. In another matter related to schedule, we referred to G.S.O. staff, with our strong support, a request from the A.A. Grapevine Board that there be an A.A. Grapevine presen-

tation at every General Service Conference.

We incorporated consideration of a request from A.A.W.S., Inc. to modify the deadline for receipt of proposed Conference agenda items to September 15, with a provision that all agenda items be approved by the November Board Weekend, into our response to a Conference Advisory Action asking that we create a plan to translate all Conference material. The completed translation plans were forwarded to the 2016 Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions. In addition, we forwarded to the Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions a proposal for all Conference members to receive the same background material, with the exception of digital media and works in progress.

The committee was pleased to forward to the Conference Committee on Policy and Admissions a request for two persons from A.A. in the Ukraine to attend the 2016 General Service Conference. However, we took no action on a request from Adult Children of Alcoholics (ACA) to observe the 2016 General Service Conference, instead asking that the Conference Policy/Admissions Committee consider the over-arching concept of admitting representatives from the service structure of other Twelve Step Fellowships to observe our General Service Conference.

We studied over 300 pages of background and reflected and shared at length over the Consideration asking us to fully explore the potential role that the Conference Agenda Committee might play in the selection process of Agenda items. Our conclusion was that there is no potential role for the Conference Agenda Committee to play in the agenda item selection process; our sharing raised a number of questions that are contained in our final report. In conjunction with this topic, we reviewed two requests regarding voting privileges of the delegate chairs and the selection of the final Conference agenda items, and took no action, finding both proposals to be in conflict with the principles of trust and participation reflected in our Concepts and the Conference Charter.

The committee also took no action on a request to "...consider the development of an Armed Services Conference Committee (with establishment of corresponding Armed Services General Service Board Committee and General Service Office Armed Services staff position). However, we have great interest in this subject and have asked that the General Service Office explore this issue in depth and report back to us.

The committee also discussed and forwarded to the A.A.W.S. Board for their consideration a request that an A.A. Guideline be prepared that lays out what Young People in A.A. (YPAA) is, how it operates, what its relationship to the Fellowship and the service structure might be, and how young people would go about finding and joining their area YPAA.

We also forwarded to the General Service Board a request to review, as part of their policy regarding the role of delegate chairs at the Winter Board Meeting, what is provided to delegate chairpersons attending their corresponding trustees' committee meeting.

Andrew Ware, chairperson



COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY/ TREATMENT AND ACCESSIBILITIES

Staff report: The Conference coordinator is the G.S.O. contact for General Service Conference members. The Conference process continues throughout the year and the coordinator corresponds regularly with all Conference members to make the annual Conference responsive to the needs of the Fellowship. The annual meeting of the General Service Conference, which first met in April 1951, is the closest thing A.A. has to a group conscience in the U.S. and Canada.

A.A. members are encouraged to submit topics through their area structures for consideration by the Conference. Suggested topics may be forwarded to a trustees' committee for consideration and, where appropriate, referred directly to a Conference committee. Occasionally topics are submitted that are more appropriately under the purview of either the A.A.W.S. or Grapevine Boards. These items are accordingly forwarded to those boards for their attention. The Conference coordinator is responsible for:

- Serving as secretary to the Conference Agenda Committee and the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference.
- Assembling suggestions for the Conference theme and presentation/discussion and workshop topics that are reviewed by the Conference Agenda Committee, which makes selections that are recommended to the Conference for approval.
- Working with the G.S.O. staff and general manager on planning and coordinating each phase of the Conference.
- Scheduling and assembling for translation all reports and other information for the Conference Manual; and, with the guidance of the Publishing Department, the summer edition of *Box 4-5-9* and the *Conference Final Report*.
- The Conference coordinator cooperates with the G.S.O. IT personnel to develop and maintain necessary digital platforms as the means used by the office to transmit all Conference information, reference material and background to Conference members.

Mary Clare Lynch

Trustees' report: The trustees' Committees on Cooperation With the Professional Community and Treatment Facilities were combined by action of the General Service Board in April 1998. Then, in August of 2009, the trustees' committee expanded its scope to include service to Special Needs-Accessibilities Committees and oversight of Special Needs literature. The title of the committee was changed to Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities in 2009. In November of

2015 "Special Needs" was removed from the name of the trustees' Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities and throughout the committee's Composition, Scope and Procedure. Since the 2015 General Service Conference, the trustees' committee has met three times.

Cooperation With the Professional Community (C.P.C.) — The committee undertook the following tasks this past year:

- Reviewed the 2015 C.P.C. Conference Committee's suggested changes to the C.P.C. Workbook and requested that the staff secretary submit changes to the Publishing department for the next printing.
- Reviewed an Additional Committee Consideration regarding reading and reviewing the current selection of pamphlets in the C.P.C. Kit and appointed a subcommittee to review the pamphlets, focusing on those that fall under the purview of Cooperation With the Professional Community. The trustees later expanded the scope of the subcommittee to include:
 - Development of service material on A.A. as a resource for the mental health professional.
 - Ensure that any still-relevant information from the pamphlet "Three Talks to Medical Societies by Bill W." is captured in other A.A. literature.
- Throughout the year, the trustees' committee reviewed progress reports from the Subcommittee on Reading and Reviewing C.P.C. Pamphlets as well as an area request regarding a proposed change to a pamphlet and agreed to forward to the 2016 Conference C.P.C. Committee the following:
 - A recommendation that the pamphlet "Three Talks to Medical Societies by Bill W." be retired because the pamphlet is too lengthy and dated.
 - Text changes to the pamphlet "How A.A. Members Cooperate with Professionals."
 - Text be added to the pamphlet "If You are a Professional..." to clarify that A.A. members do not give medical advice.
 - Text be added to the introduction of the pamphlet "Is

There an Alcoholic in the Workplace?” to clarify that A.A. can cooperate with employers of any size, including small businesses such as medical practices, etc.

- A matrix of subcommittee comments regarding pamphlets in the C.P.C. Kit be provided to the Conference C.P.C. Committee for their review of the C.P.C. Kit and Workbook.
- Agreed with the subcommittee suggestions to have the secretary work with the Publishing department to:
 - Develop service material to replace the pamphlet “Three Talks to Medical Societies by Bill W.”
 - Incorporate content from the pamphlet “Let’s Be Friendly With Our Friends” into the C.P.C. Workbook to preserve its important historical context for A.A. members involved in C.P.C. service work.
 - Develop service material on A.A. as a resource for the mental health professional using input from a Class A trustee in that profession.
- Requested that the secretary send a memo to the trustees’ committees on Public Information and Literature with the notes from the 2015 Conference C.P.C. Committee outlining their discussion regarding pamphlets that fall under the purview of those committees.
- Reviewed the methods used to evaluate the process and outcomes of exhibiting and presenting at national professional conferences and agreed to continue discussion at their July 2016 meeting. The committee noted that professionals access information online and requested that G.S.O. consider posting pamphlet content for professionals directly on aa.org instead of in PDF format.

Treatment and Accessibilities — The trustees’ committee reviewed the report of the 2015 Conference Committee on Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities and noted the following:

- The request to the A.A.W.S. Board to consider posting contents of A.A. literature items produced in audio formats on G.S.O.’s website, aa.org, was forwarded to the Technology/Communication/Services Committee of the A.A.W.S. Board.
- The consideration to publish a service piece of the Twelve Concepts for World Service in American Sign Language (ASL) was reviewed by the Publishing department as a pending project.
- The report on exploring ways to provide electronic versions of the Workbooks and other material in the Kits to committee chairs as an alternative to automatically mailing hard copies was reviewed. The committee recognized the A.A.W.S. Board’s request that G.S.O. management develop and report on a plan for consistent delivery of all service workbooks and kits in the most efficient and effective manner.
- The Conference committee’s suggested changes to the Treatment Kit and Workbook and changes to the Special Needs-Accessibilities Kit and Workbook

were forwarded to the A.A.W.S. Publishing department.

- In consideration of the request regarding how to better realize the commitment to make A.A. more readily available to all and agreeing with the need to focus on the concept of overcoming barriers in accessing, receiving, and carrying the A.A. message, rather than the limiting concept of identifying “special needs,” the committee:
 - Reviewed the staff secretary’s report on appropriate and effective vernacular for the name of the trustee’s Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities.
 - Appointed a Subcommittee on Making A.A. More Readily Available to All to work on a revision of the committee’s scope and to consider how to move forward on revising and reorganizing the Special Needs-Accessibilities Workbook.
 - In response to the subcommittee progress report the trustees’ committee recommended to the General Service Board and the board approved, that “Special Needs” be removed from the name of the trustees’ Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities and throughout the committee’s Composition, Scope and Procedure. The committee agreed to forward to the 2016 Conference Committee on Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities a suggestion that “Special Needs” be removed from their committee name and throughout their Composition, Scope and Procedure.
 - The trustees’ committee reviewed a request to change the committee name of “Special Needs-Accessibilities” to “Accessibilities and Accommodations” and took no action and noted that they had already agreed to change the trustees’ committee name.
 - The committee requested that the staff secretary work with the Publishing department on title revisions of committee service pieces and Conference-approved literature.



The Special Needs-Accessibilities Workbook and the service piece, "Serving Alcoholics with Special Needs" will be revised as specified in the subcommittee report. The workbook will be reviewed by the trustees' committee at their July 2016 meeting. In addition the committee reviewed the pamphlet "A.A. for the Alcoholic with Special Needs" and requested that the staff secretary work with the Publishing department to remove "Special Needs" throughout the pamphlet and bring back a draft revision replacing these words with alternative phrasing where needed. The committee also requested that the Publishing department prepare an inventory for the committee of all A.A. material that uses the phrase "Special Needs."

- The trustees' committee reviewed two requests to update the pamphlet "Bridging the Gap" and took no action noting the 2014 Conference Committee on Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities consideration regarding this pamphlet.

Joel Castellaw, chairperson

Staff reports:

Cooperation With the Professional Community — Experience indicates that many professionals are aware of A.A., yet relatively few know what A.A. is or what it is not. It appears that even fewer have been to an "open" A.A. meeting. The staff member on the Cooperation With the Professional Community (C.P.C.) assignment, along with an assistant, provides information about A.A. and facilitates communication with those outside A.A. who may have direct contact with the still-suffering alcoholic through their professional work.

The C.P.C. desk responds daily to numerous inquiries from professionals. We put about 100 of these professionals in touch with local C.P.C. committees who responded with offers for direct contact, information about how to send clients to meetings, offers of literature, or other means to assure that A.A. is a resource for professionals.

In 2015, we published two issues of our newsletter for professionals, *About A.A.* The Spring 2015 issue featured an article entitled "We Are Not Professionals" in response to queries to the C.P.C. desk from interested parties both outside and within the Fellowship who are either looking for or hoping to become "an A.A. professional." The Fall 2015 issue focused on the current trends revealed in our 2014 A.A. Membership Survey and also included an article explaining why we protect A.A. member anonymity at the level of press, radio, television or social media. Currently, some 11,500 professionals receive *About A.A.* either by digital or print subscription. Another 5,000 visitors annually access it on G.S.O.'s A.A. website.

Professional exhibits continue to result in requests for additional A.A. information, as well as personal contacts with local committee members. The C.P.C. assignment arranged for displays at 25 national or international conferences of professionals in 2015. At these exhibits, G.S.O. provides the booth space, display

and literature; local C.P.C. committees coordinate A.A. volunteers who staff the booth to answer questions and provide literature and contacts. Professionals in a broad range of fields visited the A.A. booth at these national events. In the interest of extending the hand of A.A. to all who suffer, each year we include some Public Information events, such as the GLBT Expo, the Lifestyle Intervention Conference, and meetings of the Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication and the Public Risk Management Association. In addition, we referred 20 local exhibits to area C.P.C. committees and supplied C.P.C. material for several exhibits and events set up by local committees.

As a result of actively pursuing presentation opportunities, we reached new audiences with five high-profile appearances by Class A (nonalcoholic) trustees at professional conferences, including the American Probation and Parole Association and the American Academy of Physicians Assistants. In addition, we supported the efforts of local committees by putting them in touch with the Class A trustees.

The C.P.C. desk serves as a resource for C.P.C. chairs throughout the U.S. and Canada. New chairpersons at the area and district levels receive welcome letters and applicable C.P.C. background material. Upon request, we assist local C.P.C. committees by sharing experience collected on this assignment. We encourage committees to send meeting minutes and to share local experiences for possible inclusion in future *Box 4-5-9* articles. Articles get published in *Box 4-5-9* about local C.P.C. activities throughout the year. This creates interest in C.P.C. service work with courts, clergy, doctors, medical students, educators and other professionals. In 2015, we updated the graphics and content of the popular C.P.C. presentation "Let's Be Friendly with Our Friends" to make it more accessible to professionals contacted by local C.P.C. committees.

The staff member on C.P.C. also serves as a liaison representative to several national organizations, such as the National Institute for Alcohol Abuse and Alcoholism (N.I.A.A.A.) and, when requested by other Twelve Step Fellowships, provides information about A.A.

M. Tracey Ober

Treatment and Accessibilities — the assignment name has been changed by the trustees' Treatment and Accessibilities Committee to Treatment/Accessibilities. At their core the purpose of the two distinct committees remains the same. That purpose is to carry the A.A. message to the alcoholic who still suffers regardless of what challenges may stand as barriers between the alcoholic and the A.A. message. While the two types of service committees which make up this assignment may strive to carry the A.A. message of recovery from alcoholism to different populations of alcoholics, the overall purpose of the assignment is to share A.A. and service committee experience and information through literature, activity

updates and other communications. The breakdown of committee chairs currently receiving communications from this assignment are Bridging the Gap (BTG) 229, Hospitals and Institutions (H&I) 96, Treatment 576 and Accessibilities 283. This total of 1,184 committee chairs is an increase of 133 from last year and an indicator of a constant increase over the last two years.

New chairs receive welcome letters, workbooks, service related materials and service kits for their particular position and committee. These materials continue to be shipped via postal mail. At every opportunity these trusted servants are reminded that the vast majority of information that they seek can be read or printed on the A.A. website. On their respective committee web pages they can immediately access the majority of committee service-related material regardless of their position within the committee. In addition, all area level chairs receive a list of other area level chairs to share their local experience and activities.

The committee chairs receive updates on other committees' activities through articles in Box 4-5-9, as well as receiving updates from the assignment coordinator that may contain ideas, activities, questions and solutions from other committees. These activity updates contain information about the General Service Office, requests for sharing and efforts to clarify any areas of potential confusion.

The Treatment/Accessibilities assignment welcomes correspondence from clients and professionals in treatment centers. In addition, communication is constantly received from alcoholics with challenges, such as visually- and hearing-impaired, brain injury and other physical and mental impairments. Each inquiry receives a response from the staff member who, as often as possible, links these professionals, treatment clients and alcoholics with challenges to the appropriate local committee member in the Fellowship who can serve as an additional resource.

The staff member on this assignment serves as secretary to the Conference Committee on Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities, and as co-secretary to the trustees' Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Accessibilities.

The assignment staff member is also a regional correspondent to one of the eight regions in the U.S. and Canada, sharing A.A. experience with hundreds of A.A. members via emails, phone calls and written correspondence.

Clement Cann

CORRECTIONS

Trustees' report: The trustees' Committee on Corrections recommends to the General Service Board actions that support carrying the A.A. message to alcoholics confined in a variety of correctional settings. Since the 2015 General Service Conference, the committee has met three times.

In keeping with the 2014 Conference Advisory Action, the committee focused on the development of the video to

replace *It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell*. The committee heard a progress report on pre-production and made certain that the new video would meet the criteria of the Conference Committee on Corrections. Specifically, it would provide information about A.A. as a source of hope for incarcerated alcoholics, featuring inmate sharing in a documentary style on the Twelve Steps, A.A. Literature, Corrections Correspondence Service, and Prerelease. Also, it would reflect diversity of race, gender and age and would include a variety of correctional facilities in the U.S. and Canada.

The committee viewed a rough cut of the video in October and reacted positively, while suggesting a few areas for revision. They viewed a new rough cut in January and, again reacting positively, requested two additional revisions. The committee agreed to forward the revised video to the 2016 Conference Committee on Corrections.

Throughout the year, the committee focused on increasing participation in the Corrections Correspondence Service (C.C.S.), and were pleased to note that there are now enough A.A. volunteers to be able to answer inmate requests for correspondence immediately. This is true for both men and women, though not yet for Spanish-speaking men. The committee is supporting efforts to recruit more Spanish-speaking correspondents.

The committee continued their ongoing discussion about developing a C.C.S. for Canada. They also added an appointed committee member with experience in Canadian corrections work, who was welcomed at the October meeting. Efforts are ongoing to raise awareness of C.C.S. among Canadian inmates and to recruit more Canadian A.A. members as correspondents.

In keeping with the 2015 Conference Corrections Additional Committee Consideration, the committee agreed to add an issue of *La Viña* to the English-language Corrections Kit as well as to the French-language Corrections Kit.

The committee discussed the need for an annual corrections workshop for A.A. members in the U.S. and Canada and appointed a Subcommittee on the Feasibility of a Corrections Workshop. The subcommittee worked with staff to draft a questionnaire to be sent to Corrections/H&I Committee chairpersons and area delegates. The questionnaire inquired about workshops currently being held by states/provinces/areas/districts, then asked respondents if they felt the need for a North American corrections workshop. The questionnaire also asked if respondents would consider hosting such a workshop should a need be expressed. The returned questionnaires indicated a strong need for a North American corrections workshop, saying it would greatly benefit the corrections community in the U.S. and Canada. The committee requested that the secretary thank all the respondents and link those who expressed an interest in hosting the event in order to facilitate further discussion.

The committee also discussed unmet requests from inmates for Grapevine/La Viña subscriptions. They reviewed the current process of filling requests from

inmates and discussed whether or not it needed to be simplified, noting that a Grapevine Outreach committee was currently working on refinements. Also discussed were ways of making inmates more aware of the opportunity to request Grapevine and LaViña subscriptions, recognizing that the process to fulfill subscriptions through local channels has been clarified and improved.

Richard Boisvert, chairperson

Staff report: The Corrections assignment is responsible for helping A.A. members and local committees carry the A.A. message to alcoholics confined in a variety of correctional settings. Approximately 500 pieces of mail a month arrive from inmates, many requesting free literature, others asking to participate in our Corrections Correspondence Service (C.C.S.) or for help in making contact with A.A., either by asking for a meeting in their facility or for a pre-release contact. While not everyone who writes to G.S.O. has a problem with alcohol, all letters are answered; those indicating they have a drinking problem are provided with basic literature, information about Twelve Step services specifically designed for the alcoholic who is incarcerated, and a warm invitation to participate in the Fellowship and program of recovery of A.A.

If an incarcerated alcoholic requests free literature, he or she may be sent a Big Book, a copy of Grapevine or La Viña, and a selection of pamphlets, and often the booklet *A.A. in Prison: Inmate to Inmate*, with an explanation that the enclosed literature is made possible through the voluntary contributions of A.A. members throughout the United States and Canada. However, this assignment tries to avoid being viewed as the primary source of A.A. literature, since “carrying the A.A. message” in this way is an A.A. service opportunity. Requests for multiple copies for an inside group, or ongoing requests from the same facility, are usually referred to local A.A. members doing this type of Twelfth Step service. This practice is also in keeping with past recommendations of Conference and trustees’ Committees on Corrections.

The Corrections Correspondence Service, coordinated by this assignment, continues as one of our most valuable efforts. Many alcoholics who are incarcerated are looking to turn their lives around and crave outside support from A.A.s with whom they can share their experience, strength and hope. To fill their requests, this assignment puts out regular requests to the Fellowship through various channels for new correspondence volunteers — especially males. One of the challenges to this staff assignment is explaining why — when A.A. members continue to volunteer their time — we can never completely close the gap. The short answer is that every day more and more alcoholics in correctional facilities discover that the root of their problem is alcohol and decide to do something about it! Once they come across the message of Alcoholics Anonymous, they want to share their journey with someone, just like the rest of us.

In 2015, we linked 1,148 male and 314 female alcoholics in prison to an outside A.A. correspondent through the C.C.S. In order to meet those requests, we needed to be able to match the inmates with 1,462 outside A.A. volunteers. Although many of those offered to write to more than one incarcerated alcoholic at a time, the number of volunteers needed remains large. And that is the data for just one year.

One of the most gratifying aspects of the assignment is communicating with area and district Corrections, Hospitals and Institutions, and Bridging the Gap committees. The desk fields daily calls and emails from A.A. members doing corrections service work. In 2015, we passed along to area corrections committee chairs 354 requests from inmates, corrections professionals, and A.A. members taking meetings into correctional facilities for prerelease contacts, outside support, or A.A. literature. We send out a periodic activity report to each of these committee chairs with updated information or requests for shared experience.

G.S.O.’s A.A. website has a special section where most Corrections service material can be found, including current and past issues of the newsletter *Sharing From Behind the Walls*. This quarterly publication contains excerpts of sharing from A.A. members in prison who have written to G.S.O. This desk prepares selections from these A.A. members’ letters and sends them a copy of the excerpt along with a request to reprint it in a future issue. The permission letter also mentions the possibility that the newsletter might be posted on G.S.O.’s website. Posting this anonymity-protected newsletter on the website and inviting members who take meetings into correctional facilities to print out copies is another way of ensuring that the sharing from this population of alcoholics gets into the hands of those who need it most.

A.A. members involved in corrections service frequently ask how they can get their fellow members on the “outside” to commit to speaking or sponsoring a meeting in a correctional facility. Often, people in the Fellowship unfamiliar with this type of Twelfth Step activity express the fear that the alcoholic in prison will not identify with an A.A. member who has not been to prison, and are reluctant to commit to the amount of time institutions sometimes require for orientation seminars to qualify to go into their correctional facilities. *Carrying the Message Behind These Walls*, a video created to encourage A.A. members to participate in corrections service, addresses many of the concerns that may hold members back from this rewarding Twelfth Step work.

We receive many letters from inmates expressing their gratitude for the hope found in the literature received, as well as for the many dedicated members who take the time to reach out inside the walls by bringing an A.A. meeting into the institution or via our Corrections Correspondence Service.

Jeff Wine

FINANCE AND BUDGETARY

Trustees' report:

2015 Budget vs. 2015 Actual Results

General Service Office — At last year's Conference, we reviewed the proposed budget for 2015 and reported that G.S.O. expected a profit from operations of approximately \$195,125. This was revised downward following the actions of the 65th General Service Conference to \$13,125. However, for the year 2015, G.S.O. turned in positive results from operations of \$205,625, a net improvement of \$192,500. This was due to publishing revenues and overall expenses being significantly less than budget and contributions being greater than budget.

Net sales of publishing activities for 2015 were \$12,489,433, approximately \$2,080,567 (14.3%) less than budget. Manufacturing and royalty expense were \$309,800 less than budget, and shipping and warehousing expenses were \$304,500 less than budget as well. This resulted in a gross profit of \$8,170,384, or \$1,466,366 (15.2%) less than budget. Adding to these positive publishing results were the Fellowship's actual self-support contributions of \$7,154,146, which were \$154,146 (2.2%) greater than budget. Finally, operating expenses were \$1,504,686 (9.1%) less than budget.

A.A. Grapevine — The 2015 Grapevine budget anticipated a net loss of \$14,607. Instead, the actual results were significantly better for the Grapevine, a net profit of \$240,811. For the year, gross profit from Other Publishing activities was approximately \$30,400 better than budget. Expenses for the year were \$225,117 less than budget as well.

Reserve Fund — At December 31, 2015, the Reserve Fund balance represented approximately 10.4 months of operating expenses, compared to a budget of 9.8 months.

2015 Actual Results vs. 2014 Actual Results

General Service Office — Our revenues come from two sources: contributions from the Fellowship and profits from literature sales.

Contributions of \$7,109,338, received from *groups and members* (excluding funds received from World Service Meeting countries) were approximately \$280,848, or 4.1% greater than the \$6,828,490 received during 2014. The \$7,109,338 in contributions came from 26,500 groups, individuals, and service entities. That, for comparison, represents approximately 40.3% of the 65,741 groups listed with G.S.O., down from the 41.6% reported last year. This downward trend in participation is a continuation of the negative trend that has occurred over the last decade.

As shown in the Contributions Statistics report, included in the Conference material, there were 65,741 groups, some 519 greater than the 65,222 groups reported last year. It is important to remember, however, that the statistics we discuss concerning number of groups, membership and averages are only a reflection of the information we capture on "our systems." We report to you what you report to us.

During 2015, 77,235 contributions were received,

approximately 5,700 fewer than the 82,927 contributions that were received during 2014, and compares with 79,363 received in 2013, 80,936 received in 2012, 80,683 received during 2011 and 77,185 in 2010. Interestingly however, fewer contributions resulted in more dollars.

Beginning in June 2010, we implemented the online Contributions function for both groups and individual members. For the period June through December 2010, we received approximately 1,056 contributions via the online method, representing approximately \$82,500. During 2011, we received approximately 1,748 online contributions, \$156,553 and in 2012, 2,346 contributions or \$213,400 were received. During 2013, 2,980 were received for a total of \$302,230. During 2014, we received approximately 4,000 online contributions for a total of \$379,599. For the year 2015, we received approximately 4,600 online contributions for a total of \$420,000.

The recurring Contribution function is an underutilized gem of A.A. Remember that individual members can set up an account to automatically charge their credit card either monthly, quarterly or annually. The individual has the option to designate to his or her group if desired or simply designate the contribution for G.S.O. It would seem that this function has been a secret because at the end of 2015 there were only 139 members actively using this function. Perhaps the word is getting out because as of March 8th there were 189 active users. Spread the Word!

Beginning in 2002, we commenced recording funds received on behalf of the World Service Meeting International Literature Fund as Contributions to G.S.O. Total contributions of \$7,154,146 received by G.S.O.,

Estimates of Groups and Members as of January 1, 2016¹

	Groups	Members
United States	60,698	1,262,542
Canada	5,043	85,530
Sub-Total	65,741	1,348,072
Correctional facilities ²	1,450	35,710
Loners, Internationalists, Homers	2	66
Total	67,193	1,383,848
Outside U.S. & Canada ³	50,555	705,850
Grand Total	117,748	2,089,698

¹ The General Service Office does not keep membership records. The information shown here is based on reports given by groups listed with G.S.O., and does not represent an actual count of those who consider themselves A.A. members.

² U.S. and Canada only.

³ We are aware of A.A. activity in approximately 180 countries, including 62 autonomous general service offices in other lands. Annually we attempt to contact those G.S.O.s and groups that request to be listed in our records. Where current data is lacking we use the previous year's figures.

reflected in our 2015 financial statements, include approximately \$44,800 received to help carry the message around the world from those participating countries. The comparable comparisons for prior years were: 2014, \$69,600; 2013, \$36,130; 2012, \$34,665; 2011, \$74,588; 2010, \$129,518; 2009, \$133,715; 2008, \$137,600; 2007, \$144,400; 2006, \$145,000; 2005, \$135,000; 2004, \$128,357; 2003, \$102,900; and 2002, \$108,000.

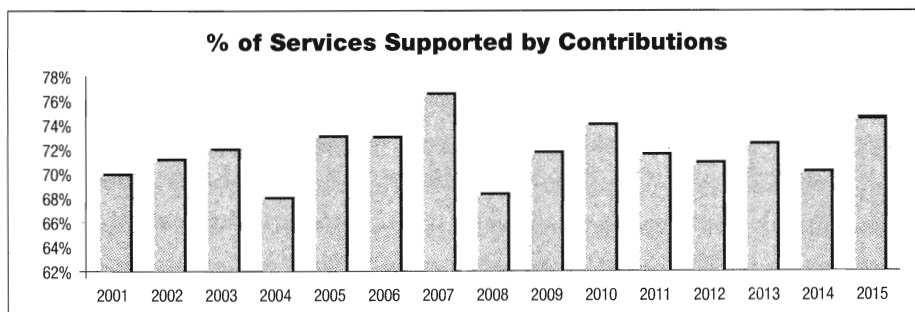
Turning to the other major component of our income, net sales of literature were \$12,489,433, a decrease of \$4,382,847 from the prior year. During 2015, approximately 780,000 Big Books were sold compared with 1,130,500 in 2014, 973,000 in 2013, 947,430 in 2012 and 945,500 in 2011. Not included in the 1,130,500 Big Books sold in 2014 were sales of 177,888 copies of the 75th Anniversary Edition (\$1,888,880). The large increase in 2014 units sold and associated reduction in 2015 units sold was a result of large bulk purchases occurring in the third quarter of 2014 prior to the October 1, 2014 price increase.

Printing and manufacturing costs, shipping expenses and royalty payments were in the aggregate \$2,659,254 less than 2014. This decrease was a result of three items: (1) less sales equals less cost of manufacturing and shipping costs; (2) only a small amount of royalties as the last remaining Royalty recipient passed away in 2015; and (3) included in 2014 manufacturing costs was an allowance for an inventory write down for excess inventory of the 75th Anniversary Edition in accordance with Generally Accepted Accounting Principles (\$823,000). In 2015, another inventory write down was required of approximately \$86,000. The Gross profit from literature of \$8,170,384 was \$1,723,592 less than 2014.

The combination of contributions and net literature sales resulted in total G.S.O. revenue of \$15,324,964, \$1,467,507 less than 2014.

Total operating expenses for G.S.O. during 2015 were \$15,119,339, approximately \$296,475 less than 2014, and \$1,504,686 less than budget.

For the year 2015, there were three significant variations from 2014 expense lines. The single largest item was in Retirement expense, approximately \$157,000 less



based on a reduced funding requirement due to a transfer of \$1,500,000 from the Reserve Fund to the Pension Fund in 2014.

Professional fees were approximately \$108,000 less than 2014, due primarily to fewer costs incurred for legal representation based on various litigation matters.

Travel and Meetings showed an increase of approximately \$147,000 greater than 2014 primarily due to the 2015 Conference being held back in Manhattan. Furniture and equipment was less than 2014, primarily due to the write off of unamortized costs of the app due to the A.A.W.S. Board decision to discontinue support of the app and move to third party vendors.

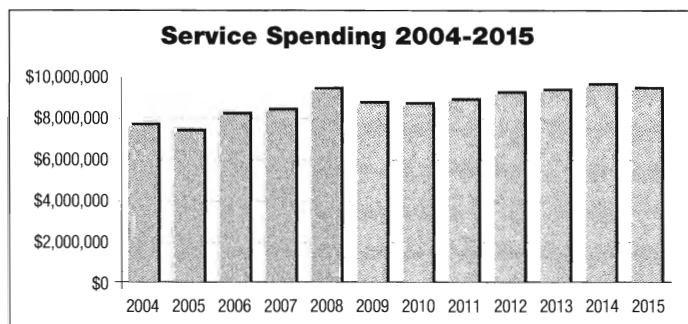
Expanding on the use of the Fellowship's money in providing services to the Fellowship, in 2015 \$9,629,499 was spent to provide Services to the Fellowship, approximately \$95,711 less than the \$9,725,210 spent in 2014 and compared with \$9,507,582 spent in 2013 and compared with \$9,254,131 spent in 2012; \$8,747,139 in 2011; \$8,642,112 in 2010; \$8,783,762 in 2009; \$9,447,300 in 2008.

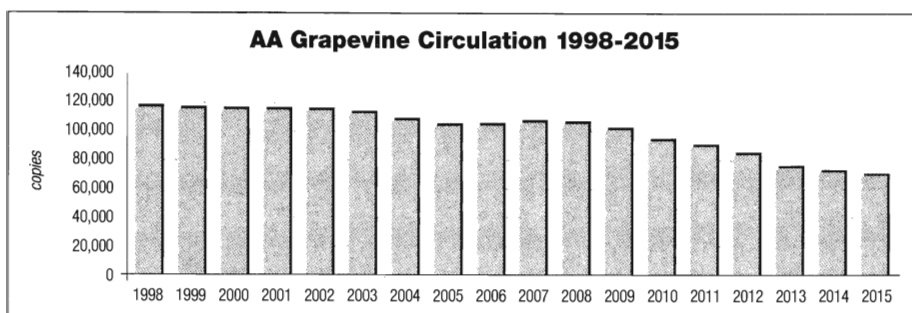
The 2015 service dollar was spent on the following activities: Group Services, 30.5% (which includes various group contact-type costs in addition to Box 4-5-9; A.A. Directories; records and files; contributions processing; and French services); the General Service Conference, 16.4%; Loners, International Assignment and Overseas Services, 6.5%; trustees' and directors' activities, 5.9%; Regional Forums, 6.0%; Archives, 10.5%; C.P.C., 4.6%; Public Information, 5.4%; Corrections, 4.6%; Treatment, 1.9%; Special Needs, 1.0%; Nominating, 3.1%; Convention, 3.1%; World Service Meeting, .1%; and other various 0.4%.

Contributions provided 74.3% of the support for these services and 25.79% came from the profit from literature sales. This compares with 70.1% and 29.9% in 2014, 72.6% and 27.4% in 2013; 70.9% and 29.1% in 2012; 71.6% and 28.4% in 2011; 74.2% and 25.8% in 2010; 71.7% and 28.3% in 2009 and 68.1% and 31.9% in 2008.

2016 G.S.O. Budget — Sales for 2016 are budgeted at \$13,707,484, approximately 7.7% greater when compared with 2015. While we are experiencing a gradual decline in ongoing unit sales, we are expecting an overall increase in unit sales as those who purchased significant amounts prior to the general literature price increase October 1, 2014 will need to restock in 2016.

Your trusted servants continue to explore methods to reduce the costs of operations, as well as assess the





services supplied. We are trying to make more use of electronic communications wherever possible to reduce the costs of postage and supplies. One should remember that as we continue to strive to have literature available throughout our Service Conference, in Spanish and French, as well as English, lower print runs in non-English languages usually result in higher production costs. Nevertheless, we generally have the same selling prices regardless of the manufacturing cost; therefore, lower overall gross profit margins for low volume items affect the overall gross profit percentages and make literature price increases necessary from time to time.

With Contribution revenue in 2015 slightly ahead of budget (and it is hard to determine what World Service Meeting Counties will contribute to the literature efforts), we have budgeted contributions for 2016 approximately even with 2015 at \$7,100,000. A.A.W.S. is continuing to actively undertake various self-support efforts initiatives.

Dividing total Contributions received in 2015 (\$7,154,146) by the 65,741 groups listed gives us an average of about \$108.82, up slightly from last year's \$105.76, while expenses to support services to those groups amounted to approximately \$146.48 (down from \$149.11 last year).

The 2016 budget anticipates approximately a 6.7% increase in costs when compared with 2015 actual results, with "People Costs" being the principal driver. The combination of inflation plus a number of existing and new staff positions being filled in 2016 underlays this increase. During 2015, we had a very large number of employees either retire or leave G.S.O and many of those open existing positions were not filled before year-end. In addition, last year we noted a need for additional staff in the accounting department and this year we hope to fill those positions. Also, as noted previously, we were able to reduce Pension cost to both operating entities by several hundred thousand dollars a year as a result of the General Service Board transfer of \$1,500,000 from the Reserve Fund to the Pension Trust.

Based on these preliminary assumptions — approximately a 7.7% increase in sales, approximately even contributions, and an increase in total operating expenses — the projection for 2016 is for a slight loss from operations of \$26,691.

During the budget process, the A.A.W.S. Board, as well as the trustees' Finance Committee, remains cognizant of the level of the Reserve Fund. Management continues to assess expenses and operations with an eye toward reducing costs.

The Reserve Fund (and Historical Reference for price adjustments) — In 1994, G.S.O. lowered prices and increased discounts on literature. These changes were undertaken to lower the Reserve Fund, which was at

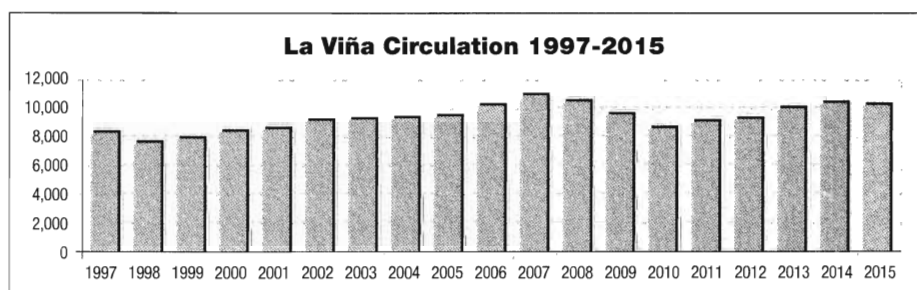
that time approaching the upper limit of 12 months of combined operating expenses established by the General Service Conference. In subsequent years, it became necessary to restore the revenue stream with pricing adjustments. As noted in previous reports, G.S.O. management was charged with presenting ongoing budgets with sufficient revenue that, with all things being equal, would maintain the Reserve Fund at a nine-month level of operating expenses.

The adjusted balance used for the number of months' calculation at December 31, 2015 of \$14,583,935 amounts to about \$222 per listed A.A. group.

The Grapevine — At the Grapevine, gross magazine income for 2015 of \$2,144,278 was approximately \$86,100 less than the prior year. Total magazine income includes the print magazine, single copies, back issues, Digital Magazine Subscriptions, GV Online, Digital Archives Project Subscriptions, and the Audio Grapevine. The average paid circulation for print magazines continued its long-term decline. The recent decline had been about 5% per, however, during 2015 the decline was mitigated somewhat by promotional efforts to a 2.7% decline. Actual paid circulation for 2015 was 71,766 down from 74,000 for 2014. This compares to 77,126 for 2013; 83,263 for 2012; 90,493 for 2011; 93,104 for 2010; 102,281 for 2009; and 104,993 for 2008.

Subscriptions for the Online magazine averaged 5,233 during 2015, essentially even with the 5,262 for 2014 and compared with 5,175 for 2013; 5,535 for 2012; and the 2015 budget of 5,368.

Gross profit on the magazine of \$1,418,247 was \$110,814 less than 2014, and \$14,400 less than budget. Other publishing income of \$550,581 was \$41,278 greater than 2014 actual, but \$44,775 greater than budget. Total income, including interest earned, was \$1,976,928, \$68,533 less than 2014, and \$30,300 greater than budget.



Costs and expenses for editorial, circulation and business, and administration were \$1,736,117. Costs and expenses were \$16,480 greater than 2014, and \$225,118 less than budget. The Grapevine reported a profit from operations of \$240,811, which was approximately \$85,016 less than the 2014 result of \$325,827, and \$255,425 greater than the budgeted loss of \$14,614.

The Grapevine's 2016 budget anticipates magazine income of \$2,093,366 (approximately \$50,912 less than the \$2,144,278 realized in 2015), an increase in magazine direct costs of \$5,006, and a gross profit of \$1,362,329 is anticipated. Gross profit from magazine is anticipated to be approximately \$55,918 less than 2015. Gross profit on other publishing income is anticipated to decrease approximately \$195,927 to \$354,654, and interest income is estimated lower than 2015.

A loss for 2016 of \$146,263 is anticipated, compared with a \$240,811 profit for 2015.

La Viña — *La Viña* is the Spanish-language magazine approved by the 1995 General Service Conference. Since then, the magazine has grown from an idea to a full-fledged publication with a 2015 average circulation of 10,355. This compares with a 2014 average of 10,379; 2013 average of 10,145; 2012 average of 9,157; 2011 average of 8,982; 2010 average of 8,741; 2009 average of 9,663; 2008 of 10,404.

During 2015, subscription income was \$121,130 and direct costs of publishing were \$57,970, resulting in a \$63,160 gross profit. During 2015, *La Viña* realized approximately \$10,080 from the sales of other items, net of costs. Operating expenses directly associated with the publication were \$221,470. These include the editorial, circulation and administrative costs attributable to *La Viña*. Therefore, the overall net shortfall between revenues on the magazine and all costs to produce and distribute *La Viña* was \$146,378.

This shortfall of \$146,378 was covered by the General

Fund of the General Service Board. The 2015 shortfall compares with the 2014 shortfall of \$132,026; the 2013 shortfall of \$142,544; \$115,820 for 2012; \$69,725 for 2011; \$75,481 for 2010; \$54,472 for 2009; and \$76,260 for 2008.

For 2016, the net cost to the General Service Board for the *La Viña* magazine is budgeted to be approximately \$152,607 (\$6,229 greater than 2015), with circulation anticipated to be slightly (338) lower. The Grapevine Board and the trustees' Finance Committee continue to monitor progress and report results to the Conference. Since the inception of the magazine, approximately \$1,947,000 has been invested in *La Viña* in excess of revenues generated. In 2001, the General Service Board recommended that *La Viña* continue to be published and agreed to provide the necessary funding.

Other Items

International Convention — The 80th International Convention was held in Atlanta, Georgia in July. Although attendance was a record high, nearly 57,000, resulting in revenues of \$5.9 million, expenses to put on the convention were \$6.1 million. This resulted in a \$210,000 loss, compared to a budgeted profit of \$80,000. The principal reasons for the loss were that the higher numbers of attendees necessitated the need for more hotels located much further away from downtown Atlanta and that resulted in the need for significantly more busses to transport the people from their hotels to the convention center. Other expenses that were much higher than anticipated were for security, and larger numbers of attendees with special needs. A summary page is included in the Audited Financial Statements provided in the Conference Manual

A.A.W.S. self-support report 2015 work — The Committee heard a report from A.A.W.S. on Self-Support efforts (the work of the previous TFC subcommittee on self-support efforts having been assigned to A.A.W.S.).

The committee heard a report from A.A.W.S. concern-





ing the “Your Seventh Tradition Contributions — Carrying Our Message Beyond Your Home Group” flyer that was prepared by A.A.W.S., has been distributed at various venues (including the International Convention in Atlanta) and has been received favorably. In addition, it was reported that A.A.W.S. will continue discussions on other self-support ideas, including Birthday envelopes. Members are reminded of the option of “Recurring Contributions,” the ability to make repetitive contributions automatically.

In response to two very large contributions the Committee reviewed a “Draft Policy for Excessive Annual Contributions or Death Bequests” and recommended the following policy be approved by the General Service Board:

“Consistent with the Seventh Tradition of Self-Support, the General Service Conference has from time to time established specific dollar limits on the amount of annual contributions (currently \$3,000 per year) and bequests (currently \$5,000 at death) that the General Service Office is allowed to accept from any individual member of Alcoholics Anonymous (A.A.). These limits were established to eliminate the possibility, or even the perceived possibility, of undue influence in the affairs of A.A. Therefore, it is the policy of the General Service Board that any funds received from an individual member of A.A., either directly or indirectly that exceeds the limits established by the General Service Conference will not be accepted and will be returned.”

In summary, your trusted servants continue to vigilantly monitor the financial affairs of A.A. Steps have been taken over the past several years to enhance the net revenue streams of our publishing activities, to diligently manage the expense side of our support services and to address our long-term obligations, all with the goal of helping insure that the Fellowship’s finances remain in good condition. Your General Service Board Trustees and operating Corporation Directors continue to assess options going forward.

While the economic outlook for 2016 and beyond may be uncertain as the economy unfolds, we will continue to monitor events with our goal to insure the financial wherewithal to carry our message.

David Morris, treasurer

GENERAL SHARING SESSION

Trustees’ report: Since the 65th General Service Conference, the General Service Board has held three General Sharing Sessions. In August 2015, the topic was “A.A.’s Primary Purpose: Reaching the Alcoholic Who Still Suffers.” Bill Farnsworth, regional trustee, shared on the topic, “What more could we do?” and Bill Noonan, general service trustee, shared on “Is our literature and communication tools effective in helping groups and members reach the alcoholic who still suffers?”

During the October 2015 board weekend, the Sharing Session topic was “Diversity in Recovery — The A.A. Experience.” Joe Downey, general service trustee, shared on “A.A. today — is the door still open wide enough, or is the door closing with rigidity and dogma?” and Clay Rittenhouse, G.S.O. staff member, shared on “How do we communicate about the diversity of A.A. experience in the application of our program of recovery from alcoholism — both outside and within the Fellowship?”

The January 2016 Sharing Session topic was “Spirituality and Money.” Chet Parker, regional trustee, shared on “How do I ‘pay forward’ a spiritual experience through the basket?” and Richard Purtell, regional trustee, shared on “Is my contribution an expression of gratitude and service, or has it become just a habit?”

Complete copies of these presentations are available and may be requested from the staff coordinator at G.S.O.

Andrew Ware, chairperson

A.A. GRAPEVINE, INC.

Office report: Since the last Conference, A.A. Grapevine, Inc. has produced 12 issues of Grapevine; six issues of La Viña; four new books and ebooks: *Happy, Joyous & Free*, (special Conference editions in English, Spanish and French); *Forming True Partnership* (about relationships in sobriety); an audiobook version of *The Language of the Heart*; a wall calendar; and a pocket planner.

In 2015, A.A. Grapevine participated at the International Convention in Atlanta, with a Grapevine/La Viña booth and a Carry the Message booth, and presented four workshops (for both Grapevine and La Viña).

A.A. Grapevine also initiated a Fellowship-wide 2015 Subscription Challenge for Grapevine and La Viña. The state or province with the largest number of new subscriptions for each magazine, expressed as percentage growth by late December 2015, will receive a special section in Grapevine and/or La Viña devoted to A.A. in that state or province in 2016. A.A. Grapevine posted a resource page on its website (www.aagrapevine.org/grapevine-challenge) to help the Fellowship view the progress. Also in 2015, preparations began for next year's 20th anniversary celebration of La Viña.

A "mobile-friendly" version of Grapevine magazine is currently in development for possible release to the Fellowship in early 2016. Also in 2015, A.A. Grapevine launched an audience building effort using short message service (SMS) for La Viña.

In 2015, A.A. Grapevine continued the collection phase for audio story submissions from the Fellowship. As of January 2016 A.A. Grapevine has collected 230 audio stories. Nine stories are available free on www.aagrapevine.org as examples for members who wish to record a story.

The A.A. Grapevine website continues to expand and in 2015 received an average of 40,000 unique visitors each month. Throughout the year A.A. Grapevine worked on improving the website and will continue into 2016. Landing pages were created to improve the user experience for the purchase of subscriptions or books such as *The Language of the Heart*. In 2015, the Archive team began tagging stories to improve the members' experience when using the Story Archive. The project is expected to be completed in 2016.

In 2015, Grapevine and La Viña magazines continued the Carry the Message project in an effort to inform members and groups about an option to purchase subscription gift certificates to give to delegates or local committees for distribution to members in need.

Jon Witherspoon, senior editor

GROUP SERVICES/LIM

Staff report: To assist groups, the General Service Office develops service material based on an indicated need and shares information and experience not found in Conference-approved literature. A seven-page list describes the service items. Examples of service material include: Group Handbooks; G.S.R. and D.C.M. Kits; A.A. Guidelines; Referral List of "Fellowships Similar to A.A."; "A.A. Around the Globe"; and "Anonymity Online."

Service material is available to A.A. members upon request. A large portion of the material differs from Conference-approved literature in that it has not come about through Conference Advisory Action. It is produced when there is an expressed need for readily available information on a specific subject or in a specific format. Service material reflects A.A. group experience as well as specific and timely information that is subject to change.

Current ongoing projects involving Group Services:

- The Group Services coordinator collaborates with the Special Projects manager regarding the three regional A.A. Directories (Canadian, Eastern U.S., and Western U.S.), G.S.O.'s group and service committee records, and intergroup and central office records and lists.
- Supervises the updating of G.S.O.'s available service material upon request, and in Spanish and French, whenever possible.
- Functions as G.S.O.'s liaison to some 500 central offices and intergroups in the U.S. and Canada. Coordinates A.A.W.S.'s participation at the annual intergroup/central office seminar and serves on the seminar's Policy and Site-Selection Committees. The 31st Annual Intergroup/Central Office Seminar will take place in Kansas City, Missouri, in November 2016.
- Serves as a resource to the managing editor regarding the updating of *The A.A. Service Manual* and serves as secretary to the Conference Committee on Report and Charter.
- Finally, the *Loners-Internationalists Meeting (LIM)* is under the purview of this assignment. G.S.O. receives an average of 20 shares per month which comprise a *confidential* bimonthly bulletin sent to Loners, Homers, Internationalists, and to Loner Sponsors and Port Contacts — members unable to attend meetings in person. The LIM bulletin includes full names and addresses of the 435 or so participants who correspond with one another year round.

Racy Joseph

INTERNATIONAL

Trustees' report: This committee is responsible for suggesting policies and actions to assure that the A.A. message is available around the world, especially in areas where there is no established service structure. We provide shared experience, support translations of A.A. literature in other languages, and encourage the expansion of regional or zonal meetings. The committee is the primary link between the international A.A. community and the U.S./Canada General Service Board of Trustees.

The 2016 Literature Assistance budget of \$50,000 will allow A.A. World Services to translate and publish a variety of foreign language books, pamphlets and reprints. A portion of this expense will be drawn from the International Literature Fund, representing contributions from A.A. groups and structures around the world. A.A.W.S. holds the copyrights on all foreign-language versions of our Conference-approved material and issues licensing agreements for publication and distribution to those countries which have an established general service board. When necessary, we translate and publish the material, subject to scheduling by the Publishing department and approval of the A.A.W.S. Board. The Big Book is currently available in 69 languages, and other literature is available in approximately 90 languages.

The 24th World Service Meeting (WSM) will be held October 23-27, 2016 in Rye Brook, New York with the

theme “One World, One A.A., One Language of the Heart.” We are anticipating approximately 60 delegates representing an estimated 40 countries or linguistic zones. Representing our General Service Board will be first-term delegate Scott Huyghebaert, trustee-at-large/Canada, and second-term delegate Bob Wilcox, trustee-at-large/U.S. G.S.O. general manager Greg Tobin will be presiding at the event and staff member Mary Cumings will serve as WSM coordinator. Other staff members who will serve as secretaries to WSM committees are Racy Joseph, Steve Smith and Clay Rittenhouse.

The United States and Canada were represented at four zonal service meetings in 2015, which are held in the year when the World Service Meeting does not convene. In June 2015, Phyllis Halliday and Rick Walker attended, as observers, the 7th Sub-Saharan Africa Service Meeting (SSASM), which was held in Johannesburg, South Africa. In October, Greg Tobin and Mary Cumings attended, as observers, the 18th European Service Meeting (ESM) in York, England. At the end of October, Mary Cumings and David Rosen attended, as observers, the 11th Asia-Oceania Service Meeting (AOSM) in Dubai, U.A.E. Also in October, Bob Wilcox, trustee-at-large/U.S. and Scott Huyghebaert, trustee-at-large/Canada, attended, as delegates, the 19th Meeting of the Americas (REDELA) in Mexico City, Mexico.

Over the past few years, the General Service Board and General Service Office have received fewer invitations from other countries to attend events ranging from conventions, anniversary celebrations, conferences, board meetings, office visits, and regional assemblies. In addition to the zonal events listed above, in 2015 trustees and staff members visited Italy, Poland, and Ukraine. Tentative international travel for 2016 includes the 37th Central American Convention in Panama City, Panama, and the German General Service Conference in Rösrath, Germany.

The committee reviewed an updated draft, and adopted the “Guidelines for Adequate Interpretation on International Trips.” The committee approved the addition of interpretation related information to the Trip Consultation Team Form. This form is used by the Trip Consultation Team, which makes decisions about accepting invitations for international travel.

The committee considered favorably the idea of an international A.A. data map that could include information by country about A.A. presence, available translations, zonal meeting and World Service Meeting participation, etc. and appointed a subcommittee to define the scope, purpose and feasibility for a proposed interactive international A.A. data map. The committee also requested staff to explore, evaluate and recommend the purchase of specific mapping software, and looks forward to a report from the subcommittee on this project at the July 2016 meeting.

We discussed background regarding having an alternate delegate for the World Service Meeting, and noted that an alternate would be useful for the Meeting of the Americas as well. While the committee did not want to appoint an individual as an alternate, it was recommended to the

General Service Board that, in the event that one of the U.S./Canada delegates to the World Service Meeting or Meeting of the Americas is unable to attend, the chair of the General Service Board consult with the chair of the trustees’ International Committee and appoint another trustee to participate as an alternate. The General Service Board approved this recommendation and the committee added this to their Composition, Scope and Procedure.

The committee also discussed the request from A.A.W.S. to develop a self-support strategy for the World Service Meeting (WSM) and noted that the WSM Policy/Admissions/Finance Committee discusses WSM finances and is a standing agenda item for this WSM committee. The committee agreed that communication of WSM financial information to the WSM delegates is vital and noted that the delegate fee and transportation forms for the 24th World Service Meeting are being revised to incorporate suggestions from the WSM Policy/Admissions/Finance Committee. The committee also asked that a presentation on the Seventh Tradition be included in the WSM agenda, and will continue this discussion at their July 2016 meeting.

We continue to be encouraged and inspired by the international A.A. community and General Service Boards and offices in other countries, which carry the A.A. message to countless thousands in new regions and across difficult linguistic, cultural and economic barriers.

Bob Wilcox, chairperson

Staff report: The International desk receives correspondence from groups, individual A.A.s and professionals interested in obtaining information about A.A. in countries outside of the U.S. and Canada. Additionally, the staff member corresponds with 62 international general service offices and/or literature distribution centers.

The International desk is also responsible for communication with structures, groups and members outside the United States/Canada. Correspondence arrives at the International desk in many languages and is answered in the appropriate language, often accompanied by A.A. literature. In order to accomplish this, the staff member on the assignment is assisted by a bilingual (English-Spanish) assistant and outside professional services. Where there is a nearby office, we provide that contact information. We emphasize our trust in the fact that these members can maintain sobriety, help others and become independent in their own countries.

The International staff member benefits from the experience of G.S.O. staff, cooperation with the Publishing department, and the support of the trustees’ International Committee, which he or she serves as secretary. Other responsibilities on the assignment are:

- Serving as coordinator for the biennial World Service Meeting (WSM) and maintaining contact with WSM delegates and their offices throughout the year.
- Maintaining close communications with our Publishing department on requests for new translations of literature,

and the beginnings of new general service or information offices that may be able to distribute literature to local members and groups.

- Each year, A.A. World Services receives offers to translate our literature into foreign languages. The Big Book has now been translated into 68 languages, and additional translations are in progress. Primary in consideration of each request is the need to ensure the integrity and authenticity of A.A.'s message. To that end, the Publishing department has the responsibility of having each translation checked against the English original. In countries where there is a general service board licensed to publish or distribute A.A. literature, an approved translation is often financed and published there. Where a stable A.A. structure is not yet present, the A.A.W.S. Board undertakes the new publication when funds are available.
- Handling communications related to overseas travel, and attendance at Zonal Service Meetings. Our trustees-at-large (U.S. and Canada) are our delegates to the Meeting of the Americas (REDELA). Other Zonal Meetings include the Asia-Oceania, European, and Sub-Saharan Africa Service Meetings.
- Working closely with our Records department to insure that our International A.A. Directory (for countries outside of the United States and Canada), which is published annually, contains updated contact information for G.S.O.s, central offices and intergroups, groups, international contacts and Loners around the world.

Mary Cumings

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/ REGIONAL FORUMS

Trustees' reports:

International Conventions — The 2015 International Convention, held last summer in Atlanta, Georgia, was a wonderful experience for the approximately 57,000 attendees, larger than past Conventions. In all, over 1,000 people participated as invited speakers or chairs for about 250 A.A. meetings, panels, marathons and Big Meetings. There were 784 registered attendees designated ASL (American Sign Language).

Once again members from around the world who were unable to make it to Atlanta had the opportunity to view an anonymity-protected, delayed broadcast of the Opening Flag Ceremony from G.S.O.'s A.A. website. A total of 93 flags from different countries were displayed in addition to the Eagle Staff representing the Native American/First Nations. Eva Sanchez, the Convention coordinator, other G.S.O. personnel, the Convention consultant and the Atlanta Host Committee combined to provide a truly international experience celebrating A.A.'s 80th Anniversary, "Happy, Joyous and Free."

Since the 2015 General Service Conference our committee has met three times.

The purpose of the trustees' committee as it relates to

International Conventions is to work on plans for each forthcoming International Convention. The objectives of the International Conventions are:

- To provide opportunities for a rededication of attendees to the primary purpose of A.A.
- To enable attendees to witness the success and growth of the A.A. program around the world.
- To let the world know that A.A. is alive, flourishing and available as a community resource, locally and internationally.

The committee acts and makes recommendations in order to fulfill the broad purposes of the General Service Board, as those purposes relate to the strengthening of the Fellowship and the advancement of its message, through well-planned International Conventions. The detailed work inherent in putting on the Convention is executed by the Convention coordinator and a professional Convention Consultant.

At the October meeting following the Convention, we reviewed the unaudited financial results of the 2015 International Convention, noting that the Convention financials reflected a preliminary unaudited deficit of \$219,000. Also in October, the committee recommended to the General Service Board that Al-Anon be invited to participate in A.A.'s International Convention in 2020 in Detroit, Michigan. Al-Anon's participation will be based on their participation in 2015 in Atlanta, 2010 in San Antonio, 2005 in Toronto, and 2000 in Minneapolis.

At the January 2016 meeting, the committee discussed the process of issuing Requests for Proposals (RFP) for the Consultant/Management company to assist with the 2020 International Convention in Detroit, and agreed to move forward with the mailing of the RFPs following the February 1, 2016 meeting of the General Service Board. The committee asked that a report with a short list of the top candidates be brought to the trustees' Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums for review at the July 2016 meeting. Also at the January 2016 meeting the committee considered a request to produce, and make available for sale, video recordings of International Convention A.A. meetings which are interpreted in American Sign Language and asked the staff secretary to gather further information on costs and possible recording options.

Regional Forums — Since the 2015 General Service Conference, Regional Forums have been held in the Northeast, West Central, Southwest and East Central regions. An "Additional" Forum was held in Western Canada and a Local Forum in Eastern Canada. All were well attended by enthusiastic A.A. members interested in learning more about the General Service Board, General Service Office and A.A. Grapevine. Many in attendance were experiencing their first Forum. Each Forum was viewed as an opportunity to exchange information among local trusted servants, A.A.s interested in service, trustees, directors and staff of G.S.O. and Grapevine.

Equally important was the opportunity to hear sharing of experience, strength and hope, as well as challenges and successes of A.A. members on the front lines of service. Following each Regional Forum the trustees' Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums reviewed a summary of the Forum evaluation questionnaires.

Also since the 2015 General Service Conference, our committee has met three times. The committee reviewed and approved the schedule for the 2015-2017 Forums and the board members attending the 2016 Regional Forums. After discussion, the committee recommended to the General Service Board that the request for a late 2016 Local Forum, to be hosted by the Queens County A.A. community in Area 49, Southeast New York, be approved.

Questionnaires were reviewed from the 2014 Southeast Regional Forum, the 2015 Northeast, West Central, Southwest, and East Central Regional Forums along with the 2015 "Additional" Forum in Western Canada. Additionally, the committee discussed the content of Regional Forums and noted the benefits of personal sharing within trustee and staff presentations. The committee asked the staff secretary to explore options for trustee and staff presentations to include a blending of written material along with opportunity for sharing their experience, strength and hope in service. Finally, the staff secretary was asked by the committee to explore ideas for trustee and staff Regional Forum presentations to be video-produced in anonymity-protected formats and to be made available to the Fellowship in additional avenues, including aa.org. The following Forums are scheduled for 2016:

2016		
June 3-5	"Additional" Southwest	Denver, CO
July 8-10	Eastern Canada	Thunder Bay, ON
September 30-October 2	Pacific	Waikoloa, Hawaii
December 2-4	Southeast	Orlando, FL

Bill Farnsworth, chairperson

Staff reports:

International Convention — the assignment entails coordinating the myriad details involved in producing the A.A. International Convention, held every five years. Working with four committees — Trustees, Conference, G.S.O. Planning and Host — the International Convention coordinator is responsible for bringing the Convention to life and ensuring that thousands of A.A.s can share and celebrate A.A.'s Anniversary.

Last July saw the successful culmination of years of work by then coordinator Eva Sanchez. Members of Alcoholics Anonymous and their families and friends from all over the world celebrated A.A.'s 80th Anniversary at the 2015

International Convention, July 2-5 in Atlanta, Georgia. The theme of the Convention, "80 Years — Happy, Joyous and Free," resonated throughout this joyous weekend.

The 2015 Convention included meetings, panels, workshops, marathons and stadium events. The Convention began on Thursday evening with dances and, beginning at midnight, marathon meetings got underway in all three official languages of the General Service Conference U.S./Canada — English, French and Spanish.

Opening ceremonies were held Friday night at the Georgia Dome, complete with the Parade of Flags of those countries represented at the Convention, followed by the Big A.A. Meeting. On Saturday night, there was the Oldtimers Meeting and on Sunday morning, the customary Closing Meeting at the stadium.

Local A.A. Host Committee volunteers numbered about 4,000 and did a fabulous job welcoming the many visitors to Atlanta. For family members and loved ones that belong to Al-Anon or Alateen who accompanied us to Atlanta, daytime meetings, workshops, marathons and other events were offered at the Marriott Marquis in downtown Atlanta.

While still on the back burner, initial plans are underway for the next International Convention in Detroit, July 2-5, 2020. Big Meetings will be held in the Ford Field Stadium and other meetings will take place in the Cobo Conference/Exhibition Center and at local hotels. Notifications about the Convention, including housing and registration information, will be made available as we get closer to the dates. Starting in 2019, there will be articles in *Box 4-5-9*, which is sent to the general service representative of every group listed with G.S.O. Information will also be accessible on G.S.O.'s A.A. website.

Julio Espallat

Regional Forums — The staff member handling Regional Forums is responsible for coordinating and following through on all arrangements necessary for holding Regional Forums and Additional Regional Forums in the U.S. and Canada. These sharing weekends help foster wider communication and understanding among A.A. groups, members and trusted servants in a region, the General Service Board, A.A. World Services, Inc., A.A. Grapevine Corporate Board, and Grapevine and General Service Office staff. Regional Forums are organized by the General Service Board and regularly scheduled at the invitation of a particular region every two years.

The Regional Forums coordinator at G.S.O. distributes the annual Regional Forum flyers and individual Forum registration forms to trusted service workers in the region and coordinates Forum details: hotel arrangements, program, displays, on-site registration, etc. The Regional Forums coordinator works closely with the host contact who recruits volunteers to assist staff with hospitality, set-up and registration during the Forum weekend. The location for a Regional Forum is decided jointly by the regional trustee, area delegates and G.S.O., who also suggest presentations and workshops. The Regional Forums

coordinator is also responsible for overseeing the preparation and distribution of an “early bird” newsletter at each Forum and forwarding a Forum Final Report to all who attend. Advance planning and on-site work gets done with the help of a very able staff assistant.

In October 2006, the General Service Board implemented Additional and Local Forums on a five-year trial basis. In July 2012, the General Service Board agreed to discontinue Additional Regional Forums after completion of the eight region cycle in 2016. The board noted the cost of each Forum and the impact on the attendance and effectiveness of Regional Forums when three consecutive yearly Forums are held in any one region.

The General Service Board also agreed that regions continue to be encouraged to support Local Forums structured to meet cultural, accessibility and population considerations within their own A.A. communities, and that the trustees’ Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums continue to annually approve, at its July meeting, travel of up to two members of the General Service Board, nontrustee directors of the A.A.W.S. or Grapevine Boards or the G.S.O. or Grapevine staff at up to three Local Forums.

The staff member on the Regional Forums assignment serves as cosecretary to the trustees’ and Conference International Conventions/Regional Forums Committees.

Steve Smith

LITERATURE

Trustees’ report: This report offers a summary of the literature projects of the trustees’ Committee on Literature since the 2015 General Service Conference.

Projects resulting from 2015 Advisory Actions and Additional Committee Considerations of the General Service Conference

- “*Inside A.A. Understanding the Fellowship and Its Services*” — The committee asked the Publishing department to

revise the pamphlet so that it better reflects the full range of A.A. services and to bring the revised draft pamphlet or a progress report to the January 2016 meeting. A fully-revised draft pamphlet was reviewed by the committee and forwarded to the 2016 Conference Committee on Literature.

- “*A.A. and the Gay/Lesbian Alcoholic*” pamphlet — A subcommittee was appointed to revise the pamphlet to reflect a broader scope and to prepare a draft revised pamphlet or progress report for the January 2016 meeting. The committee forwarded a progress report to the 2016 Conference Committee on Literature.

- “*A.A. and the Woman*” pamphlet — A subcommittee was appointed to work on a revision of this pamphlet. A progress report was reviewed by the committee and forwarded to the 2016 Conference Committee on Literature.

- *Develop literature for the alcoholic with mental issues* — A subcommittee was appointed to work on this project. A progress report was reviewed by the committee and forwarded to the 2016 Conference Committee on Literature.

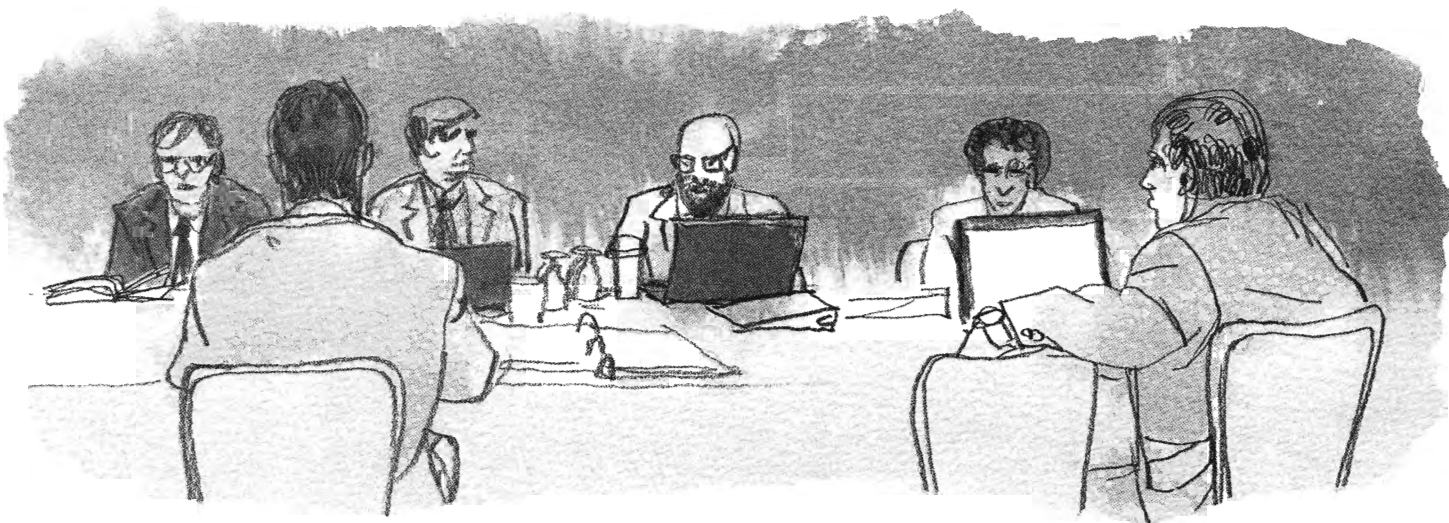
- *Develop a plan for the systematic review of A.A. recovery literature* — In response to an Additional Committee Consideration, a subcommittee was appointed to work with a staff member on a plan for the systematic review. A progress report was reviewed by the committee and forwarded to the 2016 Conference Committee on Literature.

Additional Items reviewed, discussed and forwarded to the 2016 Conference Committee on Literature:

- To develop a plain language version of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*.
- To revise the pamphlet “Young People and A.A.” to include information on young people’s conferences.
- To update the pamphlet “Twelve Traditions Illustrated.”

No Action Items:

At their quarterly meetings the committee thoroughly discussed and took no action on the following items:



- Suggestion to produce a Pocket Guide to the Steps, Traditions and Concepts. The committee noted that there was no widely expressed need for such a piece and that needed service material can be produced locally.

- Request to revise the *Living Sober* book to include *The A.A. Service Manual/ Twelve Concepts for World Service* to the list of recovery literature noted in "Reading the A.A. Message." The committee noted that there was no widely expressed need to revise the *Living Sober* book as requested.

- Request to remove a story from the pamphlet "Young People and A.A." The committee agreed that all stories submitted from the Fellowship for consideration to be included in A.A. literature are considered spiritual anonymous contributions.

- Request to review the "Appendix on the Spiritual Experience" in the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, specifically with respect to attribution of the quote "contempt prior to investigation." The committee observed that attribution of the quote "contempt prior to investigation" has been researched and addressed, including but not limited to, in the "Frequently Asked Questions" on the aa.org website.

- Request to reconsider changes to the "Primary Purpose Card." The committee acknowledged that the item was fully discussed and considered by the 2014 General Service Conference.

- Request to revise the pamphlet "Many Paths to Spirituality." The committee noted that, at this time, there is no widely expressed need from the Fellowship for revisions to this pamphlet.

Joe Downey, chairperson

Staff report: As secretary to the trustees' and Conference Committees on Literature, the Literature coordinator works closely with the editors, writers and illustrators on reviewing all new recovery pamphlets, books and audio-visuals, in accordance with recommendations from the General Service Conference. Along with the Publishing department, the coordinator follows the progress of writers and illustrators on the updating and revising of all exist-

ing recovery books, booklets and pamphlets.

Final design and production of all this material is under the auspices of the A.A. World Services Publishing Department.

The Literature desk receives and responds to correspondence from A.A. members and groups about A.A. literature. Many of these inquiries are passed along to our Order Entry department, our Customer Service representatives, our Publishing staff and our Archives staff. Contact is also maintained with all current area, district, and intergroup/central office literature chairpersons. Each newly elected literature chairperson receives a welcoming letter

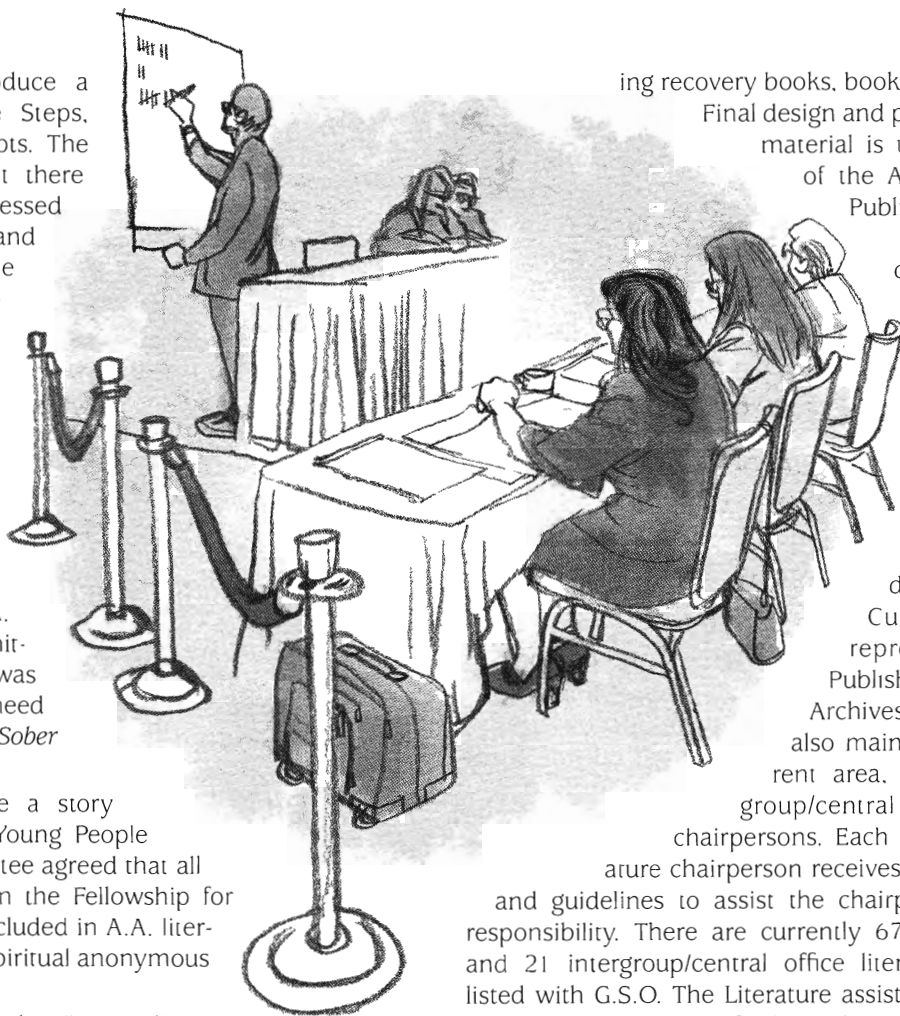
and guidelines to assist the chairperson in this vital responsibility. There are currently 67 area, 404 district and 21 intergroup/central office literature chairpersons listed with G.S.O. The Literature assistant is invaluable in supporting and helping facilitate the responsibilities of this aspect of the assignment.

The Literature staff member also gathers sharing for *Box 4-5-9*, working closely with the Publishing department managing editor to continue to provide the Fellowship with news and notes from G.S.O. Such "news and notes" may include articles containing shared experience from A.A. Conference-approved literature that addresses questions raised in multiple phone calls, emails and letters to staff members. G.S.O. always welcomes committee sharing on service from the Fellowship, which may be included in articles so that *Box 4-5-9* can be an accurate reflection of both Fellowship and G.S.O. activities.

Box 4-5-9 is published in English, French and Spanish with current quarterly distribution of 61,744 copies in English, 1,425 copies in French and 2,791 copies in Spanish. In addition, there are currently 10,996 subscribers to the digital delivery service for *Box 4-5-9* available through G.S.O.'s A.A. website. Also on the website the interested A.A. member can find a digital copy of every issue of *Box 4-5-9* going back to the original issue from 1956.

As literature is essential in helping to carry our message of recovery, this remains a challenging and rewarding assignment.

Sandra Wilson



NOMINATING

Trustees' report: The trustees' Committee on Nominating of the General Service Board was first appointed by the chairman of the board on January 18, 1944. At that time primary responsibilities were to "establish criteria for and to review resumes of trustee candidates and directors and to make recommendations regarding electoral procedures and matters which may affect the composition of the board and election to it." (History and Actions of the trustees' Committee on Nominating)

Since that time the trustees' Committee on Nominating generally has met three times each year and, with the forming of the General Service Conference in 1951, the committee began to meet annually with the Conference Committee on Trustees. The responsibilities of the committee grew over time to encompass criteria for all vacancies, whether in the ranks of trustees or among key service directors and staff members.

Activities of this committee in the past year:

- *Class A Trustee Election* — The committee created a list of seven Class A (nonalcoholic) trustee applicants to interview during the January 2016 General Service Board weekend.

Following the interviews, the committee recommended to the General Service Board that the Honorable Christine Carpenter and Nancy McCarthy, be invited to serve as Class A trustees to succeed John Fromson, M.D. and Michele Grinberg, J.D. following the 2016 General Service Conference.

- *Regional Trustee Elections* — The committee recommended to the General Service Board, as eligible for election in April 2016, all candidates submitted for West Central and Western Canada regional trustees.

- *Board Slates* — The committee reviewed and recommended proposed slates of General Service Board members, officers of the board, and A.A. World Services and A.A. Grapevine directors to the annual meeting of the members of the General Service Board in April 2016, following presentation at the 2016 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any.

- *A.A.W.S. Directors* — The committee recommended that Richard Purtell serve as trustee director for a two-year term on A.A. World Services, Inc. to succeed Chet Parker. The trustees' Committee on Nominating also agreed to a request from the A.A.W.S. Board to initiate a search for a new nontrustee director, who would replace Carole Boerner on the A.A.W.S. Board in 2016.

- *A.A. Grapevine Directors* — The committee recommended that Carole Boerner serve as a general service trustee, replacing Ed Martin on the A.A. Grapevine Board; the committee recommended that Yolanda Flores serve as trustee director for a two-year term to succeed Bill Farnsworth on the A.A. Grapevine Board, the committee also recommended that Josh Eggleston serve as nontrustee director on the A.A. Grapevine Corporate Board following the 2016

General Service Conference.

- *General Service Board Chair search* — The committee reviewed the process for the General Service Board chair search to replace Terry Bedient after the April 2017 Conference and agreed to begin the search according to the schedule provided.

- *Committee's Composition, Scope and Procedures* — In the past year the committee reviewed the Composition, Scope and Procedures and recommended that the sentence in the trustees' Committee on Nominating's Composition, Scope and Procedure, under Procedures which currently reads: "Minutes of committee reports are sent to the members of the corresponding Conference committee," be replaced with: "Following the quarterly meetings, meeting highlights are reported in the *Quarterly Report* from G.S.O. and sent to the corresponding Conference committee."

At the August meeting, the committee reviewed the trustees' Committee on Nominating's Procedure No. 4 (Procedures for Election of Class A Trustees) and requested that the staff secretary develop language for paragraph one to include communication with nonalcoholic participants in the most recent two International Conventions.

At the October meeting the committee reviewed the suggested addition to Procedure #4 and recommended to the General Service Board that the phrase, "In the year of an International Convention, announcement letters will be sent to the nonalcoholic professionals chosen to participate in the International Convention," be added to section 1 of Procedure #4 (Procedures for Election of Class A Trustees) of their Composition, Scope and Procedure. Additionally, the trustees' Committee on Nominating recommended to the General Service Board revisions to the Procedures and Areas of Authority under the headings "Position," and





"Immediate approval of the recommendation rests with" related to the approval of recommendations to fill various Grapevine employee positions.

- *Appointed Committee Members* — The committee recommended the reappointment of Caroline Carney of New York, NY for an additional one-year term as appointed committee members on the trustees' Committee on Public Information.

- *Ratio of voters for trustee-at-large/Canada* — The committee carefully reviewed information related to the ratio of voters during the process of electing the trustee-at-large/Canada and after discussion agreed to take no action. The committee carefully considered the concerns expressed, but agreed that the current procedure provides clear direction for the election of trustee-at-large/Canada.

- *Concept Eleven* — The committee reviewed two communications related to the recruitment of General Service Board trustees, which addressed two paragraphs in the Concept Eleven essay from *Twelve Concepts for World Service* by Bill W. The committee carefully reviewed the communications in regards to matters related to the recruitment of future trustees and agreed that the request for review of the paragraphs in the Concept Eleven essay be forwarded to the trustees' Committee on Literature for consideration.

- *Expanding the Pool of Candidates* — The committee reviewed a report from the Subcommittee on Expanding the Pool of Candidates and noted that the report included a variety of options that can be utilized in the distribution of vacancy notifications. The report also includes a suggestion to request additional direction from the General Service Board on the ideal skills that would most benefit the General Service Board at the time. The com-

mittee agreed to forward the subcommittee report to the Conference Committee on Trustees for their review.

- *Unexpected Vacancy of a Regional Trustee* — The committee reviewed the report from the Subcommittee on the Unexpected Vacancy of a Regional Trustee, and after careful discussion, agreed to forward to the Conference Committee on Trustees the following option for their consideration

If a vacancy for a Regional Trustee occurs prior to September 1 in the first year, then an election for a three-year term would occur at the following General Service Conference (GSC) for the affected region. If a vacancy for a Regional Trustee occurs between September 1 in the first year and August 31 of the third year then the delegates from the affected region would be given an option to hold an election for a six-year or five-year term, or leave the position vacant, depending on when the vacancy occurs. Regardless of whether the term was for three, five or six years, the Regional Trustee would be expected to serve two-years on one of the two operating corporation boards.

Bill Noonan, chairperson

Staff report: This assignment's staff member is responsible to the trustees' Committee on Nominating, and to the Conference Committee on Trustees, serving as secretary to these committees as well as to trustees' subcommittees. Since the last Conference, the staff member prepared background, minutes and reports for three quarterly trustees' committee meetings. The staff member worked with the trustees' Committee on vacancy announcements, sent time commitment and interest status letters to Class A candidates. The staff member later sent follow up letters to Class A candidates, and organized the interview scheduling processes of the search for two Class A trustees to succeed John Fromson and Michele Grinberg. The staff member also coordinated the transcription and review of resumes for Class B trustee candidates who made their names available to participate in this year's Conference elections procedure.

Julio Espaillat

PUBLIC INFORMATION

Trustees' report: The trustees' Committee on Public Information is charged with the responsibility of helping the membership carry the A.A. message of recovery through the general public to the alcoholic who still suffers. We do this by recommending and coordinating activities which include: creating a greater public understanding of the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous; producing video and audio public service announcements (P.S.A.s); preparing and posting press releases on aa.org; coordinating health fairs and other community and school exhibits with local P.I. committees; conducting the triennial A.A. Membership Survey; and carrying A.A.'s message through electronic as well as print media. Projects over the past year have included:

- *Anonymity* — Because this vital principle lies at the heart of all our Traditions, the committee discussed a number of topics and related literature:

- *Annual Mailings*: The committee reviewed and accepted the text of the annual Anonymity Letter to the Media, which includes a link to a brief video on anonymity, to be emailed to approximately 30,000 media professionals. The committee also reviewed the text of the Memo to Tapers. The staff secretary will follow up with distributing this item in 2016 in the same manner as 2015, including copying all delegates on this mailing.
- *Launch of Anonymity Resource Page on aa.org*: A new Anonymity Resource Page was added to aa.org so that all available resources on anonymity might be gathered for easy access. The new page can be found on the *Information for A.A. Members* page.
- *G.S.O.'s A.A. Website* — The committee reviewed quarterly reports from the A.A.W.S. Board regarding changes to aa.org, updates on website activity, a summary of requests from the Fellowship regarding the website, a summary of actions taken by the A.A.W.S. Board in response to those requests and status reports on the redesign of G.S.O.'s A.A. website. An annual report by the A.A.W.S. Board was forwarded to the 2016 Conference Public Information Committee, along with a report from the trustees' Public Information Committee on website analytics.
- *A.A. Grapevine/La Viña Website* — The committee reviewed reports from the Grapevine Board on the Grapevine/La Viña website activity.
- *Public Information Comprehensive Media Plan* — In July, a subcommittee was appointed to review and develop the Public Information Comprehensive Media Plan. The trustees' Public Information Committee reviewed the final report from the subcommittee on the Public Information Comprehensive Media Plan, and agreed to forward to the 2016 Conference Committee on Public Information:
 - A recommendation for the implementation of both a Google-For-Non-Profits and a Twitter account for carrying the message of A.A. to the public.
 - A recommendation that a guideline be developed on "Carrying the A.A. Message Online and in Social Media."
 - The 2016 Public Information Comprehensive Media Plan.
- The trustees' Public Information Committee also agreed to forward:
 - To the trustee's Cooperation With the Professional Community Committee, a request to explore the feasibility and potential implementation of an official LinkedIn page for the purpose of cooperation with the professional community.
 - To the trustee's Archives Committee, a request to explore the feasibility and potential implementation of an official A.A. Flickr page dedicated to the public display of historic A.A. photos, illustrations, and other

artifacts from A.A. history with links to aa.org and aagrapevine.org for additional information.

- To the A.A.W.S. Board, a request to explore the addition of content sharing functionality (i.e. share buttons) to aa.org.
- To the A.A. Grapevine Board, a request to explore the addition of content sharing functionality (i.e. share buttons) to aagrapevine.org.

Membership Survey — The results of the 2014 Alcoholics Anonymous Membership Survey were produced in pamphlet and tabletop display formats.

Video P.S.A.s — The 2015 Conference-approved video P.S.A. "Doors" was finalized and made available. Distribution and tracking reports for the new "Doors" P.S.A. were reviewed by the trustees' Public Information Committee and forwarded to the 2016 Conference Committee on Public Information as background. The committee reviewed the final report from the subcommittee on the Usefulness and Relevance of Public Service Announcements and agreed to forward the report to the 2016 Conference Committee on Public Information, including:

- A recommendation that the video P.S.A. "Tengo Esperanza," in English and French, be centrally distributed, tracked and evaluated at a cost not to exceed \$40,000.
- A recommendation that the video P.S.A. "I Thought" be discontinued.

Member-submitted video on anonymity — The trustees' Public Information Committee took no action regarding the suggestion to develop a proposal to request member-produced videos regarding anonymity, noting the difficulties in gathering broadcast quality video submissions that the "Young People" video project encountered and the difficulty in identifying an appropriate distribution model.

Anonymity online video — The committee reviewed a request to produce a video "aimed at the Fellowship," that would address the A.A. member's responsibilities in regard to anonymity online. The trustees' Committee took no action noting that a 2015 Conference Advisory Action already authorized the creation of video service material.

Full face video policy — The trustees' Public Information Committee reviewed a request to reconsider the 2011 Conference Action regarding the use of full faces in A.A. videos and





agreed to forward the request to the 2016 Conference Committee on Public Information

P.I. Kit — In response to an Additional Consideration from the 2015 Conference Committee on Public Information the committee requested that the Public Information Kit contents on the Public Information Committee page of aa.org have links to those items available online. In July 2015 the links on the English language page were completed and the French and Spanish page links are in process. The P.I. Workbook has been updated to reflect the 2015 Conference Committee on Public Information's Additional Considerations. These changes included updating the anonymity statement under *Sample Meeting Format*, expanded information regarding aa.org under "G.S.O.'s A.A. Website," and including the 2015 annual letter to the media which provides information on the new Anonymity Video.

The committee remains committed to doing all it can to assist the membership in its service of carrying the message of recovery through public resources to the general public and to the alcoholic who still suffers, and welcomes suggestions from the Fellowship as to what more can be done.

Ivan Lemelle, chairperson

Staff report: This assignment is charged with assisting the A.A. members who carry our message to the suffering alcoholic through the public — schools, health fairs, community events, libraries, and all forms of media. Below are some of the ways that this task is carried out:

- Communicate with 879 P.I. committee chairpersons at the area, district, intergroup/central office and group level to provide them with Workbooks, Guidelines, and current shared information on Public Information activity.
- Provide literature to supplement the efforts of local Public Information committees which are serving as a resource about Alcoholics Anonymous at local health and community fairs.
- Provide P.I. committees with information regarding the production and distribution of video and audio Public Service Announcements (P.S.A.s), in order to enhance their efforts on the local level, and refer all media requests for P.S.A.s to local committees.
- Respond to all inquiries that come to the office from the media, providing them with accurate information about Alcoholics Anonymous. Coordinate media coverage of International Conventions, held every five years. Work closely with Publishing department regarding development and distribution of press releases.
- Read and review media stories that mention Alcoholics Anonymous, and receive information from members regarding anonymity breaks at the level of press, radio, films, television and the Internet.
- Pass along instances of anonymity breaks in the media to the delegate in the area in which the break occurred, and provide them with an opportunity to contact the member and share experience regarding our Eleventh Tradition.
- Send out the Annual Anonymity Letter to the Media. In April 2015 the letter was emailed to over 29,500 media

outlets in the U.S. and Canada. The email included a link to view a brief video on anonymity on aa.org. The letter was distributed to a variety of media outlets including newspapers, wire services, radio stations, and TV networks, stations and cable services.

- Coordinate production of new television and radio Public Service Announcements as necessary, and work with the Publishing department regarding available formats and delivery options.
- Work closely with Publishing department regarding development and updating of Conference-approved literature and assignment related service material.
- Coordinate the triennial A.A. Membership Survey. The results of triennial surveys are published in pamphlet form and as a table display for visual information about Alcoholics Anonymous at public events.
- Participate as a member of the Intra-Office Website Committee, which reviews suggested changes to the aa.org website, a key aspect of our Public Information efforts.

The goal of Public Information work at G.S.O. is to see that the A.A. message of recovery reaches the still-suffering alcoholic by informing the general public about the A.A. program.

Clay Rittenhouse

STAFF COORDINATOR

Staff report: The General Service Office provides services to A.A. groups and members, and shares A.A. experience when available. Twelve A.A. members comprise the "G.S.O. Staff" with each person responsible for a functional assignment in addition to responding to requests from a specific region in Canada and the U.S., or from other countries. The staff coordinator shares responsibility for corresponding with members from the Southwest region, covering the busy six months of the year for the Conference coordinator

In 2015, the staff received 91,074 pieces of correspondence by mail, email and fax, a 1.25% increase over correspondence received in 2014. The staff also answers many phone calls daily. The staff coordinator helps to assure that letters are answered when staff members are involved in large projects or away from the office to attend A.A. events, or at times of illness or vacation. Mail, email, faxes, etc., are responded to within ten business days.

G.S.O. staff benefits from the experience of A.A. groups gathered over many years. These resources are passed on to members who seek guidance for their group, central office, district or area assembly. Questions and requests for

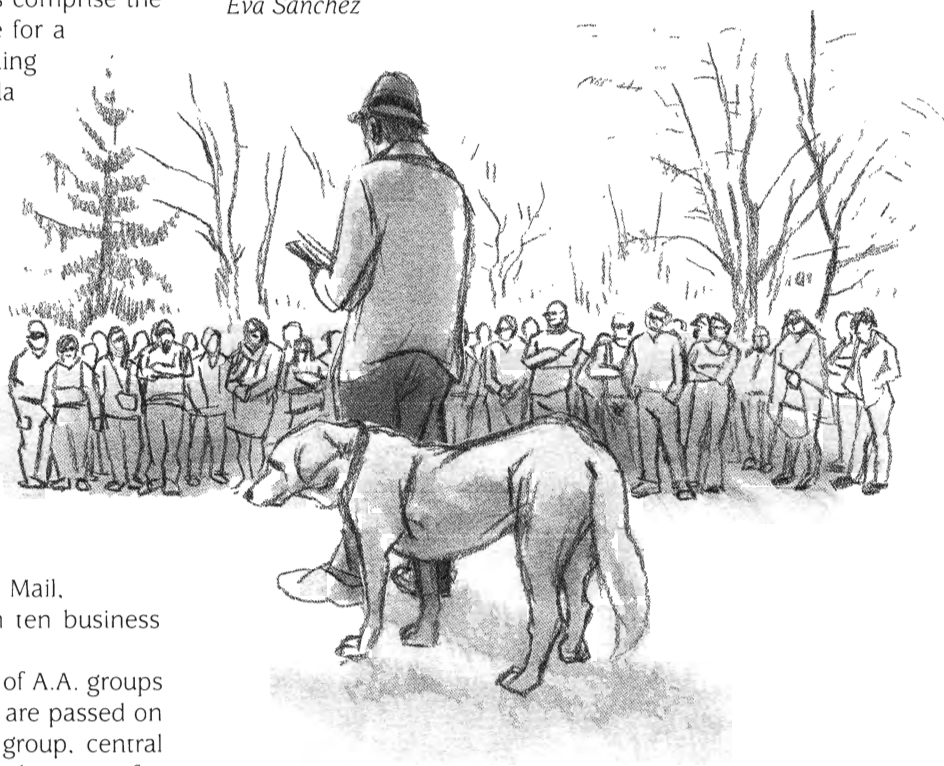
sharing from the Fellowship are often brought to weekly staff meetings, so that responses reflect either research from A.A. literature or service material or the collective experience of G.S.O. staff and archives. Our weekly staff meetings provide a forum for sharing ideas on how to better serve A.A. groups and members or how to provide the most complete answers to Fellowship inquiries.

G.S.O. staff members serve as secretaries to trustees' and Conference Committees and also are voting members of the General Service Conference. The staff coordinator is secretary to the Conference Policy/Admissions Committee.

During the months of January through August in 2015, G.S.O. welcomed a total of 1,646 individuals, including many English- and Spanish-speaking groups ranging in size from 10 to 50. Each visitor had an opportunity to see and hear "how G.S.O. works" and view a display of Grapevine material during a tour of G.S.O. Often visiting members and guests attend the open A.A. meeting held at G.S.O. at 11:00 a.m. on Fridays. This is an opportunity for the G.S.O. staff to welcome A.A. members from all over the world or from around the corner. Due to construction, no tours were conducted in the months of September through December.

The staff coordinator has the privilege of serving as a director on A.A. World Services, Inc. in accordance with Concept IV, and also serves as liaison between staff members and other G.S.O. departments. None of these activities would be possible without the dedication and skill of a very capable support staff.

Eva Sanchez



■ Area Service Highlights — Panel 66 Delegates (Only first-term delegates give Area Highlights)

Alaska: In Area 2, the A.A. message is carried above the Arctic Circle, on the Aleutian Chain and down in the SE Panhandle. Currently, Area 2 has 174 listed groups with over 3,000 members. Geographic distances are a factor but the language of the heart can be transmitted many ways. A statewide telephone A.A. meeting continues to help carry the message to communities off the road system and trips are planned periodically to remote communities. Teleconferences are also held monthly for area, district and other general service committee meetings. Our C.P.C. and Corrections committees are active and the Bridging the Gap program is blossoming. Literature and Grapevine committees have placed Big Books and Grapevines in all libraries around the state and our Archives is digitizing cassettes of oral histories and speaker tapes. The Area Committee recognizes the need to educate groups and districts about the services provided by G.S.O. and the importance of the Seventh Tradition. In the meantime, however, the area assembly voted to eliminate one budget assembly per panel. — *Laura Hansen*

Alberta/Northwest Territories: Area 78 is the largest area in North America, extending from the Canada-U.S. border to the Arctic Circle. The 48 districts are distributed throughout Alberta, the Northwest Territories, Nunavut, northeastern British Columbia, southeastern British Columbia and one community in Saskatchewan. There are 436 active groups with a membership of over 9,000. The area committee is made up of the six table officers, ten service committee chairs and the D.C.M. from each district. Our past delegate serves as a voting table officer for the two years following his term as delegate. The area committee meets twice a year in locations throughout the area. We have a pre-Conference assembly in March and a business assembly in September. We also have an appointed archivist and webmaster. Recently we established a standing E-Services committee. Our Remote Communities Committee hosts a very successful weekly Spirit of the North Video Conference open A.A. Meeting for members in isolated communities who have no access to regular meetings. — *Larry Mumby*

Arizona: Area 3 is fairly diverse with approximately 30% Hispanic and 5% Native Americans. There are over 2,200

A.A. meetings, with 1,026 of them listed in the G.S.O. database. We average close to 200 G.S.R.s at our assemblies. There are 54 local districts within our 15 county districts, with one overlying Hispanic Linguistic District with 54 active groups. We currently have 45 active prison groups, some of which have a G.S.R. on the outside. Our service structure assigns groups randomly to panels which mirror the General Service Conference committee structure. These panels meet at assemblies and make recommendations to our assembly body. Our area structure has a service arm made up of 12 coordinators and their committees. The Administrative Committee, which is made up of seven elected officers and five at-large members, has the responsibility to insure that assembly actions are implemented. We have four assemblies which are bid on by local districts and are held throughout our state. Area 3 continues to participate in the Navajo translation of the Big Book. We are currently in the vetting process to insure that the translation not only captures the verbiage, but also the language of the heart. — *Dave Bradford*

California (Mid-Southern): Area 9 is one of six areas in the state and spans four counties: Orange, San Bernardino, Riverside, and part of Los Angeles, which includes the city of Long Beach. We have a total of 12 area meetings per year including three general assemblies, six area service committee meetings, a pre-Conference Workshop, a Servathon, and a jointly hosted event by the Spanish- and English-speaking districts called the FORO. We are comprised of 24 districts, most are divided into subdistricts, making a D.C.M.C. necessary. Six districts are Spanish-speaking. We have a total of 3,473 groups from which approximately 70% are existing meetings, however, only 51% are currently listed as active with G.S.O. We have a total of 14 central offices, including five Spanish-speaking central offices. Each of the intergroups has a vote at our assemblies. Our area is also comprised of 16 standing committees, half of which have a Spanish-speaking co-chair. We have a robust YPAA presence (Young People in A.A.) in our area and they too have a vote at our assemblies. We also have an active H&I presence which brings panels of A.A.s to institutions. — *Joe Carlon*



California (Northern Interior): Area 7 is the largest of the six areas in California. We have approximately 1,016 groups and 28,801 members. There are 29 districts including four Spanish-speaking districts. We have seven elected area officers and nine appointed area positions. We hold four assemblies a year and eight area committee meetings. We foster group participation through extensive interaction with our G.S.R.s. Every year, we hold Agenda Topic Workshops and conduct an area inventory every other year. We will be hosting the 2017 PRAASA in Sacramento. Our G.S.R.s stand at the mike anxiously waiting to give their groups report on the agenda items at the pre-Conference Assembly. Our past delegates continue to be available to offer counsel and assistance year after year. Our groups support our general service efforts by giving generously of their time and money. — *Vikki Ray*

California (San Diego-Imperial): In Area 8 we are working hard to attract A.A. members to experience our Third Legacy by inviting them to participate on the San Diego-Imperial Area's 13 standing committees. Our two self-funded H&I committees are voting members of our assembly. One of our districts has a CEC Committee that is interacting with the area's C.P.C. Committee. Each year we connect with Areas 5, 9, and 93 for our 4-Area D.C.M. Sharing Session. New in 2016, we are planning a 4-Area Spanish-speaking Women's Workshop. We hope this will become an annual event for an underserved A.A. population. The active participation of our Spanish-speaking districts includes members in Tijuana, Mexico. Our deaf community has eight ASL-interpreted meetings per week and many of our deaf members serve on our highly active Accessibilities Committee and as G.S.R.s. We are discussing revisions to our financial guideline. Our three YPAAs have enthusiastic and mature leadership. We are urging our districts to interact with our area registrar after visiting unrepresented groups. We are currently in need of a Remote Nation's Liaison to serve in communicating with the 12 reservations in our area. — *Jane Giatras*

Delaware: Area 12 has 253 registered groups, 13 districts and three intergroups. Our area assembly meets four times a year; our area committee seven times. Our spring assembly is devoted to pre-Conference sharing to prepare the delegate for the General Service Conference. Area 12's committee structure includes Archives, Budget & Finance, CPC, Literature, Grapevine, Public Information as well as the Area Convention. Often, treatment and corrections activities are handled by the individual intergroups or by groups of individuals who are committed to that work. We have a majority of active districts, and we are delighted that more groups are electing G.S.R.s. Cofounder Bill W. in *A.A. Comes of Age* writes of the sacrificial nature of A.A. Traditions. He calls on us to sacrifice our personal desires for the good of the whole. In Area 12 we are committed to making the sacrifices necessary to transmit our dedication and enthusiasm for recovery

through service, using the experience of the whole to the benefit of the whole. — *Susan Riedy*

Georgia: Area 16 has 766 groups and 51 districts and zones, each represented by a D.C.M., with an estimated membership of over 19,000. This includes our linguistic (Spanish) district, which encompasses the entire area. Our area office in Macon maintains the lists of groups, distributes literature and answers numerous calls. It also houses the environmentally controlled repository for Area 16's archives. Georgia has three assemblies annually, along with a pre-Conference and a yearly planning meeting with all the area's D.C.M.s and committee chairpersons. Four area forums are held yearly in different regions. Area 16 has a prepaid state convention, financed by Georgia A.A. group contributions entirely, and allows for an experience without a registration cost to any Georgia member. Our 2015 State Convention, held shortly after the International Convention in Atlanta, had over 800 attendees. Our communication committee handles all aspects of our area website and publishes our bimonthly *Georgia Message*. The committee also is responsible for the translations done at the forums, assemblies, and individual district workshops. — *Ernest Murphy*

Idaho: Area 18 is composed of 12 districts, with over 239 registered groups and over 4,591 active members. In the last few rotations Area 18 has made strides to share the message with Spanish-speaking members, young members, and members with accessibility issues. These efforts have included the translation of the Area Guidelines, assembly materials, and fliers into Spanish; inclusion of a YPAA Special Committee chair on the area committee; and efforts to meet the needs of members with accessibility requirements. The area committee meets three times a year in the south-central part of the area and twice with the G.S.R.s at assemblies, rotated through the districts. In addition to the five other gatherings, the members of Area 18 come together in March to discuss the agenda for the upcoming General Service Conference. It is with great energy, love, and commitment that the members, groups, and committees inside of Area 18 serve the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous. — *Barry Smith*

Illinois (Northern): Area 20 has over 22,000 members in more than 1,260 groups. There are 25 districts, two of which are Spanish-speaking. The Spanish members are active in service at the area level and we have a Spanish interpreter at all our assemblies. We have four committee meetings each year, and they are scheduled before our four assemblies. Our area has a Service Orientation Workshop at every Winter Committee meeting. We encourage all A.A. members to attend. At our area meetings there are usually between 5-7 past delegates in attendance. Our Spring Conference has the business part of our Spring Assembly embedded within it; this allows us to have a full day to prepare our delegate for the

General Service Conference. Our area hosts an Illinois State Conference every third year that rotates between Area 19 Chicago and Area 21 Southern Illinois. This year the 43rd annual State Conference and East Central Regional Conference will be hosted by Area 20. This year will be our 23rd one-day Big Book Conference, which takes place every fall and is hosted by the districts. Besides having ten standing committees, with the Bridging the Gap Committee added at our 2014 fall assembly, there are five administrative committees appointed by the area chairperson and four appointed positions. — *Kelly Lambert*

Indiana (Central): Area 23 has over 740 meetings serviced by 41 districts, including our Hispanic district. In our efforts to continue to carry the message and create the service experience we conduct committee chair workshops and sharing sessions. We are also actively seeking American Sign Language (ASL) interpreters to assist with our new communities of deaf people. All A.A. members are encouraged to attend our area assemblies and we conduct G.S.R. schools and D.C.M. schools throughout southern Indiana. This year we are looking forward to finalizing our area inventory so that we can identify better ways to carry the message. In the upcoming year we will be conducting our five annual assemblies with our budget assembly being held in November. — *Charlotte Crabtree*

Kansas: Area 25 has an estimated A.A. membership of 8,750; currently there are 315 registered groups and 28 districts, three are linguistic. We are embarking on a platform of rebuilding and interest and enthusiasm for general service began to grow after we participated in the South West Region of Alcoholics Anonymous Service Assemblies. It was at these assemblies, where ideas are exchanged and effective means of committee work are discussed, that new ideas and shared collective experiences began to be implemented. For over 25 years, in an effort to emulate G.S.O., Area 25 has had a physical office, employed a special service worker, and had a board of directors. The employee was assigned responsibilities and performed duties that in other areas are performed by the delegate, area chair, area committees, registrars and the treasurer. With the recent announcement of our employee's retirement, an opportunity presented itself to move in a different direction. At our area assembly we made the decision to move forward without a paid employee. With the use of technology and a commitment comprised from the assembly body, we are beginning the process. So it is with anticipation that Area 25 is embarking on a new journey as we relearn and experience committee work anew. — *Sue Cunningham Neill*

Kentucky: Area 26 covers approximately 44,000 square miles in Kentucky and southern Indiana. We are mostly a rural area, with Louisville and Lexington our largest cities. We currently have 745 groups, served by 37 districts,

including one Spanish-speaking linguistic district. There are six intergroup/central offices that serve in and with our area. Our State Convention is held in February each year, hosted on a rotation basis throughout the area. We have four meetings each year, three Committee Meetings with an assembly in October. These weekends start at 9:00 a.m. Saturday morning with a "Welcome to Service" meeting for people new to service. Our D.C.M. meeting is held at the same time, allowing D.C.M.s to share their experience with each district. After lunch there are workshops by the hosting district and the area. Saturday afternoon there are D.C.M., Intergroup and Host Committee reports. An A.A. speaker meeting is held Saturday night. Sunday there are area officer and standing committee reports. Our 11 standing committees also meet at each area meeting. They carry workshops throughout the area during their term. — *Kenny Brown*

Maine: Area 28 represents Maine and parts of New Brunswick, Canada, with 20 active districts. As an area we are geographically challenged, as it is 480 miles from border to border north and south, as well as 200 miles east to west. We have approximately 462 groups in Maine and seven in Canada. Our Fellowship is served by 813 meetings a week including treatment facility meetings and meetings in a maximum security prison. Many of the meetings in the northern part of our area are French-speaking or bilingual and we have a meeting in the south that has ASL interpretation. Last year we became a non-profit corporation and are awaiting approval of our tax exempt status from the IRS. We hold two assemblies a year, in the spring and fall. Our area committee meets six times a year, of which one is a pre-Conference Forum and another is a post-Conference Forum. Our 17 committees are active in helping our members carry out our Twelfth Step efforts. Unfortunately only about 15% of our groups are represented at our assemblies. We are continuously trying to improve our communication by rotating our assemblies to different districts around the state; supporting numerous Love & Service Days; through information on our website; and publishing our newsletter, *The Boomerang*. Our area puts on a Round Up every summer that is attended by an average of 1,000 people. Our Fellowship is well served by our Down East Intergroup and a Central Service Office that provides needed services. — *Gene Wilson*

Manitoba: Area 80 is a province located at the longitudinal center of Canada, with a population of 1,300,000 over an area of 251,000 square miles. It has always been a challenge to serve the far districts and members in remote areas. We have made great progress in the last few years with teleconferencing and the Remote Community's trip on the winter roads. Two-thirds of our population and the majority of the 4,000 members live around Winnipeg. Manitoba Central Office is the literature hub for the area; it serves as Winnipeg Intergroup Office and many general

service committee meetings are held there. We are proud to be the first Canadian city to host the annual Archives Workshop in 2017. We have 14 districts with around 150 active groups. We hold four assemblies a year, two in Winnipeg and two in rural areas. Our assemblies deal with A.A. business, budget approvals, G.S.R. training, pre-Conference and delegate reports and workshops. We have eight standing committees and have been working diligently to parallel the work done at the Conference. Each year we hold a Gratitude Day, a Keystone conference in the fall, a winter conference in January and the River City Summer conference in June. Our treatment and corrections committees recently resurrected the Bridging the Gap program, which has insured many more people leave with information about A.A. and connected to a member willing to help. Area 80 will host WRAASA in February of 2017. — *Ian Rabb*

Maryland: Area 29 covers 21 of Maryland's 23 counties, has 34 districts with approximately 1,000 listed groups, over 15,000 members, and is served by ten intergroups. We redistricted in 2014 to assist in better serving our groups. We rotate our five assemblies, four committees and area mini-Conference to locations around the area. Our standing committees mirror those of the General Service Conference. There are eleven active Ad Hoc Committees and two annual conventions. We have eight past delegates who actively participate in a variety of ways. Area 29 recently revised its year-long Conference Agenda Review Committee process, which provides a forum for the Fellowship to inform the delegate of their views on selected Conference Agenda items. The CARCs meet in four locations covering the expanse of the entire area to discuss a modified agenda and develop pros and cons on specific agenda items for the annual mini-Conference in April. Our goal is ongoing communication to attract and keep A.A. members active in the Legacy of Service, both in our districts and the area, in order to promote a more informed group conscience. — *Linda Jopling*

Massachusetts (Western): Area 31, includes all of Western Massachusetts with some towns from north central Connecticut. Our beginning can be traced back to 1942 in Springfield. We now estimate over 300 registered groups with a membership of 5,300. These A.A.s have formed six districts, seven standing committees, two intergroup offices, an Institutions committee and Western Mass Young People of A.A. Our area committee meets monthly where its area officers, service committees and districts discuss how we carry the message and serve all. During the course of the year we meet at semiannual assemblies, the annual Roundup and workshops put on by the districts and committees. We reach out in service to the third party in our community by radio, visiting schools' student bodies and staff. Also, we work with our friends in treatment centers, hospitals and institutions

providing both meetings and information about our Fellowship. With our neighbor in Area 30 we host a Massachusetts State Convention every November. Area 31 had the opportunity to host our first NERAASA this year — its 25th Silver Anniversary! — *Mark Naegeli*

Michigan (Western): Area 34 has 583 registered groups meeting in 15 districts. District 17 is a Spanish-speaking group. Our assembly meets monthly, rotating throughout our districts. Our 12 standing committees meet in the morning except for months when a workshop is scheduled. We have newcomer orientation for new D.C.M.s and G.S.R.s, chaired by our alternate delegate and assisted by a past delegate. In March we hold a pre-Conference assembly to review the GSC agenda. Committees prepare a brief summary and the assembly votes on the agenda items, giving our delegate information on how Area 34 feels about the items discussed. Each quarter the three Michigan delegates, chairpersons, corrections and Grapevine chairs meet. The Statewide Corrections committee discusses how to carry the message into state prisons and puts on a Statewide Corrections Workshop annually. The Statewide Grapevine committee discusses Grapevine issues and puts on a panel or skit for the Convention. The Statewide Service committee meets to coordinate State Convention items and to put on our Mock Conference where agenda items are discussed and the Conference experience is duplicated. — *Jim Gordier*

Minnesota (Northern): Area 35 consists of 17 districts, divided into four zones starting from International Falls, close to the Canadian border, down to Elk River in the south. We currently have 535 registered groups. Our area committee consists of five officers, 11 Action Committee chairs and 17 D.C.M.s. We have two assemblies a year—spring and fall—along with a Service Workshop in January where we always use the Conference theme of that year. We meet as a committee four times a year. We have a newsletter, *The Northern Light*, which is published every other month covering news from our area. We have five prisons and several jails in which A.A. volunteers carry our message of hope. Our P.I. and C.P.C. Action Committee chairs are always busy educating our professionals and the public on what A.A. is and isn't. Also, in collaboration with Area 36, we meet once a year in a Workshop to exchange ideas and information. We also have a statewide Corrections Committee and work together so that individuals who request one will have a contact person when leaving a treatment center or a correctional facility within our state. We have implemented an online state-wide meeting locator that has had great results. Both areas yearly cover the Minnesota State Fair with volunteers in our A.A. booth. — *Kelly Dempster*

Mississippi: Area 37 currently has 4,554 members consisting of 228 groups in 22 districts. We have full assemblies quarterly that are one day events. Including

alternates there are nine area officers and 10 standing committees. We will be having our 67th State Convention this summer, and we have a full selection of conventions, roundups, group anniversaries and get togethers, both indoors and outdoors, averaging two per month with spring and fall events every weekend. There are 17 correction groups. District 51 has sent hundreds of Big Books to the state penitentiary at Parchman. We have had an excellent website since 1999, with most groups listing their meeting schedules and calendar of events. The site also has generic contacts for officers and standing committee chairs and a password-protected members-only section which archives area assembly minutes and newsletters. We have a per capita contribution rate of \$5.16, which is \$.25 higher than the average in the U.S. and Canada. We have overcome many diversity challenges and continue to meet those demands with P.I. and C.P.C work, trying to break through cultural perceptions of the nature of the illness, plus an awareness of the discomfort that being different can bring. While larger towns and cities have their intergroup and club activities, the closeness found in our many small town groups nurtures compassion and deepens the appreciation for anonymity. — *Harry "Bub" Branton*

Nebraska: An historic action occurred within Area 41 when the G.S.R.s, by an area united vote, were graced for the first time with voting privileges at all area assemblies. Being aligned with *The A.A. Service Manual* was the mind set of Area 41 as we move forward in service. This year Area 41 will be conducting a Reunion Inventory. The Reunion is an event that other areas may refer to as their State Convention, where it is possible to hear the delegate's report from the Conference. We will not be charging registration for non-A.A. members, staying in full spiritual thought and action of our Seventh Tradition. At one of our area assemblies in 2015 the Special Needs Committee forwarded an item for a vote to the area to rename their Committee to Accessibilities and Accommodations. This item passed at the area assembly by a vote of 60-8. — *Trent Geistlinger*

New Brunswick/Prince Edward Island: Area 81 is located on the east coast of Canada, just north of the state of Maine. Language mix is approximately 65% English, 35% French. We have 173 registered groups in 12 districts, including four penal institution groups, plus several unregistered meetings in other penal institutions. Meetings are also held in most treatment centers. We hold two area assemblies annually — May and October, plus one pre-Conference committee meeting in March, and one additional area committee meeting in August. Assemblies and area committee meeting locations vary, yet we try to keep reasonable travel distance. CERAASA (Canadian Eastern Regional A.A. Service Assembly) will be held in Moncton, New Brunswick in February 2017. Most area activities are conducted in English with a spat-

tering of French. Our least active district rarely attends these events and has little or no interaction of any kind with the other districts, the area or G.S.O. In my opinion this is because of our inability at the area level to provide service in the French language. As is probably the case in many localities with lower populations, to some degree the view of A.A. is predominantly "small town," meaning the North American and world picture of A.A. is not always acknowledged. Forty-one percent of our groups contributed to G.S.O. in 2015. There is little or no training for new D.C.M.s and G.S.R.s. Most communication is by email. In the past two years delegate to D.C.M. communication has improved considerably. — *Michael Dunn*

New Hampshire: Area 43 has some 716 groups among 15 districts, numbered 7 thru 21. We have indoor and outdoor activities year-round, such as picnics, cookouts, bonfires, round ups, dances and holiday Alcahons. This year will be our 50th annual convention. Information for all this activity, complete meeting list as well as our monthly e-newsletter, can all be found on our website, which is maintained by our webmaster who serves on the Technology committee, one of our 12 standing committees. We maintain an online store where you can purchase medallions, books, and other literature. We now use a mobile pay service for literature sales at many of our activities. Our centrally located office is known as the "Area Assembly," where we hold most committee meetings and maintain a walk in store. Area 43 has four area assemblies per year, the pre-Conference, post-Conference, inventory or election depending on the year, and a 4th assembly. The New Hampshire State Conference of Young People in A.A. has their own convention and activities. The area also maintains a toll free hotline where locals and visitors can call for help, basic information and receive a return call from a live alcoholic if needed. — *Dale Randolph*

New Jersey (Southern): Area 45 serves approximately 9,000 members attending 550 groups in 29 districts. Recent efforts have focused on ensuring that all of these districts are active in our assembly. Many of our districts host service related workshops as well as picnics and dances. We have 14 standing committees. Our quarterly assembly and committee meetings are hosted by our districts and we offer a new D.C.M./G.S.R. Orientation before each of our assemblies. We host an annual convention; 2016 is our 52nd. The convention is followed by our yearly mini-Conference which provides our delegate with an overview of the area's group conscience. We join our three intergroups in hosting an annual Day of Sharing and our alternate delegate acts as a liaison to the intergroups. Our Special Needs Committee has been working closely with the intergroups to accurately update meeting lists for those in need of special facilities. We have a longstanding tradition of cooperating with Al-Anon by providing literature, hosting meetings and having an A.A. speaker at their

annual state-wide convention. Our Grapevine Committee hosts a biennial Grape-Fest and writer's workshop. We have a website and our *Fourth Dimension* newsletter is available online. — *Andrew Levecchia*

New Mexico: Area 46 has 19 districts; two are Spanish-linguistic districts comprising the northern and southern halves of the state. The area assembly meets three times a year, March, September and December, in various cities throughout the state. An Area Convention is held each summer with districts bidding to host in a different city each year. The area committees mirror the Conference structure with traditional committees along with committees unique to Area 46. There are currently 14 standing committees. Last year the assembly approved the creation of a new Special Needs and Accessibility Committee. A unique committee to the structure is our Bilingual Committee addressing the needs of the large number of Spanish-speaking members in the area. The Bilingual Committee provides translation from Spanish to English, and vice versa, at each of our area assemblies and our Area Convention. We have a website and a newsletter, *El Farolito*, which can be accessed through the website. — *Jim Hollen*

New York (Hudson, Mohawk, Berkshire): Area 48, HMB, is the largest of the four areas of New York State. It holds more than 11,000 A.A.s who belong to almost 800 registered groups. We hold eight annual events including two voting assemblies on even number years and three in odd. We also have our annual Delegate's Day of Sharing and a new Joy of Service Day. In autumn of each year we hold our Area Convention. We have 18 districts, all active, and our area committee chairs are elected by the district chairs and work closely with them. This past year we were honored to host the Northeast Regional Forum in Albany, with wonderful attendance. Also as a result of our Area Inventory Day we voted to change our election procedures and have almost finished a complete revision of our area service manual. We have begun our new area workshops to increase interest in correctional work as HMB holds more than half the N.Y. state prisons in addition to the facilities of the more than 20 counties that make up the area. — *Bill Walker*

New York (Western): Area 50 currently serves approximately 308 active groups in an eight county area. There is one central office and three intergroups within 22 districts. The assembly meets seven times a year, eight when we have an election assembly. We participate at the Buffalo Fall Convention and the Cataract Convention in Niagara Falls in the spring. We host the New York State Informational Workshop this year on a rotating basis with the other three areas of New York State. After an inventory in the fall, an educational component to the Assembly was proposed by an ad hoc committee. That educational component is now an integral part of each assembly, in addition to committee process changes which include assigning new G.S.R.s to committees. The influx in participation from outlying

intergroups has doubled members. In April, the Archives Committee will host the sixth annual Archives Breakfast. It has been a unifying event for the area and presents an opportunity for everyone to fellowship, see our area archives and enjoy an excellent speaker. — *Wally Eick*

Ohio (Northwest): Area 55 currently covers 17 districts in Northwest Ohio and Monroe County, Michigan, and includes 4,500 members, 400 groups and over 500 meetings a week. The area contains two intergroup associations and the Intergroup Committee finances the central office as well. Area 55 has nine living past delegates, who are frequently asked for their experience, strength and hope. There are six standing committees, and we currently hold monthly assembly meetings in downtown Toledo. Our committee responsibilities are year round and our area meets monthly. Our State Convention rotates between the four Areas in Ohio. We are working hard at filling our district seats, and are striving to increase participation of all our districts. As always, our goals are to foster unity between intergroup associations and general service, and to grow and remain responsive to change so we may be of maximum service to those we serve and those yet to come to our Fellowship. — *John Carter*

Ohio (Southwest): Area 56 includes rural, suburban and urban populations in 15 counties. We have 30 districts, of which seven are active. The active districts primarily serve our rural populations, while the areas surrounding Cincinnati and Dayton are supported by each city's intergroup. We recently framed a mission statement to make it easier for local A.A. members to understand what and who we are. In order to make general service attractive to more people, our latest inventory led to changes: we went from eleven monthly meetings a year, of which six were assemblies, down to three. We also established an Area Committee — as suggested in *The A.A. Service Manual* — which will meet roughly every other month. We continue to emphasize the importance of our annual mini-Conference, held every March. This event prepares the delegate for the General Service Conference. In Area 56, we continue to improve our communication with groups and members alike. This is the key both to effective service and to a healthy group conscience. — *Laura Goostree*

Ontario (Northeast): Area 84 is comprised of seven districts serving groups in urban settings along with smaller outlying rural communities. We have over 150 groups, several of our meetings are French-speaking and hundreds of A.A. members are bilingual. Most of our districts host a one or two day roundup at different times of the year. Some of our districts even rotate a fall business meeting to a more isolated town within their district as a gesture of inclusiveness. We have one intergroup office within the two districts and all our districts have a functioning answering service. Our Archives is in flux as affordable rental space comes available. Recently, we hosted a Local

Forum in Timmins, a powerful and informative weekend that we hope will revitalize this district. We have a yearly spring sharing session before each Conference, along with three general service meetings and one fall voting assembly. Area 84 holds an annual fall convention which presently rotates between three of our largest cities. This year it will be our 49th convention in Sault St. Marie. Our website is now becoming a more practical and economical way to communicate the business of A.A. between all levels of service to post minutes, guidelines and upcoming events in a timely fashion. — *Jim Cullen*

Ontario (Western): Area 86 has about 850 groups in 23 districts and a membership of over 11,000 alcoholics. Our area extends from the Windsor/Detroit border north to Sundridge, Ontario, which is 50 miles south of North Bay and from the shores of Lake Huron to the Fort Erie/Buffalo border. We cover 60,000 square miles with industry concentrating in the south and cottage country in the north. Our area has two assemblies a year — in the spring and the fall. It also holds three or four area committee meetings hosted by various districts. The four areas in Ontario form the Ontario Delegates Committee (ODC) that meets once a year to discuss upcoming General Service Conference items and to give the incoming delegate(s) an idea of what this Conference is all about. We are part of the CERAASA, where every other year we meet along with the 10 Eastern Canada areas. Area 86 is doing its best to make sure that all the available tools of recovery get to our groups and to the people that need them the most while doing their and our most important job — the Twelfth Step call. — *Fredy Mendoza*

Oregon: Area 58 has over 1,000 group in 36 districts. Three quarters of all groups, including two Spanish-language districts, branch out from Interstate Five north and south between California and Washington on the beautiful Oregon Coast; the rest are east of the Cascade Mountain Range. We encourage these outlying districts to host assemblies, and we respond to requests for workshops and presentations anywhere. We have four assemblies a year. Pre-Conference, post-Conference, elections, and one that focuses on the 12 standing area committees. G.S.R.s attend and vote at every assembly. Groups really like the D.C.M. and G.S.R. schools. Committee chairs facilitate workshops and support all districts. Area officers and committees work together, share information and build on the experiences of prior years. This offers a consistency of information that districts and groups depend on. We actively participate in PRAASA, PNC (Pacific Northwest Conference) and attend Pacific Regional Forums. D.C.M.s and G.S.R.s are also active in these informative events. — *Reilly Kalles*

Puerto Rico: Area 77 is geographically divided into 8 districts, serving a community of approximately 1,200 members. These districts are made up of 101 Spanish- and 6

English-speaking groups spread throughout the island. The groups also serve 6 different correctional and treatment facilities. Our area committee is composed of Public Information, Correctional, Treatment, and La Viña chairs. We also have an area office with a paid employee that serves our community on a daily basis. Our website provides local and global service information and had 52,992 hits last year. We have a monthly newsletter to inform members of A.A. activities in the area. We conduct monthly committee meetings as well as an annual seminar and convention. Area 77 will face two challenges ahead: coordinating our PSA with different local and national TV stations; and getting our fellow members to understand the importance of spirituality and money and how they work together. Compared to giant territories we are small in geographical dimensions but huge in our desire to serve. We are very accurate with the language we use, which serves the A.A. message, and that language is the language of the heart. — *Gilberto Vence*

Québec (Northwest): Although Area 90's service structure is primarily French we are a diverse, multicultural and multilingual area. Our members are served by six standing committees: Corrections, Treatment, Literature, Public Information, La Vigne (a provincial French meeting in print similar to the Grapevine) and the *Heritage*, our regional service newsletter. The area also has three work groups: Archives, Website and Information Sessions which help serve approximately 355 groups in 24 active districts. The area covers the Western part of Québec from north Montreal to Kuujuaq in Nunavik, Iqaluit and part of Rankin Inlet in Nunavut, northern Canada. The city of Joliette to the west and into eastern Ontario, to Ottawa where we serve the French-speaking members and groups. We annually host six regional meetings, two general assemblies and one Welcome assembly, open to all members wishing to learn more about service work. In March 2010 we initiated our first annual pre-Conference, which led the way for our members to express their thoughts on key Conference agenda item, in hopes of better preparing the delegate in representing the area's group conscience. — *Michael Cyr*

Québec (Southwest): Area 87 has 12,700 members and 550 registered groups distributed among 27 districts (19 are French, seven are English and one is Hispanic). We have one meeting in Québec signed language and one in Persian. Sixteen committees work to carry the A.A. message in our three official languages. French, English and Spanish. Our C.P.C. Committee presents A.A. to professionals and our P.I. Committee is active throughout the area. We also prepare a weekly radio program, billboard publicity and our participation at the province's largest agricultural fair, reaching out to 250,000 people during a two week period. Our Corrections Committee takes meetings into provincial and federal prisons; they are also present in the court houses of the area. The Treatment

Committee works with the staff and participants with regular meetings at the centers. Our Group Services Committee organizes seminars on A.A.'s service structure and workshops on Traditions and Concepts where past delegates are invited to contribute. We hold four assemblies and seven area committee meetings every year. Four delegates from Québec are board members of *La Vigne*, our French meeting-in-print. In October of each year we hold the area convention where over 2,000 people participate in the three-day experience. — *Thomas Green*

Rhode Island: Area 61 encompasses all of Rhode Island, plus a few towns in eastern Connecticut and southern Massachusetts. Area 61 is small, only 1,045 square miles with 400 miles of pristine coastline, but our recovery community is vibrant and active. Within this small area there are almost 6,000 A.A. members, nearly 300 registered groups and over 660 meetings listed in the directory. Our active treatment and corrections committees take dozens of meetings a week into institutions. The area is divided by seven geographical districts and a linguistic district. All of our committees meet monthly, as do the area officers, D.C.M.s and committee chairs. The area has four quarterly assemblies each year, and each district holds one Joy of Service meeting in-between the assemblies. Yearly we have the Rhode Island A.A. Convention in scenic Newport and last year we also hosted the Northeast Regional Delegates Meeting. A significant portion of our Fellowship remains uninformed about the spiritual rewards of service, however, and we need to do a better job with service sponsorship and communicating all the wonderful ways to give back. — *Ken Demarest*

South Carolina: A.A. in Area 62 continues to carry the message of hope and recovery. We strive to meet the needs of the 23 districts and 420 groups in carrying that message. Across the state, our service in treatment centers, corrections facilities and outreach through C.P.C. and P.I. continues to provide meetings, information and support through existing venues and contacts, as well as new and expanding opportunities. Last year, the area approved moving our three annual assemblies from a commercial hotel setting to a retreat style conference center. This lowered the overall cost of hosting these assemblies by approximately \$9,000 yearly. This move also lowered the costs of lodging to the point that we had the largest attended assembly in area history. The new location provides a setting where all participants are able to share with each other, improving overall communication that creates a better informed area. With the added financial savings and where warranted, we are looking at expanding the various activities of the standing committees. The groups and districts continue to meet the financial needs required in supporting the area. — *Jim Struchen*

South Dakota: Area 63 encompasses 77,000 square miles; there are two larger cities on each end of the state

with rural communities dotted in between. It is not uncommon to travel 150 miles to get to an evening meeting. There are three large Indian reservations in the area, of which some groups have a long history of continuous operation, despite their remote locations. There are groups keeping the doors open in fifteen districts in the area and all but a couple are active at area level. The area has a committee system with eleven committees and one subcommittee which carry out the business of staying connected with the Fellowship at four events during the year: two assemblies in the central part of the area during summer and winter, and two conferences held each spring and fall that rotate around the state using a bid system. The winter assembly and the spring conference's main emphasis is to prepare and send an informed delegate to the General Service Conference. Problems in the area seem to be ongoing issues of participation of all the districts, singleness of purpose, and financial support from all levels of A.A. The message of A.A. is carried to the public through an area website, district websites and hotlines scattered across the state. Meetings continue to go into prisons and plenty of county jails, with access to these facilities getting tougher and tougher with all the liability issues. The area works closely with districts and groups to make literature available and help small groups keep expenses down. And finally there is the Sturgis Rally which takes place in August every year and helps create unity among the groups. — *Bob Munsell*

Tennessee: Area 64 consists of the entire state of Tennessee plus two groups in Virginia and one in Alabama. Tennessee covers 42,181 square miles with 94 counties. Our assembly has 42 districts representing 580 groups; we have two Hispanic districts representing 14 groups. We have quarterly assemblies which meet over a three-day period. Friday evening is dedicated to standing committee meetings as well as first thing Saturday morning, followed by an area committee meeting on Saturday, where we have reports from officers and standing committee chairs. We have eight standing committees that answer to the assembly body through reporting their activities in our business meeting. Additionally they put on workshops and assist local committees in their functions throughout the state. We have seven area officers; elections are in the fourth quarter of odd number years taking office in January of even number years. — *Tony Shelby*

Texas (Northwest): Area 66 spans over 95,000 miles, so our service work almost always includes the saying "get in the truck." Our statistics are interesting, we had 11 districts in rotation 64 and now have 9. One of the changes was that district 9 was incorporated into district 13. These folks have become active again and some of our chairs come from this district. We also had an exodus of service persons at the area level, but now have a full panel of officers and chairpersons. Our number of groups has grown from 210 to 271. This means more opportunities for our incom-

ing chairs to be able to do workshops and to practice our Fifth Tradition. Our incoming officers and chairs are learning to better use technology to aid in the distance factor and we are utilizing our website and conference call technology to meet more often. Our districts conduct their meetings in the same format as the General Service Conference. — *Dave Houston*

Texas (Southwest): Area 68 consists of approximately 569 active groups within 33 districts; seven of which are Spanish-speaking districts. All of our assemblies, minutes, newsletters, and correspondence are translated. We have seven standing committees: Archives, Bilingual, Corrections, Grapevine/La Viña, Newsletter, P.I./C.P.C., and Treatment. We also have a rotating, but nonvoting area webmaster. We hold four assemblies a year; rotating around our area and hosted by volunteer districts. Winter and summer are Workshop assemblies. Spring and fall are voting assemblies. We hold a mock Conference at our spring pre-Conference Assembly, using several items from the final agenda. We also conduct an annual C.F.C. Conference and an annual P.I./C.P.C. Conference, hosted by volunteer districts. The area funds the venue and provides seed money. For the past several years our annual C.F.C. Conference has cooperated with the Texas Department of Criminal Justice to conduct a volunteer training session which is required for anyone wishing to take meetings into our state facilities. This training is translated by our area bilingual chairperson. Our annual P.I./C.P.C. Conference traditionally includes a luncheon for nonalcoholic professionals in the local community along with workshops and presentations aimed at education and inspiration for our A.A. members providing P.I./C.P.C. service. — *Denise Thorn*

Vermont: When the average person thinks of Vermont, they think of maple syrup, skiing, covered bridges. But to the average alcoholic, Vermont is known as the birthplace of both Bill Wilson and Dr. Bob Smith — and as the final resting place of Bill and his wife Lois. Area 70 has a strong and robust A.A. with 300 registered groups and an estimated 5,000 members. We have eleven districts; our assembly meets quarterly, our area committee meets seven times a year. We conduct an annual convention, a pre-Conference sharing session (which is loosely modeled on the General Service Conference), and we have an ever-growing number of area workshops. We have ten standing committees. There are no intergroups or central offices in Vermont, so most districts publish local meeting lists, coordinate answering services, sell Conference-approved literature and perform outreach in their communities. Because Vermont is a tourist destination, our A.A. groups are always seeing new faces. — *Bob Rowe*

Washington (East): Area 92 has 24 districts, of which four are non-geographical Hispanic districts, and over 450 registered groups. Our area covers all of Washington east of the Cascade Mountains, the northern half of Idaho, the

northwest corner of Montana and a small portion of Oregon. We celebrated our 20th anniversary last October. We have two assemblies each year, one being a pre-Conference assembly, and two area quarterlies; all are simultaneously translated for our Hispanic friends. In addition, our area hosts four Standing Committee Quarterlies each year at different locations in our attempt to better carry the message to the groups and members. We are pleased to be one of three areas, Area 58 Oregon and Area 72 Western Washington being the others, that continue to host the Pacific Northwest Conference, (PNC); Bill W. suggested such a gathering to the Fellowship in his travels to the northwest in 1948, making it one of the oldest conferences in A.A. We are also proud to be a member of PRAASA, which is held every year in our region on a rotating basis. Additionally, Area 92 participates with Area 72 Western Washington, in the annual Washington State Hispanic Convention. — *Scott Roush*

Wisconsin (Northern/Upper Peninsula of Michigan): Area 74 includes more than half of northern Wisconsin and most of the Upper Peninsula of Michigan. In 2014, we completed funding of a prudent reserve. In 2015 we were fully self-supporting, ending the year with a small surplus and 35% of our 619 active groups contributing. Total group contributions are at their highest level in six years, allowing many standing committee's budgets to be increased in an attempt to reach more still-suffering alcoholics. We hold four assemblies every year — two are stand-alone events and two take place in conjunction with our spring and fall Conferences, which are hosted by one of 24 districts. It is inspiring to witness a newly re-energized district catch fire with enthusiasm and unity. Many of our standing committees meet regularly via conference call. Participation of our past delegates is encouraged, with both a voice and a vote at assemblies; they also serve on three different committees — Archives, Finance and Structures & Guidelines. Our Literature Committee is active; the chairperson manages a substantial inventory and coordinates with districts and groups to create bulk purchases from G.S.O. — *Derek Tait*

Wyoming: Area 76 is 97,818 square miles. It has a population of around 500,000 people. We have 12 districts and 119 active registered groups. Our conventions are twice a year in our larger towns. The assemblies are twice a year rotating among the smaller towns. Our assemblies mirror the General Service Conference, with all but three of the committees filled with chairs. The remaining three — Agenda, Trustees, Regional Forum — are designated the GAP committee, chaired by a past delegate. We have very active correctional committees, taking meetings into all of the state's correctional facilities. In 2015 we hosted the West Central Regional Forum in Casper. In 2017 we will have the West Central Regional Conference in Cheyenne. — *Michelle Schmidt*

Additional Committee Considerations

Advisory Action 40 of the 1990 General Service Conference states: "Items discussed, but no action taken or recommendation made, as well as committee recommendations which are not adopted, be included in a separate section of the Final Report." Items, listed by committee, are summarized as follows:

AGENDA

The committee discussed the importance of the General Service Conference Inventory Compendium and the Additional Recommendations/Suggestions section, encouraging all Conference members to review this section for possible actions locally, regionally and at future Conferences; after discussion of the trustees' report regarding the Conference Agenda Committee and the agenda selection process, it was agreed that the actions of the Conference Agenda Committee are matters of policy not just routine programming and that the committee name should remain the same.

ARCHIVES¹

Through area assemblies and committee meetings, archives workshops, notices in *Box 4-5-9* and *Markings*, encouragement was suggested for A.A. groups to write or update their group histories, with the suggestion that the Archives service piece "Researching Group Histories" be distributed to G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s; suggestions were made to include additional resources to the Archives Workbook at its next printing.

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

The committee considered a request to discontinue the pamphlet "Three Talks to Medical Societies by Bill W." and took no action, with the suggestion that the trustees' committee continue discussing the historical value of the pamphlet and the possibility of keeping it available to the Fellowship; ways of integrating technology into the professional exhibits were offered regarding the inclusion of digital response or QR codes for pamphlets and tabletop displays, as well as development of an audiovisual presentation for continuous screening at professional events; suggestions were made for items to be added to the C.P.C. Kit and Workbook, and the "Matrix of Individual Comments" was reviewed with the suggestion that proposed changes to material *not* under the purview of the C.P.C. committee be forwarded to the appropriate trustees' committees for appraisal.

CORRECTIONS

It was noted that an accompanying service piece in a 2014 Advisory Action for the video "It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell" does not exist and so cannot be updated or revised; a suggestion was made to the trustees' Committee on Corrections to consider additional versions of the video "A

New Freedom" in varying lengths for different audiences in different settings; challenges regarding the expansion of the Corrections Correspondence Service (C.C.S.) in Canada were discussed, as were ways to attract more Spanish-speaking "outside" A.A. members to the service, while additions to the C.C.S. form (F-26) and the Corrections Kit and Workbook were suggested to the trustees' Committee on Corrections.

FINANCE

After discussion, no action was taken to increase the Suggested Delegate Area Contribution to the General Service Conference or to increase the one-time limit for individual bequests; it was suggested that G.S.O. consider additional ways, using technology, to convey the financial message contained in the flyer "The Seventh Tradition Fact Sheet" (F-203) and indicated that this item could be included in the Self-Support Packet (F-19) while removing other less effective pieces; regarding future International Conventions, it was suggested that measures be considered to assure self-support through registration activities and that the feasibility of a separate ongoing Convention Fund be considered; when dealing with items such as the World Service Meeting and related activities, it was suggested that the General Service Board consider the spiritual message of self-support in its spending priorities.

GRAPEVINE

The 2016 Grapevine Office Report on Audio Strategy was reviewed and a request made for updated information on the project to be provided to the 2017 Conference Committee on the Grapevine; suggestions were forwarded to the Grapevine board to produce books with the working titles "Stories by Atheist and Agnostic AA Members" and "Steps Four and Five" in 2017 or later; the committee reviewed the Grapevine Workbook.

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/ REGIONAL FORUMS¹

Providing more information about Regional Forums, including event details on local Area websites, suggestions to "bring a buddy" and informing members outside the Region about upcoming Forums were highlighted as ways to encourage interest and attract first time attendees; noting that the 2015 International Convention showed a loss, the committee discussed ongoing efforts by G.S.O. and the General Service Board to plan effectively for the 2020 International Convention in Detroit, Michigan, as well as recognizing positive new features from the 2015 Convention such as the Anonymity Booth and the Carry the Message Pavilion, along with the participation of over 700 A.A. members who are deaf.

LITERATURE

After discussion, no action was taken on a request to produce a plain language version of the Big Book and

¹Members serve on this committee as a secondary committee assignment.

a report from A.A.W.S. on “pagination” of Conference-approved digital texts was accepted with encouragement that A.A.W.S. continue to investigate all possible solutions; the committee reviewed progress reports from the trustees’ committee on the revision of the pamphlets “A.A. for the Woman,” “A.A. and the Gay/Lesbian Alcoholic” and the development of literature for A.A.s with mental health issues and those who sponsor them, and looks forward reviewing draft copy, revisions or progress reports on these items at the 2017 Conference; suggestions for the revised draft pamphlet “Inside A.A.: Understanding the Fellowship and Its Services” were offered to the trustees’ Literature Committee for consideration when a revised draft or progress report is brought to the 2017 Conference; it was suggested that the need for “plain-language” recovery literature be explored by the trustees’ Literature Committee.

POLICY/ADMISSIONS

The committee suggested that G.S.O. and the trustees’ committee on the General Service Conference explore ways to provide information to and encourage coordinated efforts among local translation committees regarding translation of Conference background into French and Spanish; regarding Conference observers from other fellowships, the committee took no action, noting that the General Service Conference is a closed business meeting and that A.A. freely shares its experience upon request; recognizing that current practices are sufficient and in keeping with the Conference Charter, the committee took no action on a request that all Conference members be sent the same background material with the exception

of digital media and works in progress; it was suggested that the trustees’ Committee on the General Service Conference consider developing procedures for electronic polling to be used only in matters of grave emergency that may occur between Conferences and that are in keeping with the Conference Charter.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

The committee reviewed and accepted the annual report of the trustees’ P.I. Committee on the G.S.O. and Grapevine websites, the 2016 P.I. Comprehensive Media plan, and information on the distribution, tracking and evaluation of the PSA “Doors”; it was suggested that the trustees’ P.I. Committee explore ways of providing guidance to the Fellowship on carrying the A.A. message to the general public online and in social media; the P.I. Kit and Workbook were reviewed, noting their usefulness; and the committee took no action on a request to reconsider 2011 Advisory Action 22, as the current policy on the use of full-face videos is adequate.

REPORT AND CHARTER

Reports from the Publishing department regarding preparation and publication of *The A.A. Service Manual* and General Service Conference *Final Report* were accepted along with a list of editorial updates from the Publishing department, the General Service Board and the A.A. Grapevine board for *The A.A. Service Manual*; a suggestion was made to include a definition of “Service Manual” in the Glossary of Service Terms in *The A.A. Service Manual/ Twelve Concepts for World Service*; adding text to the chart



on page S22 regarding the “Third Legacy Procedure” was suggested for consistency; the Publishing department was asked to consider using a larger font for the *Final Report* and including call-out text on the cover to highlight potential items of interest.

TREATMENT AND ACCESSIBILITIES

The committee suggested creation of an Accessibilities Checklist for the Special Needs/Accessibilities Kit that groups could use to inventory their accessibility to all alcoholics and that inclusion of the A.A. Guidelines on Carrying the Message to the Deaf Alcoholic in the Treatment Kit be reviewed.

TRUSTEES

After a review of resumes, all Class B trustee candidates for the West Central and Western Canada regions were approved as eligible; the committee discussed a report from the trustees’ Committee on Nominating regarding expanding the pool of candidates to serve the General Service Board and the Corporate Boards and encouraged consultation between the trustees’ Committee on Nominating and the General Service Board to identify the skills and backgrounds most needed for each opening; while direct questions on the candidate’s resume form regarding diverse characteristics was determined unnecessary, the committee suggested adding space to the current resume form that would allow candidates to provide additional background that might benefit the General Service Board.

Recommendations That Did Not Result In Conference Advisory Actions

FINANCE

- The committee recommended that the maximum annual limit for individual contributions to the General Service Board from A.A. members be increased from \$3,000 to \$5,000

POLICY/ADMISSIONS

- The committee recommended that background material continue to be provided in English because it is not feasible at this time to move forward with translation of Conference background into French and Spanish

Floor Actions That Did Not Result In Conference Advisory Actions

- That the trustees’ Committee on Public Information begin work on a Google-for-Nonprofit account to be used for carrying the A.A. message to the public. This request is limited to “YouTube for Nonprofit” to share video content and “Google Ad Words” which will help in search result placement. The trustees’ committee is asked to provide

a progress report to the 2017 Conference Committee on Public Information. **(Not approved)**

- That the standing agenda items on the Conference Finance Committee which read as follows:

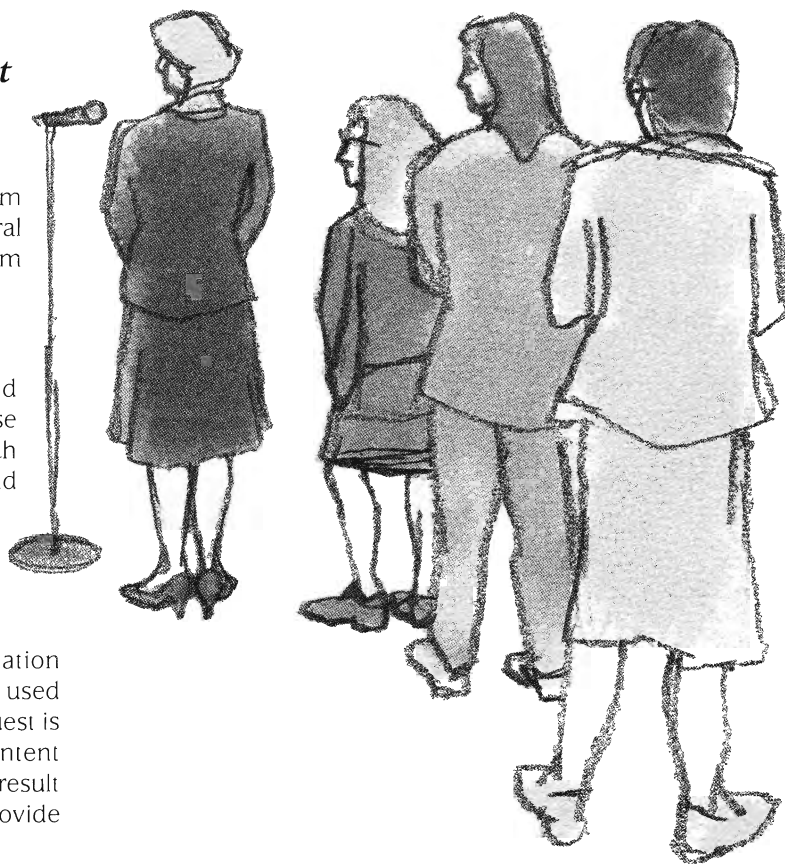
1. To review the contribution for delegate expense for the General Service Conference.
2. To approve individual bequests to the General Service Board from A.A. members.
3. To review maximum annual contribution to the General Service Board from an individual A.A. member of \$3,000.

be removed as standing items on the Conference Finance Committee agenda. **(Not approved)**

- That a subscription app for La Viña be created with the same technical components as the A.A. Grapevine app. **(Withdrawn by submitter)**

- That 2-3 hours be provided in the 67th Conference agenda to permit the Conference to consult on matters brought forward by the trustees of the General Service Board. **(Not approved)**

- That the minutes of the General Service Board meetings be posted to the General Service Conference dashboard as soon as they are approved so that all Area delegates have equal access to the minutes. **(Withdrawn by submitter)**



The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.

CONSOLIDATED STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL POSITION

December 31, 2015 (with comparative totals for 2014)

	General Service Board of A.A.								
	General Fund	Reserve Fund	Capital Projects Fund	Postretirement Medical Fund	Pension Benefits	A.A. World Services, Inc.	A.A. Grapevine, Inc.	Consolidated 2015	Consolidated 2014
ASSETS									
Cash	\$ 1,185,984	\$ 5,840,096		\$ 33,156		\$ 757,609	\$ 642,813	\$ 8,459,658	\$ 8,864,282
Accounts and interest receivable		1,138				192,474	32,165	225,777	243,106
Intercompany balances	(1,266,740)	(1,953,100)				1,243,477	1,976,363	-	-
Inventories									
Books, pamphlets, etc.						1,402,708	233,784	1,636,492	1,996,526
Paper, prepublication costs, etc.						102,505	21,141	123,646	177,316
Investments - at fair value (Note 2)		10,695,801		3,349,432				14,045,233	16,238,129
Property, Equipment and Software									
(net of accumulated depreciation and amortization of 2015 - \$5,221,942; 2014 - \$4,941,480) (Note 2)			\$1,435,277			297,744	6,296	1,739,317	809,330
Deferred charges and deposits	28,409					210,137	80,129	318,675	429,047
Prepaid conventions	132,392							132,392	1,060,067
Total Assets	80,045	14,583,935	1,435,277	3,382,588	\$ -	4,206,654	2,992,691	26,681,190	29,817,803
LIABILITIES									
Accounts and accruals payable	\$ -					\$ 799,302	\$ 79,478	\$ 878,780	\$ 755,645
Deferred income									
- orders and subscriptions, etc.	23,032					84,783	1,903,842	2,011,657	2,036,624
- convention registrations	-							-	3,527,260
Accrued postretirement health benefits				\$7,186,857				7,186,857	7,253,849
Accrued pension benefits					\$6,059,283			6,059,283	8,205,766
Total Liabilities	23,032	\$ -	\$ -	7,186,857	6,059,283	884,085	1,983,320	16,136,577	21,779,144
Net Assets (Exhibit B)	57,013	14,583,935	1,435,277	(3,804,269)	(6,059,283)	3,322,569	1,009,371	10,544,613	8,038,659
Total Liabilities and Net Assets	80,045	14,583,935	1,435,277	3,382,588	-	4,206,654	2,992,691	26,681,190	29,817,803

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.**

CONSOLIDATED STATEMENT OF ACTIVITY

Year Ended December 31, 2015 (with comparative totals for 2014)

	General Service Board of A.A.					A.A. Grapevine, Inc.		Consolidated 2015	Consolidated 2014
	General Fund	Reserve Fund	Capital Projects Fund	Postretirement Medical Fund	Pension Benefits	A.A. World Services, Inc.	Grapevine	La Viña	
INCOME AND COST OF LITERATURE									
Gross Sales						\$12,720,222	\$2,955,353	\$134,095	\$15,809,670
Less: Discounts						230,789	-	-	230,789
Net Sales						12,489,433	2,955,353	134,095	15,578,881
Cost of Literature Distributed									
Printing						(2,737,914)	(345,355)	(31,861)	(3,115,130)
Royalties on books						(19,078)	-	-	(19,078)
Direct shipping and warehousing						(1,562,057)	(641,170)	(28,994)	(2,232,221)
Gross Profit from Literature						8,170,384	1,968,828	73,240	10,212,452
CONTRIBUTIONS	\$7,154,146								7,154,146
INVESTMENT INCOME (Note 2)	43	\$ 48,969		(7,746)		391	8,100	-	49,757
Total Income	7,154,189	48,969		(7,746)		8,170,775	1,976,928	73,240	17,416,355
FUNCTIONAL EXPENSES (Exhibit C)									
Program	5,972,810	-				2,976,629	1,197,564	219,618	10,366,621
Supporting services	3,656,689	-	\$ 89,371	53,126	\$ (561,817)	2,513,211	538,553	-	6,289,133
Total Expenses	9,629,499	-	89,371	53,126	(561,817)	5,489,840	1,736,117	219,618	16,655,754
EXCESS OF INCOME (EXPENSE) FOR YEAR	(2,475,310)	48,969	(89,371)	(60,872)	561,817	2,680,935	240,811	(146,378)	760,601
Change in retirement liabilities – nonoperating	-	-	-	371,118	1,584,666	-	-	-	1,955,784
2015 International Convention (net of direct expenses of \$6,139,569) (Schedule 1)	(210,431)	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	(210,431)
INTERCOMPANY AND INTERFUND TRANSFERS									
GSB La Viña support	(146,378)	-	-	-	-	-	-	146,378	-
Other transfers	2,832,119	440,000	1,167,163	-	-	(4,199,282)	(240,000)	-	-
CHANGE IN NET ASSETS FOR YEAR	-	488,969	1,077,792	310,246	2,146,483	(1,518,347)	811	-	2,505,954
NET ASSETS									
Beginning of year	57,013	14,094,966	357,485	(4,114,515)	(8,205,765)	4,840,916	1,008,560	-	8,038,659
NET ASSETS									
End of year (Exhibit A)	57,013	14,583,935	1,435,277	(3,804,269)	(6,059,283)	3,322,569	1,009,371	-	8,038,659

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
 Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.
CONSOLIDATED STATEMENT OF FUNCTIONAL EXPENSES

Year Ended December 31, 2015 (with comparative totals for 2014)

	Group Services	Fellowship Services	General Service Conference	World Service Meeting	International Convention	Regional Forums	Publishing	Grapevine	La Viña	Supporting Services	2015 Total	2014 Total
OPERATING EXPENSES												
Salaries	\$ 858,081	\$1,047,197	\$ 187,215		\$120,190	\$137,841	\$1,338,772	\$ 511,129	\$138,692	\$2,615,059	\$ 6,954,176	\$6,984,048
Payroll taxes	57,163	73,161	11,606		9,584	13,503	109,559	38,785	15,855	194,296	523,512	534,188
Health and group insurance	112,714	144,019	22,847		18,681	26,581	215,673	72,811	14,296	745,480	1,373,102	1,357,576
Retirement expense — funding	217,907	279,815	44,390		37,381	51,645	419,031	98,990	22,815	720,884	1,892,858	2,040,824
Other program printing	200,225	71,900	81,998	\$ 5,493		19,340	5,215			2,523	386,694	388,437
Mailing labor	93,235	8,030	7,258			3,850					112,373	136,451
Postage and express	193,128	48,266	55,410		4,983	17,147	27,354	4,973		30,792	382,053	420,373
Writers fees	18,290	49,735	21,460	1,480		7,273	250			1,299	99,787	100,241
Foreign literature assistance		24,889									24,889	13,250
Selling expenses							313,160	137,428	12,712	40,660	503,960	590,928
Professional fees										238,634	238,634	351,964
Contracted services	67,899	208,749	87,371		6,095	22,875	189,903	167,490	6,429	761,088	1,517,899	1,439,709
Occupancy	111,420	144,271	11,189		8,371	3,220	215,887	25,756		368,687	888,801	869,436
Telephone	21,395	21,920	2,699			1,436	14,872	19,786		52,685	134,793	131,761
Equipment maintenance	9,811	4,534					10,860			65,561	90,766	74,024
Depreciation and amortization	29,878	23,481	5,244		148	2,519	97,152			52,540	210,962	263,916
Stationery and office	66,030	7,144	9,901		952	1,918	1,649	80,208		52,110	199,912	243,496
Office service and expense	8,436	13,530	48,419		10	2,475	8,249	60,208	1,338	271,657	414,322	399,312
Travel, meals and accommodations	6,167	45,627	760,706	1,967	346	81,203	9,043		7,481	479,262	1,391,802	1,365,659
Bad debts										15,236	15,236	12,686
Delegate fees			(281,457)								(281,457)	(381,024)
Total Operating Expenses	2,071,779	2,216,268	1,076,256	8,940	206,741	392,826	2,976,629	1,197,564	219,618	6,708,453	17,075,074	17,337,255
Postretirement health benefits										53,126	53,126	108,693
Retirement expense adjustment										(561,817)	(561,817)	(1,205,061)
Capital projects depreciation										89,371	89,371	120,162
Total Expenses	2,071,779	2,216,268	1,076,256	8,940	206,741	392,826	2,976,629	1,197,564	219,618	6,289,133	16,655,754	16,361,049
Allocation of supporting services to activities	1,122,941	1,201,257	583,350	4,846	112,057	212,918	2,513,211	538,553	-	(6,289,133)	-	-
Total Allocated Expenses	3,194,720	3,417,525	1,659,606	13,786	318,798	605,744	5,489,840	1,736,117	219,618	-	16,655,754	16,361,049
Services	\$3,194,720	\$3,417,525	\$1,659,606	\$ 13,786	\$318,798	\$605,744				-	9,210,179	\$8,749,004
Publishing	-	-	-	-	-	-	\$5,489,840				5,489,840	5,690,604
Grapevine	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	\$1,736,117	219,618		1,955,735	1,921,441
											16,655,754	16,361,049
COMPARATIVE TOTALS 2014	\$3,172,696	\$3,137,566	\$1,171,862	\$233,270	\$386,775	\$646,835	\$5,690,604	\$1,719,637	\$201,804		\$16,361,049	

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board
of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Direct Income and Expenses of the
International Convention
Atlanta, Georgia, July 2-5, 2015**

INCOME

Registration		\$5,875,482
Literature sales — souvenir book	\$225,192	
Less: Purchases and costs	<u>(137,555)</u>	<u>87,637</u>
Transit pass revenue	441,450	
Transit pass costs	<u>(475,431)</u>	<u>(33,981)</u>
Total Income		<u>5,929,138</u>

EXPENSES

Convention consultants fees and expenses	497,436
Public relations, legal and accounting fees	57,658
Stadium production — Friday, Saturday and Sunday	1,372,060
Entertainment	52,522
Printing, signs, and supplies	180,986
Busing costs	1,548,869
Host committee	81,718
Registration processing	215,346
Simultaneous translation	64,421
Convention center, decorating, security, etc. (Thursday, Friday and Saturday sessions)	1,175,341
Al-Anon	21,240
Pre-Convention travel	50,958
Transportation, subsistence, hotels	157,797
Credit card fees, insurance, meals and sundry	<u>663,217</u>
Total Expenses	<u>6,139,569</u>

Excess of Income (expense) (Exhibit B)	<u>(210,431)</u>
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The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
 Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc.
 Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.
 Consolidated Statement of Cash Flows
 Year Ended December 31, 2015
 (with comparative totals for 2014)**

CASH FLOWS PROVIDED (USED)

	<u>2015</u>	<u>2014</u>
FROM OPERATING ACTIVITIES:		
Change in net assets for year (Exhibit B)	\$2,505,954	\$(5,808,590)
Realized and change in unrealized gains on investments	67,074	(145,298)
Amortization of bond premiums	65	2,033
Depreciation and amortization	300,333	393,184
Changes in assets and liabilities:		
Accounts receivable	17,329	(44,223)
Inventories	413,704	(296,521)
Deferred charges and other assets	1,038,047	(990,961)
Accounts and accruals payable	123,135	276,235
Deferred income	(3,552,227)	3,223,771
Postretirement health benefits obligation	(66,992)	1,589,368
Accrued pension benefits	(2,146,483)	4,636,028
 <u>Net Cash Flows Provided (used)</u>		
<u>by Operating Activities</u>	<u>(1,300,061)</u>	<u>2,835,026</u>
 FROM INVESTING ACTIVITIES:		
Purchases of property and equipment	(1,230,320)	(183,664)
Proceeds from sales of investments	7,035,464	11,563,764
Purchases of investments	(4,909,707)	(9,766,991)
 <u>Net Cash Flows Provided</u>		
<u>by Investing Activities</u>	<u>895,437</u>	<u>1,613,109</u>
 Net Increase (Decrease) in Cash	<u>(404,624)</u>	<u>4,448,135</u>
 Cash, beginning of year	<u>8,864,282</u>	<u>4,416,147</u>
 Cash, end of year	<u><u>\$8,459,658</u></u>	<u><u>\$8,864,282</u></u>

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

■ Report of the Independent Auditor

INDEPENDENT AUDITOR'S REPORT

March 30, 2016

The Board of Trustees
The General Service Board of
Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
475 Riverside Drive
New York, New York 10115

Members of the Board

We have audited the accompanying consolidated statement of financial position of THE GENERAL SERVICE BOARD OF ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS, INC., ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS WORLD SERVICES, INC., and ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS GRAPEVINE, INC. as of December 31, 2015 and the related consolidated statements of activities, functional expenses and cash flows for the year then ended. These financial statements are the responsibility of the Organizations' management. Our responsibility is to express an opinion on these financial statements based on our audit.

Management's Responsibility for the Financial Statements

Management is responsible for the preparation and fair presentation of these financial statements in accordance with accounting principles generally accepted in the United States of America, this includes the design, implementation, and maintenance of internal control relevant to the preparation and fair presentation of financial statements that are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error.

Auditor's Responsibility

Our responsibility is to express an opinion on these financial statements based on our audit. We conducted our audit in accordance with auditing standards generally accepted in the United States of America. Those standards require that we plan and perform the audit to obtain reasonable assurance about whether the financial statements are free of material misstatement.

An audit involves performing procedures to obtain audit evidence about the amounts and disclosures in the financial statements. The procedures selected depend on the auditor's judgement, including the assessment of the risks of material misstatement of the financial statements, whether due to fraud or error. In making those risk assessments, the auditor considers internal control relevant to the entity's preparation and fair presentation of the financial statements in order to design audit procedures that are appropriate in the circumstances, but not for the purpose of expressing an opinion on the effectiveness of the entity's internal control. Accordingly, we express no such opinion. An audit also includes evaluating the appropriateness of accounting policies used and the reasonableness of significant accounting estimates made by management, as well as evaluating the overall presentation of the financial statements.

We believe that the audit evidence we have obtained is sufficient and appropriate to provide a basis for our audit opinion.

The prior year summarized comparative information has been derived from the Organization's December 31, 2014 consolidated financial statements, and in our report dated March 25, 2015, we expressed an unmodified opinion on those financial statements.

Opinion

In our opinion, the consolidated financial statements referred to above present fairly, in all material respects, the financial position of the three Corporations named above as of December 31, 2015 and the changes in their net assets and their cash flows for the year then ended in conformity with accounting principles generally accepted in the United States of America.

Other Matter

Our audit was conducted for the purpose of forming an opinion on the financial statements as a whole. The consolidating information presented in the consolidated statement of financial position and the schedule of direct income and expenses of the 80th Anniversary Convention are presented for purposes of additional analyses and are not a required part of the financial statements. Such information is the responsibility of management and was derived from and relates directly to the underlying accounting and other records used to prepare the financial statements. The information has been subjected to the auditing procedures applied in the audit of the financial statements and certain additional procedures, including comparing and reconciling such information directly to the underlying accounting and other records used to prepare the financial statements or to the financial statements themselves, and other additional procedures in accordance with auditing standards generally accepted in the United States of America. In our opinion, the information is fairly stated in all material respects in relation to the financial statements as a whole.

Owen J. Flanagan and Company
Certified Public Accountants
New York, N.Y.

THE GENERAL SERVICE BOARD OF ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS, INC. ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS WORLD SERVICES, INC. ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS GRAPEVINE, INC. NOTES TO CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL STATEMENTS DECEMBER 31, 2015

Note 1 Organization: The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc., ("G.S.B.") and its affiliates A.A. World Services, Inc. ("A.A.W.S.") and A.A. Grapevine, Inc. ("A.A.G.V.") are not-for-profit organizations organized for the purpose of assisting in the formation of A.A. Groups and coordinating the A.A. program of rehabilitating alcoholics throughout the world, and publishing books, magazines, pamphlets and other material directly related to that purpose. The trustees of G.S.B. are members ex officio of A.A.W.S. and A.A.G.V., and as such, elect their boards of directors. As members, they also have the sole right to amend the A.A.W.S. and A.A.G.V. bylaws, and approve their budgets.

The activities of the General Service Board of A.A. itself are conducted in five separate funds, as follows:

The RESERVE FUND — This fund was established in 1954 for the purpose of accumulating a prudent operating reserve, which during 1977, was redefined by a special General Service Board Committee as the prior year's combined operating expenses of A.A. World Services, Inc., A.A. Grapevine, Inc. and the General Fund of the A.A. General Service Board. The committee also recommended that all investment activities of the operating entities be consolidated into the Reserve Fund. That Advisory Action was approved by the Board of Trustees and since that time, all funds of the operating entities, in excess of those required for working capital, have been transferred to the Reserve Fund. Included in such transfers from A.A. Grapevine, Inc. have been amounts held for unfulfilled subscriptions reflected as a liability of the Reserve Fund. Any withdrawals from the Reserve Fund must be specifically authorized by the Board of Trustees upon recommendation of the Finance and Budgetary Committee.

The CAPITAL PROJECTS FUND — This fund accounts for the cost of leasehold improvements and computer hardware and software incurred under major capital projects, and records annual depreciation on such assets.

The CONVENTION FUND — A separate fund established to

record the direct income and expenses of international A.A. Conventions held every five years. These events are separate from the regular operations of the General Service Office, but the General Fund receives any excess of income, or pays any excess of expense, resulting from the activity.

From a historical perspective, the net direct result of all Conventions held to date is approximately an excess of income of \$1,350,000, and presently resides with all other income not required for working capital in the Reserve Fund.

The POSTRETIREMENT MEDICAL FUND — A fund established in 2006 with the goal of accumulating assets equal to 50% of the liability for postretirement health benefits by the end of ten years.

The Postretirement health benefits plan is described in more detail in Note 5.

The GENERAL FUND — This fund is comprised of those assets not included in any of the other funds and may be used for any purpose for which the Organization was formed. These purposes presently include activities related to communication and information services to A.A. groups and members, public information, cooperation with the professional community and regional, national and international meetings, conferences and conventions.

All net assets of the Organizations are free of donor restrictions.

Note 2 Accounting Policies: The Organizations use the accrual method of accounting, where income is recorded in the period earned and expenses are recorded in the period incurred and to which they pertain. The Organizations do not receive or solicit pledges, so contributions are recorded as income when the cash is received.

The Organizations receive revenue from sales of literature and magazine subscriptions and donations from A.A. groups and members.

Contributions received from A.A. groups and members are for the general activities of the General Service Office, and are recorded as unrestricted. Donations received from foreign A.A. entities for the International Literature Fund are also treated as unrestricted, as A.A.'s ongoing foreign literature assistance program satisfies the donor's condition on a current basis.

Intercompany balances and transfers are eliminated in the consolidated totals in the accompanying financial statements.

Operating expenses of the General Service Office are shared between the General Service Board of A.A. and A.A. World Services. Expenses related to service activities are charged to the General Service Board, while expenses in connection with publishing activities are allocated to A.A. World Services. Administrative and overhead costs are apportioned between the program activities they support.

Occupancy costs related to A.A. Grapevine's share of office space at the General Service Office have been charged based on the actual lease cost; substantially all other expenses related to magazine activities are paid and recorded directly by A.A. Grapevine under its separate accounting system.

Cash: For purposes of the consolidated statement of cash flows, cash is defined as cash on hand, checking and money market accounts and short term cash investments.

Cash in excess of federally insured limits are potentially exposed to concentrations of credit risk. However, the Organizations only maintain accounts with quality financial institutions with high credit standings, so as a consequence, such risks are limited.

Accounts Receivable: Receivables from sales of literature are recognized when items are shipped. Allowances for doubtful accounts are recorded based on the age and collectibility of the receivables.

Inventories: Inventories are valued at the lower of cost or

market using the first-in, first-out "FIFO" method of valuation. Proper allowance has been made for slow-moving or damaged merchandise.

Cost of literature distributed on Exhibit B for 2014 includes \$823,152 of inventory write downs on the 75th Anniversary edition Big Book due to quantities printed in excess of expected sales. An additional write-down of \$85,962 on that book was recorded in 2015 and is also included in cost of literature.

Literature distributed without charge is not accounted for separately, but is included in the cost of printing as a reduction of inventory.

Shipping and handling charges billed to customers are included in sales revenue.

Property and Equipment: The costs of major capital projects involving leasehold improvements and computer system acquisitions are capitalized and depreciated on a straight line basis over the term of the applicable lease, or the useful life of the equipment, in the Capital Projects Fund.

Normal recurring expenditures for furniture and equipment are capitalized and depreciated over estimated useful lives of three to eight years.

The following table sets forth, by classification of assets, the depreciation lives, the provision for depreciation for the year ended December 31, 2015 and the accumulated depreciation at that date:

	<u>Life</u>	<u>Cost</u>	<u>Current Year</u>	<u>Accumulated Depreciation</u>
Leasehold improvements	Terms of			
475 Riverside Drive	Leases	\$3,932,811	\$89,371	\$2,854,627
Furniture	8 Years	1,111,447	4,639	752,899
Computers	3 to 5 Years	525,777	91,620	417,925
Software	5 Years	1,391,224	114,703	1,196,491
		6,961,259	300,333	5,221,942

Included in the above categories is the office co-location project on the 11th floor including \$810,070 of leasehold improvements and \$357,093 of furniture that was in process at December 31, 2015 and was considered placed in service as of January 2016.

Investments: Investments are recorded at fair value. Gains and losses on sales or redemptions are recorded by comparison of proceeds to amortized cost on a specific identification basis.

The Organizations follow Accounting Standards Codification ("ASC") 820, Fair Value Measurements. It establishes a framework for measuring fair value, and expands disclosures about fair value measurements. Investments are now classified into one of three categories.

Level 1 — Quoted prices are available in active markets for identical investments as of the reporting date.

Level 2 — Pricing inputs are other than quoted prices in active markets, which are either directly or indirectly observable as of the reporting date, and the fair value is determined through the use of models or other valuation methodologies.

Level 3 — Pricing inputs are unobservable for the investment and include situations where there is little, if any, market activity for the investment.

All of the securities held by the Organizations at December 31, 2015 and 2014 have been valued at either Level 1 or Level 2.

Level 2 investments have been valued using the net asset values as reported by the mutual funds.

As described above, all funds of the operating entities not required for working capital are consolidated in the Reserve Fund of the General Service Board. In accordance with established policy, the Reserve Fund invests in short or medium term U.S. Treasury Notes or Bills normally held to maturity and certificates of deposit.

The Postretirement Medical Fund holds investments designed to assist in reaching the stated goal of accumulating assets

equal to 50% of the accrued postretirement health benefits by December 31, 2015. This fund invests in bond and equity mutual funds.

At December 31, 2015, investments were comprised as follows:

	Cost	Fair Value	Level 1	Level 2
Reserve Fund				
Certificates of deposit	\$10,695,801	\$10,695,801	\$10,695,801	\$ -
Postretirement Medical Fund				
Bond funds	1,240,620	1,219,583	-	1,219,583
Equity funds				
Small Cap Index	163,224	170,610	-	170,610
Mid Cap Index	159,298	171,032	-	171,032
S&P 500 Index	1,293,352	1,399,787	-	1,399,787
International Index	415,475	388,420	-	388,420
	<u>3,271,969</u>	<u>3,349,432</u>	<u>-</u>	<u>3,349,432</u>
Totals	<u>13,967,770</u>	<u>14,045,233</u>	<u>10,695,801</u>	<u>3,349,432</u>

Investment income for 2015 and 2014 is comprised of the following:

	2015	2014
Interest and dividends	\$146,837	\$106,044
Realized gains	7,031	509,525
Change in unrealized appreciation	(74,105)	(364,228)
Investment expenses	<u>(30,006)</u>	<u>(28,304)</u>
	<u>49,757</u>	<u>223,037</u>

Functional Expenses: The consolidated statement of Functional Expenses (Exhibit C) provides detail as to program costs by major activity and supporting services. In addition to the program costs reflected on that Exhibit, amounts shown on the consolidated statement of activities (Exhibit B) as cost of literature distributed also relate to the publishing and magazine programs.

Two of the major program activities described on Exhibit C are for "Group Services" and "Fellowship Services." Group Services includes those activities most closely associated with serving A.A. groups, including staff services, the *Box 4-5-9* newsletter, directories, group records and files, the contributions department and services to French- and Spanish-speaking groups in North America. Fellowship Services include activities outside of the group, such as public information, cooperation with the professional community, treatment and correctional facilities, archives and loners and overseas services.

Supporting services include costs of the General Service Office, which cannot be attributed to any specific program activity. These include administrative management, data processing and information systems, editorial and clerical support, trustee and director activities, copy center, accounting, human resources and miscellaneous administrative functions.

The allocation of supporting services to program activities on Exhibit C is done on a pro rata basis to program expenses by entity, and is provided for informational purposes only.

Fundraising costs are immaterial.

Operating Expenses: For purposes of the Statement of Functional Expenses, operating expenses are defined as recurring items requiring the current outlay of cash.

Management Estimates: The management of the Organizations use estimates and assumptions in preparing financial statements in accordance with accounting principles generally accepted in the United States of America. These estimates and assumptions affect the reported amounts of assets, liabilities, revenues and expenses. Actual results could vary from the estimates that management uses.

As described in Note 5 of this report, management made certain significant estimates in the calculation of liabilities for

postretirement health benefits. These estimates include employee retention, health care cost trends and the actuarial lives of present and projected retirees eligible for benefits. It is reasonably possible that changes in these estimates will occur in the near term. The effect of changes in these estimates cannot be determined.

Subsequent Events: In connection with the preparation of these consolidated financial statements, Management evaluated subsequent events after the balance sheet date of December 31, 2015 through March 30, 2016, which was the date the financial statements were able to be issued.

Note 3 Retirement Plan: The Organizations adopted a defined benefit pension plan effective January 1, 1965 to provide retirement benefits to eligible U.S. employees who have completed one year of service.

The plan provides an annual benefit equal to 2% of final average compensation multiplied by years of service (not to exceed 35 years), less 0.65% of average social security earnings multiplied by years of service (not to exceed 30 years). The social security offset cannot reduce the gross benefit by more than 50%.

Pension expense is recorded in accordance with ASC 715 under which costs are accrued ratably over an employee's years of service based upon factors that are not necessarily the same as those used to calculate the annual funding requirements. In addition, ASC 715 requires an employer to report an asset or liability on the Organization's balance sheet depending upon a comparison of the Plan's assets to its benefit obligations.

The contributions made to fund pension benefits are recorded by the operating companies as an expense. The difference between the amounts actually paid and the net periodic pension cost under ASC 715 is recorded as an adjustment to retirement expense as a non-cash item that does not affect current operations.

The following tables set forth the Plan's funded status, assumptions, benefit cost and payments and employer contributions for 2015:

Fair value of plan assets (at December 31)	\$ 27,788,569
Benefit obligation (at December 31)	<u>33,847,852</u>
Funded status	<u>(6,059,283)</u>
Accrued pension cost recognized in consolidated statement of financial position	<u>\$ 6,059,283</u>
Accumulated benefit obligation	\$ 30,473,175
Benefit cost	1,005,283
Employers' contributions	1,567,100
Benefits paid	1,572,354
Classification of benefit costs:	
Operating expense (cash funding)	\$ 1,567,100
Non-operating expense (non-cash adjustment to pension cost)	<u>(561,817)</u>
	<u>1,005,283</u>
Weighted — Average Assumptions used to determine benefit obligations at December 31, 2015:	
Discount rate	4.26%
Salary increases	3.0%
Expected long-term return on assets	7.5%
Weighted — Average Assumptions used to determine net periodic pension cost for year ended December 31, 2015:	
Discount rate	3.89%
Salary increases	3.5%
Expected long-term return on assets	8.0%

The expected rate of return on plan assets is determined by those assets' historical long-term investment performance, current asset allocation, and estimates of future long-term returns by asset class.

The fair value of plan assets at December 31, 2015 were composed as follows:

	Total	Level 1	Level 2
Cash and equivalents	\$ 1,345,281	\$ 1,345,281	\$ -
Domestic equity mutual funds	15,114,182		15,114,182
International equity mutual fund	2,748,337		2,748,337
Bond mutual funds	8,580,769		8,580,769
	<u>27,788,569</u>	<u>1,345,281</u>	<u>26,443,288</u>

The mutual funds in the plan are primarily index funds designed to achieve diversification between fixed income and equity investments among asset classes including S&P 500, small capitalization companies and international stocks.

The expected benefits to be paid for the next ten years are as follows:

2016	\$ 1,679,077
2017	1,657,161
2018	1,684,874
2019	1,746,879
2020	1,766,602
2021 - 2025	9,561,405

The employers' contributions for 2016 are expected to be \$1,500,000.

Effective January 1, 2013, the Corporations implemented a "soft freeze" of the defined benefit pension plan. Employees in the plan as of December 31, 2012, continue to accrue benefits; however, employees hired after that date participate instead in a new defined contribution plan. The contribution rate is 5% plus a 50% match on employee contributions up to 5%. Therefore, the maximum combined rate is 7.5%. The 2015 pension cost was \$51,364.

Note 4 Lease Commitments: At December 31, 2015, A.A.W.S. as fiscal agent for the G.S.B. and the A.A. Grapevine, Inc. was subject to the following noncancellable leases (exclusive of future operating increases) for office space at 475 Riverside Drive in New York City

\$789,812 annual lease through December 31, 2025 for space on the 11th floor; \$133,444 annual lease through December 31, 2018 for space on the 10th floor. Future minimum rental payments due under the leases are as follows:

2016	\$ 923,256
2017	923,256
2018	923,256
2019	789,812
2020	789,812
2021 - 2025	<u>3,949,060</u>
	<u>8,298,452</u>

The space on the 10th floor is subleased at \$133,444 per year plus annual operating increments through January 1, 2018 to an unaffiliated not-for-profit organization. The above lease expense will be offset by payments due under the sublease as follows:

2016	\$ 133,444
2017	133,444
2018	<u>133,444</u>
	<u>400,332</u>

Note 5 Postretirement Health Benefits: The Organizations provide health care benefits for retired employees, substantially all of whom become eligible if they attain retirement age while working at the General Service Office. Benefits are provided through health insurance contracts maintained by the Corporations. For employees hired before 2004, 25% of the cost is borne by the retirees.

For employees hired after January 1, 2004, there is a three-tier structure in the level of group medical insurance premiums paid for on behalf of employees who retire directly from G.S.O. For

employees with 5-9 years of service, the Organizations pay 25%, 10-15 years 50% and more than 15 years 75%.

In March 2016 the Organizations decided to no longer provide healthcare benefits upon retirement for employees hired after June 30, 2016.

The assumed health care cost trend rate used to measure the expected cost of benefits covered by the plan is 6.0%. A discount rate of 4.26% has been used to measure the accrued postretirement health benefit obligation shown on Exhibit B at December 31, 2015. The discount rate was 3.89% at December 31, 2014.

Prior to 2006, the Plan was unfunded. However, as described in Note 1, a Postretirement Medical Fund was created by the Board with the purpose of accumulating assets equal to 50% of the postretirement health benefits liability after ten years. As of December 31, 2015, the Fund's assets were equal to 47.1% of the benefit obligation.

The following table sets forth information regarding the Plan for 2015:

Benefit obligation (at December 31)	\$7,186,857
Benefits paid	\$ 282,804
Benefit cost	<u>\$ 586,930</u>

Benefit cost reported by:	
Operating entities	\$ 533,804
Postretirement Medical Fund	<u>\$ 53,126</u>
	<u>\$ 586,930</u>

The expected postretirement benefits to be paid for the next ten years are as follows:

2016	\$ 299,772
2017	317,758
2018	336,823
2019	357,032
2020	378,454
2021 - 2025	2,261,384

Note 6 Tax Status: The Organizations are exempt from Federal income taxes under section 501(a) as further described in 501(c)(3) of the Internal Revenue Code, and are classified as public charities. They are also exempt from New York State franchise and sales taxes.



The General Service Office 2016 OPERATING BUDGET

INCOME	2015 Budget	2015 Actual	2016 Budget
GROSS SALES	\$14,820,000	\$12,720,222	\$13,707,484
Discounts Allowed	250,000	230,789	235,000
Net Sales	14,570,000	12,489,433	13,472,484
Cost of Literature Distributed			
Manufacturing	3,038,700	2,737,914	2,710,000
Royalties	28,000	19,078	0
Gross Margin	11,503,300	9,732,441	10,762,484
DIRECT SHIPPING AND WAREHOUSING	1,866,550	1,562,058	1,755,100
Gross Profit from Literature	9,636,750	8,170,383	9,007,384
	66.14%	65.42%	66.86%
Contributions Received	7,000,000	7,154,146	7,100,000
Interest Income	400	435	400
Total Revenue	16,637,150	15,324,964	16,107,784
OPERATING EXPENSES			
Salaries	6,735,000	6,072,802	6,543,000
Payroll taxes	486,000	451,604	486,000
Insurance	1,209,800	1,206,680	1,259,800
Retirement expense	1,787,000	1,727,249	1,793,500
Other program printing	405,800	386,694	386,500
Mailing, labor, etc.	131,500	112,373	125,800
Postage & express	441,800	377,080	364,500
Writers' fees	176,250	99,787	161,500
Other literature assistance	50,000	24,889	50,000
Selling expenses	417,750	353,820	426,250
Professional fees	354,500	196,406	153,000
Contracted services	1,412,000	1,343,980	1,230,000
Occupancy	848,500	850,431	807,500
Telephone	111,700	105,490	104,200
Equipment maintenance	76,800	70,973	81,800
Furniture & equipment	244,000	206,118	167,500
Stationery & office expense	204,500	139,704	205,000
Office service & expense	343,425	320,314	386,425
Travel, meals, & accommodations	1,185,200	1,058,768	1,399,700
Bad debts	2,500	14,177	2,500
TOTAL OPERATING EXPENSES	16,624,025	15,119,339	16,134,475
INCOME (LOSS) FOR PERIOD	\$13,125	\$205,625	(\$26,691)

Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.

2016 BUDGET

	GRAPEVINE			LA VIÑA		
	2015 Budget	2015 Actual	2016 Budget	2015 Budget	2015 Actual	2016 Budget
PAID CIRCULATION—						
AVERAGE # OF PRINT COPIES	69,632	71,966	70,369	9,860	10,355	10,017
Online Circulation	<u>5,368</u>	<u>5,233</u>	<u>5,097</u>	<u> </u>	<u> </u>	<u> </u>
INCOME FROM MAGAZINE						
Subscription income	\$1,915,379	\$1,951,005	\$1,907,710	\$106,343	\$114,034	\$110,314
Single copies and back issues	38,405	34,996	31,497	9,947	7,096	8,996
GV Online	<u>159,591</u>	<u>158,277</u>	<u>154,159</u>	<u> </u>	<u> </u>	<u> </u>
<u>Total magazine income</u>	<u>2,113,375</u>	<u>2,144,278</u>	<u>2,093,366</u>	<u>116,290</u>	<u>121,130</u>	<u>119,310</u>
<u>Total direct costs</u>	<u>680,761</u>	<u>726,031</u>	<u>731,037</u>	<u>59,317</u>	<u>57,970</u>	<u>57,761</u>
Gross Profit on Magazine	<u>1,432,614</u>	<u>1,418,247</u>	<u>1,362,329</u>	<u>56,973</u>	<u>63,160</u>	<u>61,549</u>
OTHER PUBLISHING INCOME	734,373	811,075	577,187	11,632	12,965	21,984
<u>Total direct costs</u>	<u>228,560</u>	<u>260,494</u>	<u>222,533</u>	<u>2,334</u>	<u>2,885</u>	<u>6,408</u>
Gross Profit on Other Items	<u>505,813</u>	<u>550,581</u>	<u>354,654</u>	<u>9,298</u>	<u>10,080</u>	<u>15,576</u>
Total Gross Profit	<u>1,938,427</u>	<u>1,968,828</u>	<u>1,716,983</u>	<u>66,271</u>	<u>73,240</u>	<u>77,125</u>
COSTS AND EXPENSES						
EDITORIAL COSTS						
Salaries, including temporary help	414,813	390,503	435,170	97,606	94,612	93,831
Payroll taxes and benefits	158,499	137,457	164,114	34,838	34,254	35,281
Occupancy costs	38,246	34,013	44,540			
Office supplies and expenses	26,813	25,179	25,935	1,450	1,338	1,378
Product development & Web	<u>135,000</u>	<u>79,623</u>	<u>85,000</u>	<u> </u>	<u> </u>	<u> </u>
<u>Total Editorial</u>	<u>773,371</u>	<u>666,775</u>	<u>754,758</u>	<u>133,894</u>	<u>130,204</u>	<u>130,490</u>
CIRCULATION AND BUSINESS						
Salaries, including temporary help	334,340	352,179	312,220	45,031	44,080	50,640
Payroll taxes and benefits	220,079	213,515	221,176	20,079	18,712	19,273
Fulfillment	159,630	150,837	155,363	8,903	6,429	8,529
Occupancy costs	38,851	33,662	44,179			
Office supplies and expenses	94,893	95,237	98,094			
Selling expense-regular	95,000	68,446	65,582	12,046	12,712	13,094
- GvR program	11,589	6,012	11,109			
Postage	<u>2,979</u>	<u>4,973</u>	<u>5,122</u>	<u> </u>	<u> </u>	<u> </u>
<u>Total Circulation and Business</u>	<u>957,361</u>	<u>924,861</u>	<u>912,845</u>	<u>86,059</u>	<u>81,933</u>	<u>91,536</u>
GENERAL AND ADMINISTRATIVE						
Computer Consulting	30,000	19,793	30,000			
Insurance	9,247	9,029	9,390			
Professional fees	60,000	42,228	60,000			
Meetings and conferences	78,000	44,096	47,697	5,258	7,481	7,706
Furniture and equipment	15,000	4,845	15,000	518		
Canadian exchange and other	9,837	11,064	9,837			
Bank service charges	18,418	12,369	18,418			
Bad debts	<u>10,000</u>	<u>1,057</u>	<u>10,000</u>	<u> </u>	<u> </u>	<u> </u>
<u>Total General and Administrative</u>	<u>230,502</u>	<u>144,481</u>	<u>200,342</u>	<u>5,776</u>	<u>7,481</u>	<u>7,706</u>
TOTAL COSTS AND EXPENSES	<u>1,961,234</u>	<u>1,736,117</u>	<u>1,867,965</u>	<u>225,729</u>	<u>219,618</u>	<u>229,732</u>
Add: Interest earned	8,200	8,100	4,700			
Support from GSB General Fund				159,458	146,378	152,607
NET INCOME (LOSS) FOR PERIOD	<u>(\$14,607)</u>	<u>\$240,811</u>	<u>(\$146,263)</u>	<u>\$0</u>	<u>\$0</u>	<u>\$0</u>

2015 Contributions From Groups, Individuals, Specials, Special Meetings — by Delegate Area (in U.S. Dollars)

AREA #	GENERAL SERVICE CONFERENCE AREA	#GPS. REPORTED	#GPS. CONTRIB.	% OF GPS. CONTRIB.	TOTAL GROUP CONTRIB.	MEMBERSHIP	CONTRIBUTION PER CAPITA	INDIVIDUAL MEMBERS	MEMORIAL	SPECIALS ⁽¹⁾	SPECIAL MEETINGS ⁽²⁾	TOTAL AREA CONTRIBUTIONS	PER CAPITA
1.	Ala./N.W. Fla.	443	192	43.3%	\$42,265.11	9,264	\$4.56	3,610.45	\$0	\$261.49	\$0	\$46,137.05	\$4.98
2.	Alaska	182	89	48.9	18,737.92	3,065	6.11	1,240.80		453.81		20,432.53	6.67
3.	Arizona	1,007	446	44.3	128,939.87	21,656	5.95	12,700.92	37.00	6,064.48	578.00	148,320.27	6.85
4.	Arkansas	257	121	47.1	26,030.07	4,361	5.97	598.15	480.00	1,790.60		28,898.82	6.63
	California												
5.	Southern California	1,395	410	29.4	118,906.61	45,829	2.59	17,867.32		4,696.26	498.28	141,968.47	3.10
6.	N. Coastal	2,051	1,123	54.8	303,377.83	59,660	5.09	34,040.90	4,218.00	8,718.75	50.00	350,405.48	5.87
7.	N. Interior	1,045	450	43.1	93,591.72	28,509	3.28	8,607.53		2,948.54		105,147.79	3.69
8.	San Diego/Imperial	1,064	409	38.4	80,369.89	27,615	2.91	8,335.39	5,000.00	2,316.86	849.50	96,871.64	3.51
9.	Mid-Southern	2,108	831	39.4	205,719.30	62,242	3.31	16,310.29		13,595.65	680.79	236,306.03	3.80
10.	Colorado	865	440	50.9	122,019.97	19,367	6.30	13,692.24	100.00	8,703.92	61.60	144,577.73	7.47
11.	Connecticut	1,444	577	40.0	134,016.15	32,420	4.13	12,016.03	2,040.00	13,498.44	55.00	161,625.62	4.99
12.	Delaware	260	129	49.6	37,190.54	3,832	9.71	342		1,000.00		38,532.54	10.06
13.	District Of Columbia	504	198	39.3	55,708.82	13,842	4.02	3,517.38		1,918.00		61,144.20	4.42
	Florida												
14.	North	978	440	45.0	116,282.08	19,481	5.97	10,073.00	4,320.00	6,483.28	118.24	137,276.60	7.05
15.	South	2,169	908	41.9	223,914.82	41,720	5.37	18,232.91	7,138.00	118,914.23	14.00	368,213.96	8.83
16.	Georgia	758	457	60.3	120,926.54	19,233	6.29	9,239.27	100.00	6,704.78		136,970.59	7.12
17.	Hawaii	320	164	51.2	38,833.18	5,464	7.11	1,013.01		429.10	20.34	40,295.63	7.37
18.	Idaho	259	88	34.0	19,111.46	4,645	4.11	1,021.25	5,000.00	2,020.33		27,153.04	5.85
	Illinois												
19.	Chicago	1,303	320	24.6	86,318.59	25,601	3.37	7,637.66	215.00	2,045.00	285.00	96,501.25	3.77
20.	Northern	1,291	459	35.6	69,425.09	22,971	3.02	7,709.00	675.00	16,834.51		94,643.60	4.12
21.	Southern	445	168	37.8	27,610.37	7,412	3.73	1,098.00	21.00	30.00		28,759.37	3.88
	Indiana												
22.	Northern	662	247	37.3	39,367.21	9,463	4.16	2,996.60	45.00	2,840.10		45,248.91	4.78
23.	Southern	675	286	42.4	41,851.51	11,579	3.61	4,305.84	25.00	1,796.34		47,978.69	4.14
24.	Iowa	696	297	42.7	58,252.93	14,336	4.06	3,387.45		1,038.00	115.30	62,793.68	4.38
25.	Kansas	350	164	46.9	34,973.19	8,713	4.01	480.5	400.00	5,547.46		41,401.15	4.75
26.	Kentucky	763	312	40.9	77,135.66	12,064	6.39	10,904.82	398.00	4,937.41	366.00	93,741.89	7.77
27.	Louisiana	609	185	30.4	49,696.12	11,333	4.39	760		2,566.51		53,022.63	4.68
28.	Maine	557	173	31.1	25,367.17	8,420	3.01	2,887.98		3,190.78	1,078.00	32,523.93	3.86
29.	Maryland	1,018	413	40.6	89,050.45	15,087	5.90	5,763.59	25.00	287.00	24.00	95,150.04	6.31
	Massachusetts												
30.	Eastern	1,521	532	35.0	129,272.15	45,670	2.83	12,976.65	2,000.00	763.00	50.00	145,061.80	3.18
31.	Western	320	156	48.8	20,687.97	5,279	3.92	3,737.28		30.00	60.00	24,515.25	4.64
	Michigan												
32.	Central	715	253	35.4	39,568.24	14,936	2.65	4,893.10	100.00	4,503.96		49,065.30	3.29
33.	Southeastern	970	263	27.1	53,669.81	20,422	2.63	2,891.55		56,561.36		56,561.36	2.77
34.	Western	625	194	31.0	46,461.20	11,979	3.88	1,278.55		4,250.00		51,989.75	4.34
	Minnesota												
35.	Northern	570	261	45.8	35,570.69	8,418	4.23	1,585.18	50.00	333.00		37,538.87	4.46
36.	Southern	1,162	416	35.8	95,008.52	27,704	3.43	3,428.77		10,445.01	520.00	109,402.30	3.95
37.	Mississippi	219	74	33.8	17,261.22	4,325	3.99	378.1		1,500.00		19,139.32	4.43
	Missouri												
38.	Eastern	607	241	39.7	65,171.49	9,692	6.72	3,007.80		455.40		68,634.69	7.08
39.	Western	226	105	46.5	21,825.79	6,554	3.33	745.54		474.77		23,046.10	3.52
40.	Montana	269	121	45.0	30,342.96	5,264	5.76	1,104.00		1,527.15		32,974.11	6.26
41.	Nebraska	683	262	38.4	49,821.43	14,921	3.34	812.9		444.37		51,078.70	3.42
42.	Nevada	632	211	33.4	42,298.53	14,165	2.99	4,511.46	1,000.00	2,030.56	45.25	49,885.80	3.52
43.	New Hampshire	640	246	38.4	34,915.47	9,283	3.76	7,870.93		4,942.50		47,728.90	5.14
	New Jersey												
44.	Northern	1,340	530	39.6	138,917.31	31,487	4.41	16,237.10	101.00	3,448.88	1,780.00	160,484.29	5.10
45.	Southern	564	266	47.2	67,296.49	9,008	7.47	3,495.65		213.98	356.00	71,362.12	7.92
46.	New Mexico	377	167	44.3	32,248.93	7,112	4.53	1,960.27		1,652.25	105.00	35,966.45	5.06
	New York												
47.	Central	744	251	33.7	49,442.57	9,914	4.99	4,837.00		1,671.40		55,950.97	5.64
48.	H./M./B.	741	291	39.3	38,198.56	10,862	3.52	1,215.67	5,000.00	4,870.46	10.00	49,294.69	4.54
49.	Southeast	1,832	695	37.9	264,181.92	54,409	4.86	15,868.81	4,000.00	5,129.90	112.58	289,293.21	5.32
50.	Western	302	87	28.8	15,759.68	4,757	3.31	255		100.00		16,114.68	3.39
51.	North Carolina	1,132	559	49.4	143,004.63	19,222	7.44	21,546.97	50.00	15,229.64	90.00	179,921.24	9.36
52.	North Dakota	175	78	44.6	16,831.69	3,327	5.06	130		1,728.98		18,690.67	5.62
	Ohio												
53.	Central & Southeast	857	217	25.3	29,876.64	9,959	3.00	7,421.01		346.61		37,644.26	3.78
54.	Northeast	1,581	305	19.3	41,950.10	19,089	2.20	2,185.15	25.00	249.82	45.00	44,455.07	2.33
55.	Northwest	307	85	27.7	11,786.96	4,045	2.91	262		40.00		12,088.96	2.99
56.	Southwest	544	260	47.8	51,188.98	9,249	5.53	932.21		4,354.71		56,475.90	6.11
57.	Oklahoma	407	168	41.3	39,773.84	8,847	4.50	1,509.81	100.00	20.00		41,403.65	4.68
58.	Oregon	1,232	430	34.9	88,670.57	22,425	3.95	4,909.60		444.87	40.60	94,065.64	4.19

Pennsylvania													
59.	Eastern	1,645	776	47.2	189,835.06	32,535	5.83	10,995.81	3,200.00	4,939.47	143.39	209,113.73	6.43
60.	Western	925	341	36.9	60,305.41	11,896	5.07	4,639.65	120.00	1,333.16		66,398.22	5.58
61.	Rhode Island	303	126	41.6	26,056.96	6,004	4.34	2,230.70		1,887.64		30,175.30	5.03
62.	South Carolina	410	197	48.0	63,273.35	9,677	6.54	1,317.10		7,187.14	15.00	71,792.59	7.42
63.	South Dakota	188	59	31.4	12,181.44	4,744	2.57	265		3,697.41		16,143.85	3.40
64.	Tennessee	616	222	36.0	58,694.06	12,818	4.58	960	4,655.27	90.00		64,399.33	5.02
Texas													
65.	Northeast	541	184	34.0	99,527.23	19,108	5.21	7,762.63		4,544.25		111,834.11	5.85
66.	Northwest	278	60	21.6	19,555.28	5,232	3.74	1,424.00		5,926.35		26,905.63	5.14
67.	Southeast	673	268	39.8	78,873.35	16,860	4.68	11,595.02		4,276.98	25.00	94,770.35	5.62
68.	Southwest	641	266	41.5	108,313.20	14,377	7.53	7,228.05	125.00	1,498.30		117,164.55	8.15
69.	Utah	390	157	40.3	37,812.55	6,931	5.46	3,062.32		290.00	46.22	41,211.09	5.95
70.	Vermont	300	133	44.3	30,761.36	4,796	6.41	1,534.00		5,696.47		37,991.83	7.92
71.	Virginia	1,527	698	45.7	181,226.40	25,662	7.06	23,733.00	550.00	9,155.16	458.13	215,122.69	8.38
72.	Western Washington	1,534	599	39.0	143,288.17	30,963	4.63	20,089.31	75.00	22,188.07	223.00	185,863.55	6.00
73.	West Virginia	277	114	41.2	15,443.24	2,863	5.39	3,559.00	25.00	140.00		19,167.24	6.69
Wisconsin													
74.	N. Wis./Upper Pen. Mich.	759	259	34.1	31,154.05	10,850	2.87	297	475.00	226.82		32,152.87	2.96
75.	Southern	1,085	441	40.6	58,615.58	18,903	3.10	904.56		98.00	60.00	59,678.14	3.16
76.	Wyoming	124	59	47.6	13,076.56	1,963	6.66	808.15	83.00	2,797.75		16,765.46	8.54
77.	Puerto Rico	124	65	52.4	7,896.01	1,220	6.47	87		1,036.20		9,019.21	7.39
78.	Alberta/N.W.T.	544	236	43.4	83,375.23	9,152	9.11	559.67		3,394.38	1,170.34	88,499.62	9.67
79.	B.C./Yukon	810	396	48.9	101,461.94	14,604	6.95	1,514.77	4,338.94	7,352.13	288.80	114,956.58	7.87
80.	Manitoba Canada	152	40	26.3	10,584.73	3,894	2.72	137.02				10,721.75	2.75
81.	N.B./P.E.I.	180	80	44.4	11,399.53	2,830	4.03	96.39		2,462.38		13,958.30	4.93
82.	N.S./Nfld./Lab.	256	91	35.5	15,475.38	3,257	4.75	527.93		1,312.41		17,315.72	5.32
Ontario													
83.	Eastern	595	244	41.0	59,385.85	14,245	4.17	1,268.29	4,136.39	9,554.64	787.59	75,132.76	5.27
84.	Northeast	173	63	36.4	12,823.50	1,827	7.02			6,183.43	444.66	19,451.59	10.65
85.	Northwest	59	17	28.8	4,220.60	1,005	4.20	117.32	81.92			4,419.84	4.40
86.	Western	589	248	42.1	60,731.01	10,003	6.07	1,437.31		8,776.66	339.04	71,284.02	7.13
Quebec ⁽³⁾													
87.	Southwest (e)	569	438	77.0	19,389.11	9,067	2.14	1,620.85		9,891.67		30,901.63	3.41
88.	Southeast (e)	180	128	71.1	2,573.00	2,675	0.96	1,150.06		12,560.63		16,283.69	6.09
89.	Northeast	323	249	77.1	2,988.78	4,207	0.71	292.32		22,872.79		26,153.89	6.22
90.	Northwest (e)	335	303	90.4	2,672.64	5,902	0.45	639.4		66,458.65		69,770.69	11.82
91.	Saskatchewan Canada	278	119	42.8	27,292.76	2,862	9.54	270.09		3,408.11		30,970.96	10.82
92.	Washington State East	484	197	40.7	31,860.69	5,968	5.34	1,501.35		1,349.64		34,711.68	5.82
93.	Central California	1,102	407	36.9	95,005.23	27,664	3.43	5,554.53		5,172.47	1,298.49	107,030.72	3.87
Total U.S./ Canada		65,741	26,500	40.3%	\$5,973,123.75	1,348,072	\$4.43	\$471,557.94	\$60,528.52	\$550,592.01	\$13,308.14	\$7,069,110.36	\$5.24
Individual, in-memoriam, & special meetings					545,394.60								
Specials					550,592.01								
Total for U.S. & Canada					\$7,069,110.36								
FOREIGN AND OTHER													
Loners					\$48.50							\$48.50	
International Young People					3,852.00							3,852.00	
Birds of a Feather					1,400.00							1,400.00	
Foreign, WSM, other					78,521.42							78,521.42	
Online and Telephone Meetings					1,213.33							1,213.33	
Grand Total					\$7,154,145.61							\$7,154,145.61	5.27

CONTRIBUTION COMPARISON – 2015-2014 – (in U.S. dollars)

	#GPS. REPORTED	#GPS. CONTRIB.	% OF GPS. CONTRIB.	TOTAL GROUP CONTRIB.	MEMBERSHIP	TOTAL PER CAPITA INCLUDING SPECIALS ETC		
U.S. & Canada 2015	65,741	26,500	40.3%	\$5,973,123.75	1,348,072	\$5.24		
U.S. & Canada 2014	65,222	27,013	41.6%	\$5,813,064.53	1,373,497	\$4.93		
Increase (Decrease)	519	(513)	(1.3)%	\$160,059.22	(25,425)	\$0.31	EST. COST OF SERVICES PER CAPITA	2015 7.14 2014 \$7.08

⁽¹⁾ A Special contribution is one that comes from any number of A.A. entities that is not an A.A. Group. For example, a Conference, a Committee, an Area, a District, an Intergroup, etc.

⁽²⁾ A Special Meeting is a meeting that does not want to be a group but does want to contribute to the General Service Board.

⁽³⁾ Reflects not only those groups that contributed directly to G.S.O., but also those groups that contributed through their Conference Areas (per info from areas).

The Budget Highlights

2016 G.S.O. Budget

These budget highlights describe the "OPERATIONS" of the General Service Office—A.A. World Services (the Publishing operation), the General Fund (Service activities) and the Grapevine Operations. It excludes any activities reported separately in the Reserve Fund, Convention Fund, Post-Retirement Fund or the Capital Projects Fund.

Income: The 2016 budget projects literature gross sales of \$13,707,484. The 2016 budget was developed with the realization that unit sales volumes have been declining gradually, however we are expecting an overall increase in unit sales as those who purchased significant amounts of literature prior to the October 1, 2014 need to restock. When approving the 2016 budget, the A.A.W.S. Board continued to focus diligently on revenue and expense assumptions and how they ultimately affect the long-term fiscal health of the General Service Board and its Reserve Fund.

Manufacturing, royalties, and shipping and warehousing costs are budgeted slightly higher than the 2015 results taking into consideration inflationary increases and the expected increment in unit sales, offset by the absence of royalty payments as the last recipient has passed away.

After subtracting manufacturing and shipping and warehousing costs, gross profit is budgeted at \$9,007,384, or 66.9%. The 66.9% gross profit percentage anticipated for 2016 compares with 65.4% realized for 2015 and 66.1% budgeted for 2015.

It should be recognized that as we continue to strive to have literature available throughout our Service Structure in Spanish and French, as well as English, lower print runs in non-English languages usually results in higher production costs. We strive to have the same selling prices regardless of the manufacturing cost; therefore lower gross profit margins for low volume items will affect the overall gross profit percentages in the future.

The table below reflects the Gross Profit Percentages from 2011 through the 2016 budget.

2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016 Budget
63.7%	63.7%	64.3%	58.6%	65.4%	66.9%

Prudence dictates that ongoing reviews are necessary to control costs and reinforce the revenue stream to provide sufficient funds to continue providing services. Trusted servants continue to evaluate costs of operations as well as assess the services provided.

Contributions: Seventh Tradition self-support contributions for 2016 are budgeted at 7,100,000, which is just slightly higher than the 2015 budget and approximately even with 2015 actual contributions received of \$7,154,000.

During 2015, contributions from groups and individuals (as distinguished from those received for the World Service Meeting literature efforts) of \$7,109,338 were \$145,338 greater than budget and \$280,848 greater than 2014. Contributions received from World Service Meeting countries toward the World Service Meeting International Literature efforts amounted to \$44,808, approximately two thirds of \$69,600 received in 2014. Total contributions including WSM efforts were just over \$7,154,146.

The percentage of the A.A. groups that choose to list with the General Service Office that have participated in the Seventh Tradition by contributing to the General Service Office was 40.3% in 2015. For the last ten years it has been in a relatively stable range (between 40% and 45%) for the past ten years.

Total Operating Revenue for 2016 is anticipated at \$16,107,784, an increase of approximately \$800,000 (5%).

Total Operating Expenses for 2016 have been budgeted at \$16,134,475, approximately \$1,015,136 or 6.7% greater than 2015 expenses but \$489,550 (2.9%) less than the 2015 budget.

The 2016 G.S.O. budget anticipates an excess of expenses over revenue of \$26,691. After considerable discussion that included concern for sales trends and expenses, the A.A.W.S. Board recommended and the General Service Board approved the 2016 budget.

It should be remembered that generally the Reserve Fund is funded by literature profits. This anticipated loss for 2016 compares with a profit of \$205,625 for 2015, \$1,376,656 for 2014, \$31,554 for 2013, \$152,448 for 2012, \$819,132 for 2011, \$1,255,289 for 2010, \$1,273,500 for 2009, and a loss of \$275,000 for 2008.

2016 Grapevine Budget

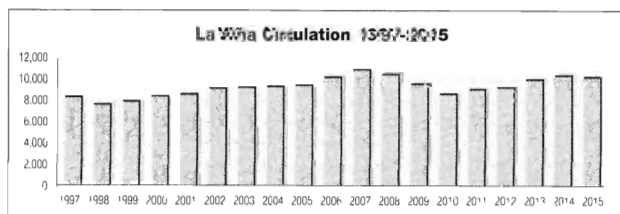
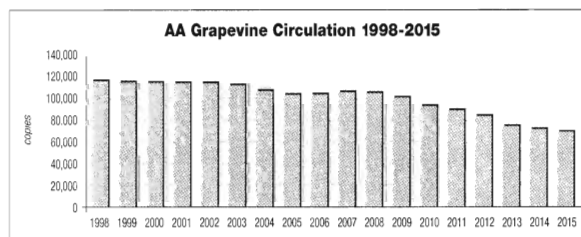
The 2016 Grapevine Budget calls for an average circulation for the print magazine of 70,369. This anticipates 737 more copies than the 2015 budget but approximately 1,597 fewer than the 2015 average paid print circulation of 71,966. The 2016 budget calls for approximately 5,097 GV online subscriptions, which compares with the 2015 budget of 5,368 and the 5,233 actually achieved. Print magazine circulation for the last 18 years is depicted in the adjacent chart.

Income: Magazine income of \$2,093,366 is expected to be approximately \$50,900 less than 2015. Other Publishing Income from books, cassette tapes, and miscellaneous items is budgeted at \$577,187, approximately \$233,900 less than 2015.

Total Gross Profit: Combining the magazine and other publishing items, a gross profit of \$1,716,983 is budgeted for 2016. This compares with \$1,968,828 achieved for the 2015 budget of \$1,938,427.

Total Operating Expenses: Total Operating Expenses for 2016 are budgeted at \$1,867,946, \$131,829 greater than the 2015 expenses of \$1,736,117, but \$95,288 less than the 2015 budget.

Net Income (loss): For 2016, the Grapevine anticipates a net loss of \$146,263. This compares with a 2015 budgeted loss of \$14,607 and an actual profit from operations of \$240,811.



For 2016, La Vina expects a gross profit on the magazine of \$61,549 compared with \$63,160 achieved in 2015. Circulation for 2016 is estimated to decline to 10,017, some 338 or 3% less than the 2015 average but 1.5% greater than the 2015 budget. Other Publishing Income is estimated at \$21,984, which after deducting cost of product of \$6,408 expects to contribute \$15,576 to revenue. Total costs and expenses are estimated at \$229,732 for 2016, approximately \$10,000 greater than 2015 and \$4,000 more than the 2015 budget. The 2016 budget projects a shortfall of expense over revenue of \$152,607, to be funded by the General Service Board General Fund. The anticipated 2016 shortfall is \$6,200 greater than the 2015 shortfall of \$146,378. As noted above these shortfalls for this service activity is funded by the General Service Board General Fund. Net shortfall since inception (1995) to date are approximately \$1,947,048.

The chart above reflects the La Vina magazine circulation

2016 La Viña Budget

Following the 1995 General Service Conference Advisory Action #7, the publication of the Grapevine magazine in Spanish was approved by both the Grapevine Board and the trustees' Finance Committee of the General Service Board. Recognizing this publication as a new venture, both boards were to review the financial impact on the Fellowship and the progress in circulation growth and to continue to monitor the viability of this new venture. In 2001, the General Service Board recommended, and the 2001 Conference approved that the La Viña magazine continues to be published by the Grapevine and that any ongoing shortfall between revenues and operating expenses be funded by the General Service Boards General Fund, instead of continuing to draw funds directly from the Reserve Fund.

■ 2016 Conference Committees

Conference Agenda

Michel Bergeron
Marge Del Carlo
Darren Flint
²Betty Morton
¹Michelle Pattridge
Ian Rabb
Barry Smith
Jim Struchen

Secretary: Mary Clare Lynch

Cooperation With the Professional Community

Boyd Bragg
¹Amy Carberg
John Carter
²Paula Elliott
Rena Harkness
Dave Houston
Ernie Murphy

Secretary: Tracy Ober

Corrections

Michael Cyr
²George Kulakowski
Irene Martin
Cheryl Nesler
Dale Randolph
Vikki Ray
Susan Riedy
Denise Thorn
¹Chris Wells

Secretary: Jeff Wine

Finance

Kenny Brown
Jim Cullen
Kelly Dempski
²Graham Gobie
Linda Jopling
Jennifer Kuntz
Tami Reynolds
¹Craig Weidner

Secretary: Donald Meurer

Grapevine

Dave Bradford
Kirk Faupel
¹Dave Fite
Kelly Lambert
²Raymundo Lujano
Fredy Mendoza
Michelle Schmidt
Vicky Shaw
Tony Shelby

Secretary: Jon Witherspoon

Literature

¹Jay Eckstein
Laura Goostree
²Tom Harlow
Tom Misteli
Larry Mumby
Mark Naegeli
Lisa Part
Derek Tait
Gilberto Vence

Secretary: Sandra Wilson

Policy/Admissions

Bub Branton
¹Lisa Dawn Gentry
Jim Hollen
Calvin Leonard
²Scott Mulligan
Bob Rowe
Joyce Saunders
Gene Wilson

Secretary: Eva Sanchez

Public Information

Tom Clyce
Jim Gordier
Laura Hansen
Andrew Levecchia
²Rebecca McNeill
Diane Perron
Scott Roush
Bill Walker
¹Glenn Walters

Secretary: Clay Rittenhouse

Report and Charter

Tommy Babuscio
¹Stephanie Bills
Pat Fallon
Jane Giatras
Thomas Green
Michael Miller
Bob Munsell
²Jim Stone

Secretary: Racy Joseph

Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities

Joe Carlon
Kenny Demarest
Wally Eick
¹Terry Ernst
Trent Geistlinger
Jennie Herd
²Kristi Hewitt
Melissa Redd

Secretary: Clement Cann

Trustees

Drew Armstrong
Charlotte Crabtree
Libbie Lapp
¹Rachel Moysan
Sue Cunningham Neill
Michael Dunn
Reilly Kalles
²Christopher Stoppler
Jim Wright

Secretary: Julio Espallat

³Archives

Michael Dunn
Lisa Dawn Gentry
²Calvin Leonard
Sue Cunningham Neill
Scott Roush
Vicky Shaw
¹Christopher Stoppler
Gilberto Vence

Secretary: Michelle Mirza

³International Conventions/A.A. Regional Forums

Bub Branton
Amy Carberg
¹Tom Clyce
Jim Hollen
Fredy Mendoza
²Cheryl Nesler
Ian Rabb
Michelle Schmidt

*Secretaries: Julio Espallat
Steve Smith*

2017 CONFERENCE CHAIRPERSONS AND ALTERNATE CHAIRPERSONS¹

Committee	Chairperson	Alternate
Agenda	Barry Smith, Idaho	Jim Struchen, South Carolina
³ Archives	Michael Dunn, New Brunswick/ Prince Edward Island	Sue Cunningham Neill, Kansas
Cooperation With the Professional Community	John Carter, NW Ohio	Dave Houston, NW Texas
Corrections	Michael Cyr, NW Quebec	Denise Thorn, SW Texas
Finance	Linda Jopling, Maryland	Kelly Demski, No. Minnesota
Grapevine	Dave Bradford, Arizona	Michelle Schmidt, Wyoming
³ International Conv./Regional Forums	Ian Raab, Manitoba	Fredy Mendoza, Western Ontario
Literature	Laura Goostree, SW Ohio	Derek Tait, N. Wisc./Upper Penn. MI
Policy/Admissions	Bob Rowe, Vermont	Gene Wilson, Maine
Public Information	Andrew Levecchia, So. New Jersey	Bill Walker, New Mexico
Report and Charter	Jane Giatras, Calif., San Diego/Imperial	Thomas Green, SW Quebec
Treatment-Accessibilities	Joe Carlon, California Mid-So.	Kenny Demarest, Rhode Island
Trustees	Charlotte Crabtree, So. Indiana	Reilly Kalles, Oregon

¹Chairperson

²Alternate Chairperson

³Members of this committee serve on this as a secondary committee assignment.

⁴The 2016 committee chairs rotated at the end of the 66th General Service Conference.

■ 2016 Trustees' Committees**

Archives

Michele Grinberg, *chairperson*
Lynda Bergeron
Carole Boerner
Peter Luongo
David Morris
Richard Purtell
Michelle Mirza, *secretary*

Audit

David Morris, *chairperson*
Richard Boisvert
Chet Parker
Albin Zezula
Don Meurer, *secretary*

Compensation

Bill Noonan, *chairperson*
Joel Castellaw
Joe Downey
Bob Wilcox
Don Meurer, *consultant*
Gary Glynn, *consultant*
Olga Mesonjnik, *secretary*

Conference

Andrew Ware, *chairperson*
Beau Bush
Joel Castellaw
Joe Downey
Michele Grinberg
Paz Preciado
Bob Wilcox
Mary Clare Lynch, *secretary*

Cooperation With the Professional Community/ Treatment/Accessibilities

Joel Castellaw, *chairperson*
Beau Bush
Yolanda Flores
John Fromson
Peter Luongo
David Noll
Richard Purtell
Tracy Ober, *secretary* — C PC
Clement Cann, *secretary*
— *Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities*

Corrections

Richard Boisvert, *chairperson*
John Fromson
Bill Noonan
Yolanda Flores
Scott Huyghebaert
*Robert MacDonald
David Noll
Andrew Ware
Jeff Wine, *secretary*

Finance & Budgetary

David Morris, *chairperson*
Leslie Backus
Lynda Bergeron
Carole Boerner
Joe Downey
Bill Farnsworth
Bill Noonan
Chet Parker
Albin Zezula
Kevin Sunkel,
consultant/independent auditor
Donald Meurer, *secretary*

International

Bob Wilcox, *chairperson*
Leslie Backus
Bill Farnsworth
Yolanda Flores
Scott Huyghebaert
Ivan Lemelle
Mary Cumings, *secretary*

International Conventions/ A.A. Regional Forums

Bill Farnsworth, *chairperson*
Leslie Backus
Joe Downey
Scott Huyghebaert
David Morris
Paz Preciado
Richard Purtell
Julio Espailat, *secretary*
— *International Conventions*
Steve Smith, *secretary*
— *Regional Forums*

Literature

Joe Downey, *chairperson*
Joel Castellaw
*Cindy French
Michele Grinberg
*Doug Grude
David Noll
Chet Parker
Paz Preciado
Eleanor Widdoes, *consultant*
Sandra Wilson, *secretary*

Nominating

Bill Noonan, *chairperson*
Richard Boisvert
John Fromson
Ivan Lemelle
Andrew Ware
Bob Wilcox
Albin Zezula
Julio Espailat, *secretary*

Public Information

Ivan Lemelle, *chairperson*
Lynda Bergeron
Carole Boerner
Richard Boisvert
Ralph (Beau) Bush
*Carolyn Carney
*Josh Eggleston
Peter Luongo
Andrew Ware
Clay Rittenhouse, *secretary*

General Sharing Session

John Fromson, *chairperson*
Eva Sanchez, *secretary*



Officers of the General Service Board

Chair
Terry Bedient
First vice-chairperson
Michele Grinberg, JD
Second vice-chairperson
William Noonan
Secretary
Andrew Ware
Treasurer
David Morris
Assistant secretary
Eva Sanchez
Assistant treasurer
Donald Meurer

The new slate of officers
is given on page 9

* Denotes appointed committee members

** Terry Bedient is an ex officio member on all committees. Greg Tobin is an ex officio on all committees except the Audit Committee, Compensation Committee and the Nominating Committee

■ 2016 Conference Members

NONALCOHOLIC (CLASS A) TRUSTEES

Terrance (Terry) M. Bedient, FACHE (99 Washington Ave., Suite 410, Albany, NY 12210) was elected chairman of the board in 2013, and has served as a Class A trustee and treasurer since 2008. Currently vice president of the Medical Society of New York, his career has included various executive positions, including hospital chief executive officer. He has served on a dozen nonprofit boards, including as trustee of the New York Lawyer Assistance Trust, which oversees substance abuse programs for attorneys and judges, and as treasurer of the Federation of State Physician Health Programs. Terry is a Fellow of the American College of Healthcare Executives.

Leslie Sanders Backus (301 East 55th St., Savannah, GA 31405) was elected Class A trustee in April 2015. Leslie's professional background is in volunteer leadership and fund development. She is currently chief financial officer in an outpatient substance abuse treatment facility. Leslie serves on the International Conventions/Regional Forums, Finance & Budgetary, and International Committees.

***John A. Fromson, M.D.** (Brigham and Women's Faulkner Hospital, 1153 Centre St., Boston, MA 02130) was elected Class A trustee in April 2010. He is a board certified addiction specialist. John is a vice chairman of the Dept. of Psychiatry at Brigham and Women's Hospital and Chief of Psychiatry at Brigham and Women's Faulkner Hospital, and teaches at Harvard Medical School. He is the author of many articles and lectures widely. John serves on the Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Accessibilities, Corrections and Nominating Committees.

***Michele Grinberg, J.D.** (P.O. Box 4879, Charleston, WV 25364) was elected Class A trustee in April 2010. She is a 1985 graduate of West Virginia University College of Law, where she now teaches a legal writing course as an adjunct instructor. Michele is a practicing attorney with a concentration in health policy and medical staff relations. She is co-editor of *Women and the Law*. Michele chairs the Archives Committee and serves on the Conference and Literature Committees.

The Hon. Ivan L.R. Lemelle (U.S. District Court, Eastern District of Louisiana, 500 Poydras St., Chambers C-525, New Orleans, LA 70130) was elected Class A trustee in April 2013. A graduate of Loyola University School of Law, New Orleans, Judge Lemelle has an extensive background in both state and federal law. He currently serves as a U.S. District Judge, Visiting Judge in various other federal courts, Immediate Past President of the District Judges Association for the U.S. Fifth Circuit, and lectures often at national and international forums. Ivan chairs the Public Information Committee and serves on the International and Nominating Committees. He is a member of the Grapevine Board.

Peter F. Luongo, Ph.D. (20312 Sandsfield Terrace, Germantown, MD 20876) was elected Class A trustee in April 2015. Pete's professional background is in public health services at state and local levels. He is currently executive director, Institute for Research, Education and Training in Addictions (IRETA). Pete serves on the Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Accessibilities, Public Information and Archives Committees.

David M. Morris, CPA (1060 Park Ave., Apt. #4G, New York, NY 10128) was elected Class A trustee in April 2013. Currently, David is the owner of Morris Consulting, a practice that focuses on providing financial and accounting guidance. He is retired from the position of senior vice president, JPMorgan Chase Bank. David chairs the Finance & Budgetary and Audit Committees and serves on the Archives and International Conventions/Regional Forums Committees.

ALCOHOLIC (CLASS B) TRUSTEES

Richard Boisvert (409 rue du Rhone, Terrebonne, Québec J6W 5M3) was elected Eastern Canada regional trustee in April 2014. A Panel 60 delegate from NW Québec, Richard remains active in his area and region. He is retired from the Aerospace industry. Richard chairs the Corrections Committee and serves on the Public Information, Audit and Nominating Committees. He is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

Joel Castellaw (4239 Collwood Lane, San Diego, CA 92115) was elected Pacific regional trustee in April 2014. A former Panel 60 delegate from the San Diego/Imperial Area, Joel is active in his area. A college professor, he chairs the Communication department. Joel chairs the Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Accessibilities Committee, and serves on the Literature, Conference and Compensation Committees. He is also a member of the Grapevine Board.

Joe Downey (43 Lennox St., Kingston, Ontario K7M 4S3) was elected general service trustee in April 2014, after having served as a nontrustee director on the A.A.W.S. Board. Joe was a Panel 51 delegate where he was chair of the Conference Literature Committee. He is a clinical researcher at a major university. Joe chairs the Literature Committee and serves on the Conference, International Conventions/Regional Forums, Finance & Budgetary and Compensation Committees. He is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

William (Bill) Farnsworth (716 Fifth St., Marietta, OH 45750) was elected East Central regional trustee in April 2013. A former Panel 47 delegate, Bill is active in his district with the Corrections committee. His professional background is in law enforcement and he is involved with

community projects. Bill chairs the International Conventions/Regional Forums Committee and serves on the Finance & Budgetary and International Committees. He is a member of the Grapevine Board.

Yolanda Flores (119 Saint Francis Ave., San Antonio, TX 78204) was elected Southwest regional trustee in April 2015. Yolanda was a Panel 50 delegate where she chaired the Literature Committee. She is retired from the engineering department of a telecommunications company. She is active in local A.A. group and district activities. Yolanda serves on the Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Accessibilities, Corrections and International Committees.

Scott Huyghebaert (#836, 15 Hudson Bay Trail, Kamloops, BC V2C 6S6) was elected trustee-at-large/Canada in 2015. A Panel 61 delegate, Scott currently takes meetings into a local detox and facilitates Twelfth Step weekends. He is an attorney. Scott serves on the International Conventions/Regional Forums, Corrections and International Committees.

William (Bill) Noonan (2345 Valley Mill Drive, Buford, GA 30519) was elected general service trustee in April 2013, after serving as an A.A.W.S. nontrustee director for four years. Bill, a Panel 49 delegate, is an executive in the Financial Risk Management field. Bill's love of general service developed as a result of his involvement with The International Conference of Young People in A.A. Bill chairs the Nominating and Compensation Committees and serves on the Finance & Budgetary and Corrections Committees. He is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

Chet Parker (1006 Eastern Way, Orlando, FL 32804) was elected Southeast regional trustee in April 2013. A Panel 59 delegate, he is involved in his area's Traditions Workshops. Chet is an attorney who has taught various courses at local institutions. Chet serves on the Literature, Audit and Finance & Budgetary Committees. He is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

Richard Purtell (12 Tamarack Trail, Bedford, NH 30110) was elected Northeast regional trustee in April 2015. A Panel 60 delegate, Rich is active in his district and area. He is a certified staffing professional and currently serves as a senior consultant to the Staffing Industry. Rich serves on the Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities, International Conventions/Regional Forums, and Archives Committee.

***Andrew Ware** (3214 Cummins Way, Missoula, MT 59802) was elected West Central regional trustee in April 2012. A former Panel 57 delegate, Andrew is active in his area and region. He is a uni-

versity professor and chair of the Department of Physics and Astronomy. He chairs the Conference Committee and serves on the Corrections, Nominating and Public Information Committees.

Robert (Bob) Wilcox (30 Whispering Wind Rd., Westfield, MA 01085) was elected trustee-at-large/U.S. in April 2013. Bob was a Panel 52 delegate, where he chaired the Public Information Committee. He owns an independent insurance agency. He chairs the International Committee and serves on the Conference, Compensation and Nominating Committees.

Albin Zezula (100 Connecticut Ave., Long Beach, NY 11561) was elected general service trustee in April 2013, after having served four years as a nontrustee director on the Grapevine Board. Albin is an associate publisher with a newspaper publishing company. He serves on the Nominating, Audit, Finance and Budgetary Committees, and is chair of the Grapevine Board.

Trustees elected by the General Service Board following 2016 Conference

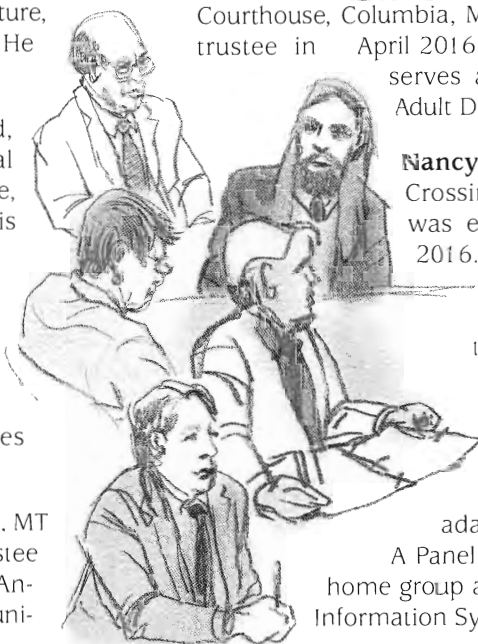
Thomas L. Ardolf (2992 Country Rd. 137, Waite Park, MN 56387) was elected West Central regional trustee in April 2016. A former Panel 50 delegate, Tom is a cofounder of Cybermation, a home-automation-focused business.

Carole Boerner (1640 Hidden Cove Lane, Billings, MT 59101) was elected general service trustee in April 2016. A Panel 59 delegate, Carole has recently served on the A.A.W.S. Board as a non-trustee director. With a background in engineering, she is currently involved in consulting and organization development.

Christine Carpenter (705 E. Walnut St., Boone County Courthouse, Columbia, MO 65201) was elected a Class A trustee in April 2016. An attorney, Christine currently serves as judge on the Boone County Adult Drug Court.

Nancy J. McCarthy (5311 Hagemann Crossing Drive, St. Louis, MO 63128) was elected Class A trustee in April 2016. Nancy has served in various positions with the Missouri Dept. of Corrections, Division of Probation and Parole, where she is now regional administrator.

Cate Wittig (301 Wildwood Park, Winnipeg, Manitoba, R3T 0E5) was elected Western Canada regional trustee in April 2016. A Panel 60 delegate, Cate is active in her home group and area. Professionally, she is an Information Systems consultant and specialist.



A.A. World Services Directors

Chet Parker, *chairperson, regional trustee*
 Carolé Boerner, *director*
 Richard Boisvert, *regional trustee*
 Beau Bush, *director*

Joe Downey, *general service trustee*
 David Noll, *director*
 Bill Noonan, *general service trustee*
 Eva Sanchez, *G.S.O. staff member*
 Greg Tobin, *G.S.O. general manager*

A.A. Grapevine Directors

Albin Zezula, *chairperson, general service trustee*
 Lynda Bergeron, *director*

Ami Brophy, *executive editor/publisher*
 Bill Farnsworth, *regional trustee*
 Paz Preciado, *director*

General Service Office Staff

Greg Tobin, *general manager*
 Clement Cann
 Mary Cumings
 Julio Espaillet
 Racy Joseph
 Mary Clare Lynch
 Tracey Ober

Clay Rittenhouse
 Eva Sanchez
 Steve Smith
 Rick Walker
 Sandra Wilson
 Jeff Wine

Grapevine Staff

Ami Brophy, *executive editor/publisher*
 Irene Donoso, *La Viña editor*

Jon Witherspoon, *senior editor*

Others Assisting the Conference (nonvoting)

Militza Alma-Noyola, *IT project assistant*
 Julie Anderson, *staff assistant*
 Kesheba Boozer, *copy room coordinator*
 Janet Bryan, *GV office mgr./executive asst.*
 Amalia Castillo, *Spanish language interpreter*
 Cindy Copeland-Woolford, *consultant, electronic voting*
 Nancy Davis, *exec. asst. to general manager*
 John DeStefano, *Spanish editor*
 Cynthia Garippa, *IT manager*
 Danielle Isaac, *staff assistant*
 Andree Lanoix, *French language interpreter*
 Fern Leclerc, *French editor*
 Oliver Lepage, *French language interpreter*
 Pamela Lewis, *staff assistant*
 Ayleen Martinez, *staff assistant*
 Donald Meurer, *C.F.O., A.A.W.S.*
 Michelle Mirza, *archivist*
 Maria Morales, *staff assistant*
 Valerie O'Neill, *hotel coordinator/onsite manager*
 Daniel Pensante, *controller, Grapevine*
 Joselin Pichardo, *GV production associate*
 Patrick Raycraft, *Spanish interpreter*
 Carlos Restrepo, *Spanish interpreter*
 Ivelisse Rivera, *staff assistant*
 Linda Samuels, *staff assistant*
 Jason Seder, *artist, Final Conference Report*
 Frank Segui, *finance assistant*
 Robert Slotterback, *controller, A.A.W.S.*
 Kevin Sunkel, *independent auditor*
 Ames Sweet, *writer*
 Rocio Taveras, *staff assistant*
 Andre Washington, *office manager*
 Eleanor Widdoes, *writer/editor, Summer Edition Box 4-5-9, Conference Report*
 Nay Williams-Wise, *Conference staff assistant*

Trustees emeriti

Leonard Blumenthal
 Ward B. Ewing, D.D.
 Gary Glynn

Area Delegates

What do panel numbers mean? Delegates to each Conference are made up of two "panels." One is even-numbered and includes those elected to start serving in an even year. The other is odd-numbered and includes those elected to start serving in an odd year. The 66th Conference includes Panel 65 (delegates now serving for their second year) and Panel 66 (new delegates).

UNITED STATES

State	Area no.	Panel	
Alabama/N.W. Florida	1	65	Jim Stone 203 Thach Ln. Meridianville, AL 35759
Alaska	2	66	Laura Hansen P.O. Box 1386 Anchor Point, AK 99556
Arizona	3	66	David (Dave) Bradford 12480 E. Placita Mirlo Tucson, AZ 85747
Arkansas	4	65	Rebecca McNeill 3109 Mossy Creek Dr. Little Rock, AZ 72211
California Southern	5	65	Scott Mulligan 1585 Turtle Creek Beaumont, CA 92223
Central	93	65	Lisa Part 14625 Kingsbury St. Mission Hills, CA 91345
Northern Coastal	6	65	Raymundo Lujano 265 N. 26th St. San Jose, CA 95116
Northern Interior	7	66	Victoria (Vikki) Ray 1450 Stabler Lane, #47 Yuba City, CA 95993
San Diego/Imperial	8	66	Jane Giatras 1374 La Mancha Place Chula Vista, CA 91910
Mid-Southern	9	66	Joseph (Joe) Carlson 3063 W. Chapman Ave., #7301 Orange, CA 92868
Colorado	10	65	Tami Reynolds 5977 S. Pierson St. Littleton, CO 80127
Connecticut	11	65	Craig Weidner 1001 Ashford Circle Brewster, NY 10509
Delaware	12	66	Susan Merrit Riedy 4 Gilmore Lane Elkton, MD 21921
District of Columbia	13	65	Amy Carberg 1716 Swann St., NW Washington, DC 20009
Florida North	14	65	Glenn Walters 7130 Hartman St. Cocoa, FL 32927
S. Florida/Bahamas/ V.I./Antigua/St. Maarten/ Cayman Islands	15	65	Graham Gobie 12305 SW 90th Ave. Miami, FL 33176
Georgia	16	66	Ernie Murphy P.O. Box 588 Rincon, GA 31326
Hawaii	17	65	Cheryl Nesler 68-1025 Kaniku Dr., #619 Kamuela, HI 96743
Idaho	18	66	Barry Smith 870 White Barn Kuna, ID 83634

<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>		<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>	
Illinois				Montana	40	65	Libbie Lapp 440 Creston Rd. Kalispell, MT 59901
<i>Chicago</i>	19	65	Thomas (Tommy) Babuscio 29 169th St. Hammond, IN 46324	Nebraska	41	66	Trent Geistlinger Box 265 Hallam, NE 68368
<i>Northern</i>	20	66	Kelly Lambert 1638 Gilberto St. Glendale Heights, IL 60139	Nevada	42	65	Michael Miller 2409 Brockton Way Henderson, NV 89074
<i>Southern</i>	21	65	Paula Elliot 8232 Jefferson Rd. Freeburg, IL 62243	New Hampshire	43	66	Dale Randolph 37 Plaistow Rd., #7-136 Plaistow, NH 03865
Indiana				New Jersey			
<i>Northern</i>	22	65	Irene Martin 2309 Barbara Jean Dr. Schererville, IN 46375	<i>Northern</i>	44	65	Jay Eckstein 1269 W. Laurelton Pkwy Teaneck, NJ 07666
<i>Southern</i>	23	66	Charlotte Crabtree 9502 Behner Lane Indianapolis, IN 46250	<i>Southern</i>	45	66	Andrew Levecchia 1218 Elm Ave. Haddon Twp., NJ 08107
Iowa	24	65	Tom Clyce 3922 74th St. Urbandale, IA 50322	New Mexico	46	66	James (Jim) Hollen 704 Spyglass Dr. Carlsbad, NM 88220
Kansas	25	66	Sue Cunningham Neill 1662 SW Withdean Rd. Topeka, KS 66611	New York			
Kentucky	26	66	Kenneth (Kenny) Brown 309 Chaplin Rd. Bloomfield, KY 40008	<i>Central</i>	47	65	Vicky Shaw 45091 Olney Rd. Redwood, NY 13679
Louisiana	27	65	Terry Ernst 6000 Canal Blvd. New Orleans, LA 70124	<i>Hudson/Mohawk/ Berkshire</i>	48	66	Willis (Bill) Walker 356 Joys Lane Hurley, NY 12443
Maine	28	66	Gene Wilson 42 Ryder Rd. Farmingdale, ME 04344	<i>Southeast</i>	49	65	James (Jim) Wright 1470 East Ave., #4G Bronx, NY 10462
Maryland	29	66	Linda Jopling 912 Schooner Circle Annapolis, MD 21401	<i>Western</i>	50	66	Walter (Wally) Eick 3324 Quacker Rd. Gasport, NY 14067
Massachusetts				North Carolina	51	65	Rachel Moysan 305 S. Rowan Ave. Spencer, NC 28159
<i>Eastern</i>	30	65	Michelle Pattridge 40 High St. Natick, MA 01760	North Dakota	52	65	Thomas (Tom) Harlow 10 Vail Circle Grand Forks, ND 58201
<i>Western</i>	31	65	Mark Naegeli 541 Thompsonville Rd. Suffield, CT 06078	Ohio			
Michigan				<i>Central/Southeast</i>	53	65	Kristi Hewitt 5 S. High St. Glouster, OH 45732
<i>Central</i>	32	65	Kirk Faupel Box 283 Saline, MI 48176	<i>Northeast</i>	54	65	Calvin Leonard 3571 Riedham Rd. Shaker Heights, OH 44120
<i>Southeast</i>	33	65	Betty Morton 930 John R Rd., #2516 Troy, MI 48083	<i>Northwest</i>	55	66	John Carter 3225 N. Eastmoreland Oregon, OH 43616
<i>Western</i>	34	66	James (Jim) Gordier 830 West Hanover St. Marshall, MI 49068	<i>Southwest</i>	56	66	Laura Goostree 6059 Hill Ave. Miamisburg, OH 45342
Minnesota				Oklahoma	57	65	Stephanie Bills 15904 Sheffield Blvd. Edmond, OK 73013
<i>Northern</i>	35	66	Kelly Dempski 13738 277th Ave. North Zimmerman, MN 55398	Oregon	58	66	Reilly Kalles Box 758 Winston, OR 97496
<i>Southern</i>	36	65	Lisa Dawn Gentry 4325 Portland Ave. Minneapolis, MN 55407	Pennsylvania			
Mississippi	37	66	Harry (Bub) Branton 131 Lake Rd. Leland, MS 38756	<i>Eastern</i>	59	65	Patricia (Pat) Fallon 312 Hamel Ave. Glenside, PA 19038
Missouri				<i>Western</i>	60	65	George Kulakowski 303 Buggy Rd. Punxsutawney, PA 15767
<i>Eastern</i>	38	65	Marge Del Carlo 3126 Portis Ave. St. Louis, MO 63116				
<i>Western</i>	39	65	Dave Fite 8281 E. Farm Rd., 146 Rogersville, MO 65742				

<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>	
Rhode Island	61	66	Kenneth (Kenny) Demarest 114 Federal Way, #301 Johnston, RI 02919
South Carolina	62	66	Jim Struchen 507 Greenbriar Dr. North Augusta, SC 29860
South Dakota	63	66	Robert (Rob) Munsell 1104 Spearfish Mountain Lane Spearfish, SD 57783
Tennessee	64	66	Anthony (Tony) Shelby 925 Sheridan St. Memphis, TN 38107
Texas <i>Northeast</i>	65	65	Tom Misteli 652 Harter Rd. Dallas, TX 75218-2114
<i>Northwest</i>	66	66	David (Dave) Houston 2821 W. Dengar Midland, TX 79705
<i>Southeast</i>	67	65	Melissa Redd 21484 Tower Guard Dr. Kingwood, TX 77339
<i>Southwest</i>	68	66	Denise Thorn 117 Haliimaile Lane Bastrop, TX 78602
Utah	69	65	Renae Harkness 2286 Willow View Way Sandy, UT 84092
Vermont	70	66	Robert (Bob) Rowe 62 Summit Circle Shelburne, VT 05482
Virginia	71	65	Christine (Chris) Wells 2251 Eisenhower Ave., #418 Alexandria, VA 22314
Washington <i>State East</i>	92	66	Scott Roush 84 Airstrip Rd. Libby, MT 59923
<i>Western</i>	72	65	Darren Flint 1206 N. Pine St. Tacoma, WA 98406
West Virginia	73	65	Barbara (Barb) Colley 3939 Highland Ave. Shadyside, OH 43947
Wisconsin <i>No. WI/ Up. Pen. MI</i>	74	66	Derek Tait 30659 W. Third Creek Row Paradise, MI 49768
<i>Southern</i>	75	65	Peter (Drew) Armstrong 1660 Alvin Ln. Brookfield, WI 53045
Wyoming	76	66	Michelle Schmidt 5138 Mountain Way Casper, WY 82601
Puerto Rico	77	66	Gilberto Vence Urb Golden Gate A#3 Calle Ebano Guaynabo, PR 00968-3405

CANADA

<u>Province</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>	
Alberta/N.W.T.	78	66	Larry Mumby 28 Maligne Dr. Devon, AB T9G1P8
B.C./Yukon	79	65	Jennifer Kuntz 92 Wickstrom Rd. Whitehorse, YT Y1A GN2
Manitoba	80	66	Ian Rabb 68 Yale Ave. Winnipeg, MB R3M 0L6
New Brunswick/P.E.I.	81	66	Michael Dunn 442 Main St., #21 Shediac, NB E4P ZG7
Nova Scotia/ Newfoundland/Labrador	82	65	Boyd Bragg 1-2430 Topsail Rd. Conception Bay South, NL A1W 5R4
Ontario <i>Eastern</i>	83	65	Joyce Saunders 133 Wynford Dr., Suite 803 Toronto, ON M3C 0J5
<i>Northeast</i>	84	66	Timothy (Jim) Cullen 252 Ash St. Sudbury, ON P3C 1Z8
<i>Northwest</i>	85	65	Jennie Herd 450 Laurensen Ln., #611 Kenora, ON P9N 4C9
<i>Western</i>	86	66	Fredy Mendoza 34 Newton St. Barrie, ON L4M 3N3
Québec <i>Southwest</i>	87	66	Thomas Green 7534, rue Fabre Montreal, QC H2E 2B5
<i>Southeast</i>	88	65	Michel Bergeron 234 A-La Rochelle Asbestos, QC J1T 3M7
<i>Northeast</i>	89	65	Diane Perron 497 Baron Baie-Comeau, QC G5C 3W4
<i>Northwest</i>	90	66	Michael Cyr 6668 rue Drolet Orleans, ON K1C 1K1
Saskatchewan	91	65	Christopher Stoppler 777 Montague St. Regina, SK S4T 3H1

